

GAMBIT

Improve Your Attacking Chess

Simon Williams

250 puzzle positions to train your king-hunting skills





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Hola a todos!

We are a group of chess fans who are producing new chess material. We have members from all around the world, belonging to different cultures and speaking different languages, all of us joined by our common love for chess! We hope you will enjoy our work!

Somos un grupo de fanáticos del ajedrez, que estamos tratando de producir nuevo material como este, desarrollando diferentes proyectos e ideas. Tenemos miembros de diferentes partes del mundo, provenientes de diferentes culturas, hablando diferentes lenguas, unidos por nuestra pasión por el ajedrez!. Esperamos que disfruten de esta muestra de nuestro trabajo!.

If you are interested in joining us, or send any comments drop us an email at: caissa_lovers@yahoo.com.
Si alguien estuviese interesado en unirse al grupo nos pueden escribir a: caissa_lovers@yahoo.com.

Best regards!!
Saludos!

Caissa Lovers

Improve Your Attacking Chess

Simon Williams

GAMBIT

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Contents

Symbols	4
Introduction	5
1 Attacking the King Caught in the Centre	8
Solutions	19
2 Attacking the Castled King	30
Solutions	44
3 Strike in the Centre	58
Solutions	69
4 Time is Everything!	84
Solutions	96
5 Attacking on Opposite Sides	107
Solutions	119
6 Expect the Unexpected	134
Solutions	146
Index of Players	158

Symbols

+	check	Wcht	world team championship
++	double check	Ech	European championship
#	checkmate	Echt	European team championship
!!	brilliant move	ECC	European Clubs Cup
!	good move	Ct	candidates event
!?	interesting move	IZ	interzonal event
?!	dubious move	Z	zonal event
?	bad move	OL	olympiad
??	blunder	jr	junior event
+—	White is winning	wom	women's event
±	White is much better	rpd	rapidplay game
±	White is slightly better	tt	team tournament
=	equal position	sim	game from simultaneous display
∓	Black is slightly better	corr.	correspondence game
∓	Black is much better	1-0	the game ends in a win for White
—+	Black is winning	1/2-1/2	the game ends in a draw
Ch	championship	0-1	the game ends in a win for Black
Cht	team championship	(<i>n</i>)	<i>n</i> th match game
Wch	world championship	(<i>D</i>)	see next diagram

Introduction

Chess is a strange and compelling game, a game that anyone can play, from any walk of life. Players' styles vary greatly, and this variety enriches chess, making it more attractive and colourful. These differing styles can range from the ultra-solid to the bizarrely wild, with most players floating about in the middle somewhere. But what is a better joy in chess than to watch a great attacking game where one tempo will change the outcome from lost to won? Attacking is at the soul of chess after all; let's remember that the aim of chess is to give checkmate! And how better to go about this than by attacking?

It seems that in modern-day chess most literature and database material are confined to the discussion of openings. Openings are certainly important, but they are not *that* important. There is no point in a player being able to get an advantage from the opening only to throw it away because he/she has no idea of what to do next. In my opinion it is more important to understand tactics and the power of positional strategies than to have a massive opening repertoire. The only way to improve tactical skills is by practising them. This book is aimed to sharpen up the reader's attacking skills through the use of exercises.

The puzzles in this book vary from the easy to the very difficult, with motifs ranging from common to bizarre. Chess-players of all standards should find something to interest and challenge them. By trying to solve these puzzles the reader will test his tactical skills and hopefully learn some new skills on the way. I have included in this book some of the most beautiful wins that I have witnessed. The reader can also try to guess the moves of great players such as Kasparov, Tal, Alekhine, Shirov, etc., which will certainly be challenging!

This book is divided into six chapters. These six chapters are all based around different aspects of attacking chess. I have arranged the puzzles so that they become progressively harder as the chapter develops. Of course this is rather a subjective matter but most readers will find the puzzles at the start of the chapter a lot easier than the puzzles towards the end. In most cases I have not given stipulations of the type 'checkmate in five moves' because in a real game it is rather unlikely that your opponent will be so generous as to tell you that you can win in 'x' moves. I have given clues to some of the puzzles and in many cases the first move is obvious; but in each puzzle it is important to analyse the chosen move as deeply as possible – ideally you should follow through until you see a win (or in

some cases a draw). You may if you wish set up the position on a board if you find this helpful. In some chapters I have given a model game as a taster and some general themes that occur regularly within that given sphere.

Basic Ideas

I will now briefly summarize some important concepts to be borne in mind when attacking.

1) Attacking chess will normally involve tactics at some point. Tactics by their nature usually involve checks or captures. So the most important things to watch for are checks and captures – this is simple common sense really. If a player on every move starts by analysing all checks and captures that are available to him, he will be more aware of any tactics that the position offers. Checks and captures have a forcing nature so they tend to lead to variations that are forcing. By the process of elimination a player can decide whether a line is viable, or in many cases whether it wins the game or loses the game.

Rule 1: Always analyse checks and captures first.

2) Successful attacks do not start from thin air; they are successful for a reason. A successful attack works because of certain features in the position; for example, an exposed king, open h-file, active pieces, etc. These are factors for which a player should always be searching. Most successful attacks occur from the build-up of small positional advantages. There is no point in a lone white knight attacking a black king that is guarded by most of its army. A rule of thumb is that three pieces are normally needed for a successful attack, but of course there are exceptions to this. Three pieces attacking a poorly guarded king will normally triumph.

Rule 2: Only attack when there is a chance of success. This can depend upon a number of factors, the most obvious being when a player has more or better placed pieces than his opponent. In other words **timing is crucial**.

3) Calculation is the key. Good calculation will give good results. People calculate in different ways; if you are missing lots of tactics look at the way in which you are calculating. One simple way to calculate in a complicated position is to do the following. Take all the moves which are critical (maybe checks and captures) and analyse them one by one. You will either find a decent line (if the

position lets you!) or by elimination you will arrive at an 'only move'. Do not swap half way through calculating from one line to another.

Rule 3: When starting an attack, calculate the possible variations as deeply as possible.

Most of the above rules are common sense but it is amazing how often players, even top players, ignore these logical rules.

1 Attacking the King Caught in the Centre

The most important piece in chess is the king; if a player gets checkmated the game is over. This is why beginners are always taught to castle as quickly as possible so their king can reach safety. A king stranded in the middle of the board is an easy target to attack, normally because it has little or no pawn-cover. The examples given within this chapter show cases when one side has left its king in the middle, thereby leaving it open to attack. Often in such cases the attack needs to be very aggressively pursued before the opponent has time to get his king to safety, and this often involves sacrifices to open up the centre. In general it is worth keeping the initiative even at the cost of material.

In the following game we see a world-class player ignoring some basic rules and getting punished for his mistakes.

Svidler – Bareev

Wijk aan Zee 2004

1 e4 e6 2 d4 d5 3 ♘c3 dxe4 4 ♘xe4 ♘d7

This variation has a reputation as being very solid for Black, but as this

game shows it requires precise play from Black to come near to equalizing.

5 ♖f3 ♗gf6 6 ♙d3 c5!?

Black strikes out in the centre. This is a slightly risky policy as the black king is still a couple of moves away from castling.

7 0-0 ♘xe4 8 ♙xe4 ♗f6 9 ♙g5

White's army is now fully harmonized. Therefore following the second rule mentioned in the introduction he can start looking for attacking possibilities.

9...cxd4 10 ♘xd4 h6?!

A dubious decision. Black should be trying to castle as quickly as possible. 10...♙e7 is a better option, when White's edge is minimal.

11 ♙xf6 ♗xf6 12 ♗d3!

White spots an opportunity to attack. The annoying threat is 13 ♗b5+.

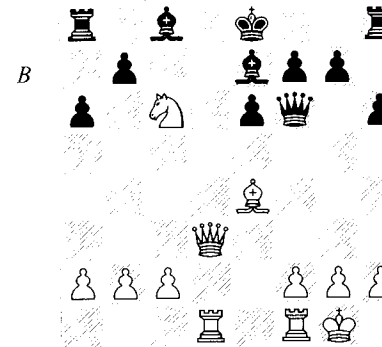
12...a6 13 ♗ad1 ♙e7 14 ♘c6! (D)

White must act quickly; otherwise Black will have time to castle.

14...e5?!

Black's position is undesirable, but the king had to be tucked away within the next couple of moves.

14...0-0 15 ♘xe7+ ♗xe7 16 ♗d6 gives White a very pleasant positional



edge, but this is preferable to what happened in the game.

15 ♘xe7 ♗xe7 16 f4!

Opening up the centre to attack the black king.

16...exf4?

Black had to castle! 16...0-0 17 fxe5 ♗xe5 18 ♗d5 ±.

17 ♙xb7!

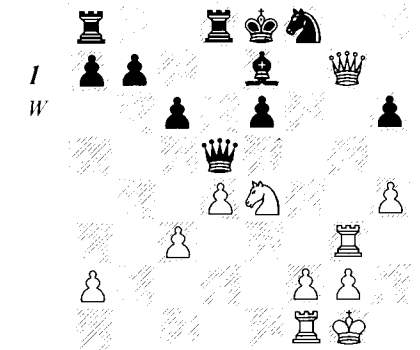
This capture finishes off the game.

1-0

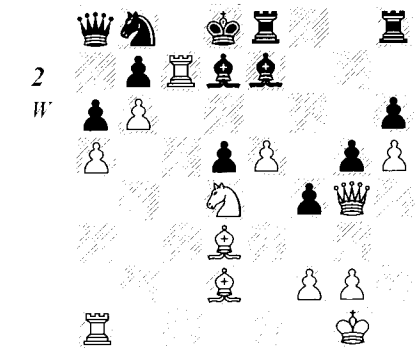
If 17...♙xb7, then 18 ♗fe1; or if 17...♗xb7 then 18 ♗d8#.

It is worth noting how White only attacked in this game when he was fully coordinated, and also how he opened lines towards the black king with 16 f4!.

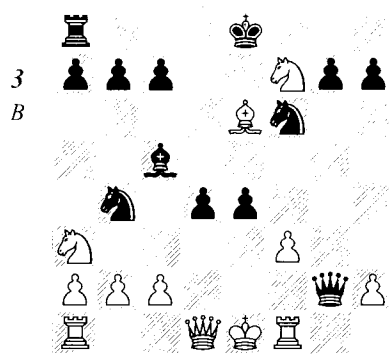
Puzzles



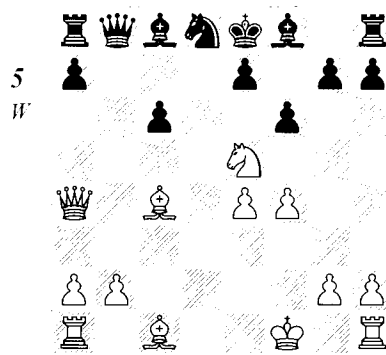
White has a dangerous initiative with three pieces attacking the black king. How can White force checkmate?



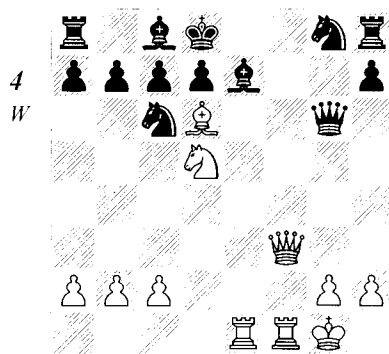
Black clearly has a dodgy position here; his queen is looking lost on a8 while the rest of Black's army is also doing very little. How can White force checkmate?



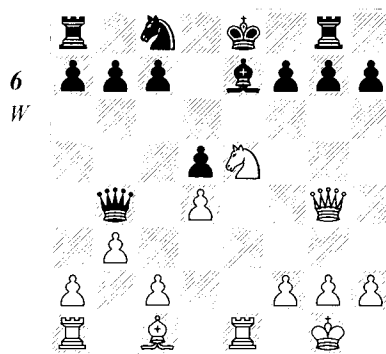
White's king is lacking squares and has no escape routes, so it is not surprising that Black can win with the use of a small combination. What did Black play here to force a won position?



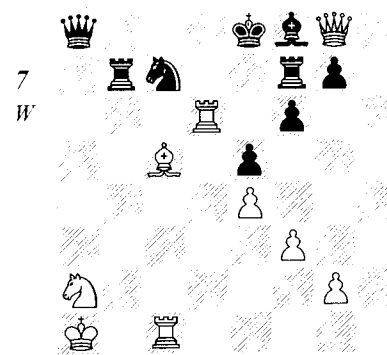
In this game Black seems to have forgotten that it is sometimes useful to develop pieces. How can White force checkmate?



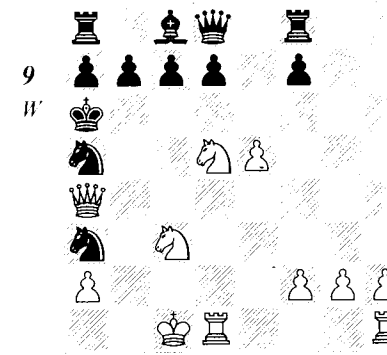
Black is lagging behind in development with a very exposed king, while White's pieces are ideally placed. It is therefore not surprising that White can force checkmate in two moves. How does White go about this?



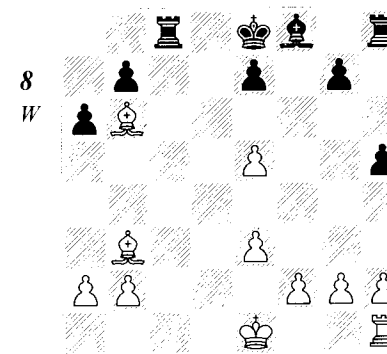
With the open e-file, well-placed knight on e5 and an actively placed queen, White is looking for the kill. What was the nice tactic that White found?



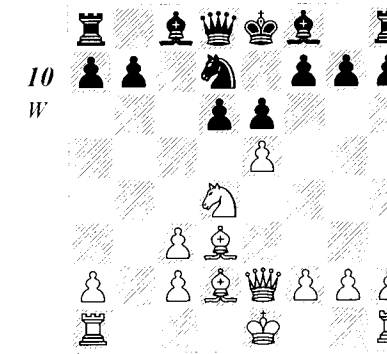
An unexpected move from White here would have forced Black to resign. What is that move?



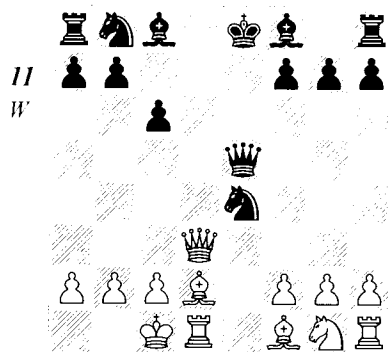
Black's king has been wandering the board in a rather disorderly fashion. How did White neatly punish Black for this?



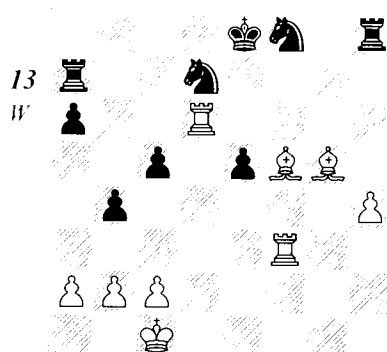
Dangerous tactics can occur at any point in the game, as shown in this example. Black's king is stuck in the centre while he is yet to develop his kingside pieces. What should White play?



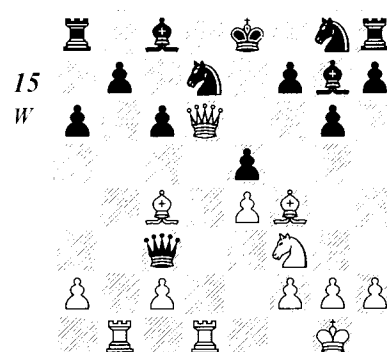
Black has not played the opening well. How did White break through?



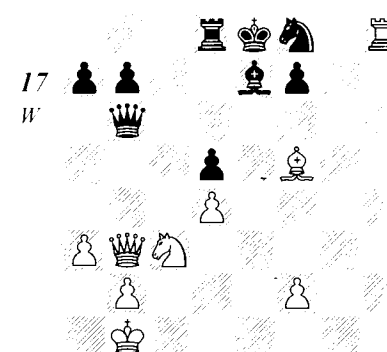
The main factor that stands out in this position is the open d-file. White already has his queen and rook lined up on it, a dangerous sign for Black. How can White force checkmate?



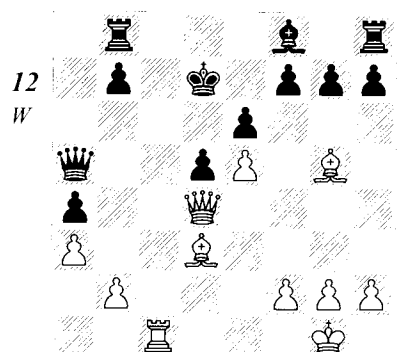
White is clearly in charge, mainly due to his two bishops which are suffocating the black king. What is White's quickest win?



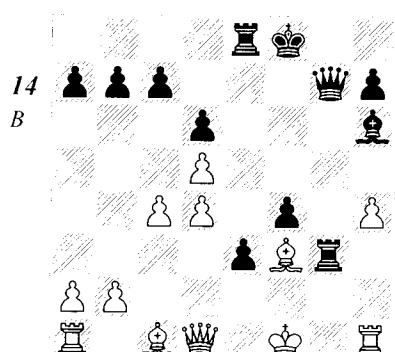
With the open d-file, well placed queen, and active bishop on c4 it is no wonder that White can checkmate the black king. What should White play?



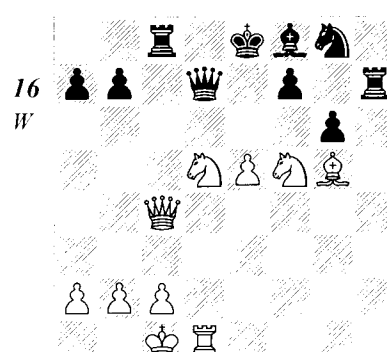
Black's king is in real danger, stuck in the middle of the board with no escape squares. What is the quickest way that White can win?



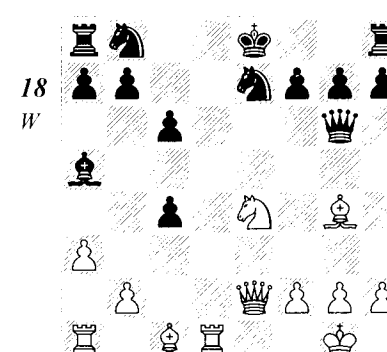
Black's king is obviously in trouble, walking around in no man's land. White has two ways to win; can you spot either of these wins?



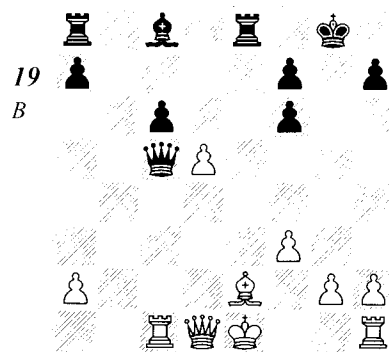
Black has obviously gained a nice initiative and would love to get his queen involved in the game. How did he make a route for his queen with a clever move?



Black's king is walking along a tightrope. How did White pull the rope down?

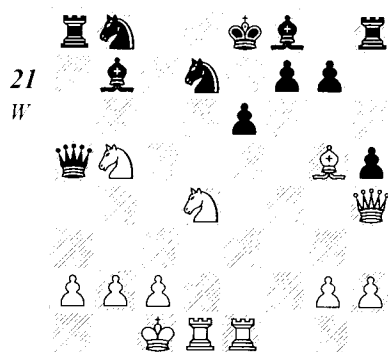


When a player has his king stuck in the centre, it needs to be attacked before it has time to escape. White found an aggressive move here that won on the spot. What was it?



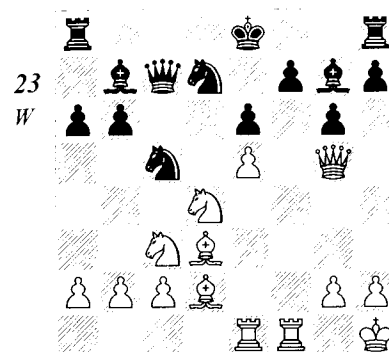
19
B

The main difference between Black and White here is the positioning of their respective kings. What should Black play?



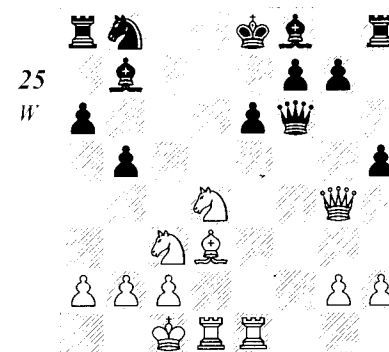
21
W

White's pieces are well positioned for the final strike, while Black is still a long way from getting castled. What should White play?



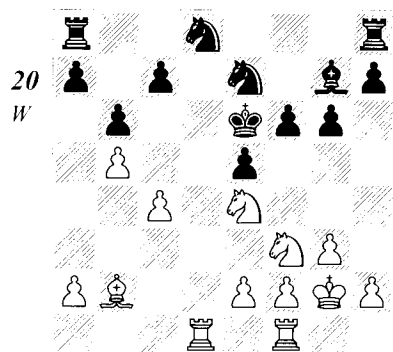
23
W

Black's king is in the centre and there are two major weaknesses in his position, the d6-square and the f7-square. How can White capitalize on this?



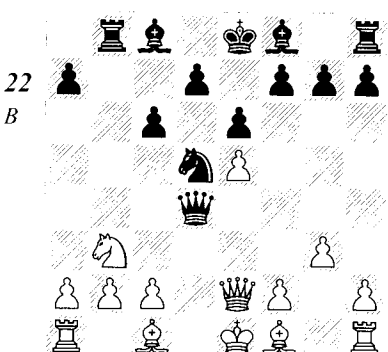
25
W

Black's king is still lazing around in the centre of the board, and Black is also behind in development. How should White exploit these factors?



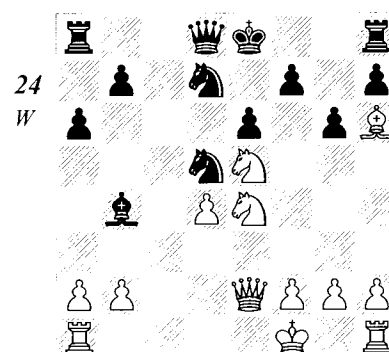
20
W

Black has placed his king in the middle of the board, thinking that it will be safe there now that the queens have been exchanged. Unfortunately for Black his judgement was erroneous. What should White play?



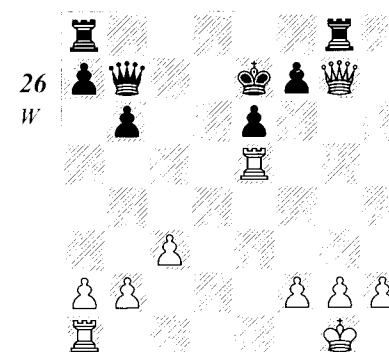
22
B

White has not played the opening well and is behind in development. Meanwhile, Black has active centralized pieces. How did Black use these factors to his advantage?



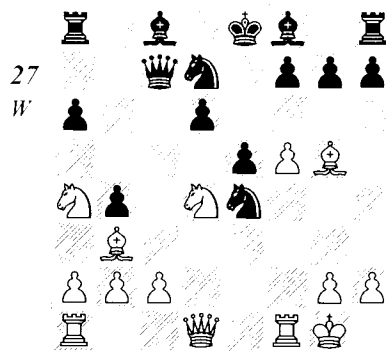
24
W

The white pieces are all very actively placed. What should White play?

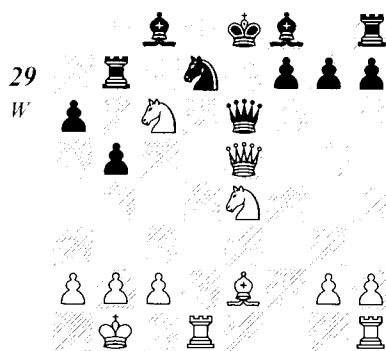


26
W

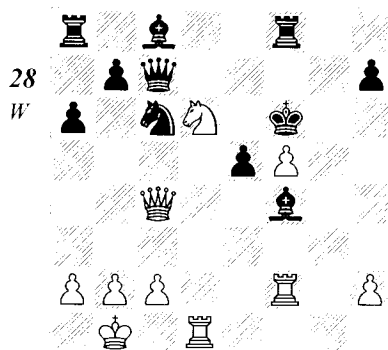
White seems to be in trouble since if the queen moves away from the g-file then Black will play 22...♙xg2#, but White had a nasty surprise in store for Black. What should White play?



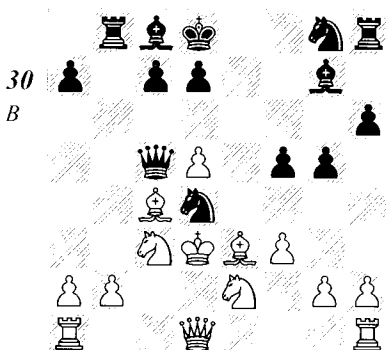
Black is still a couple of moves away from castling and White can exploit this by starting a decisive attack. How?



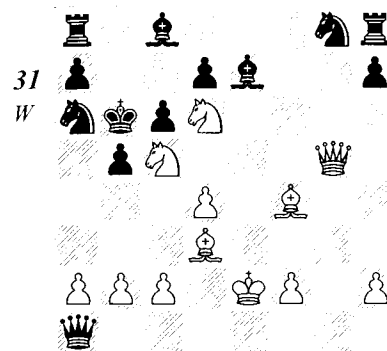
Black's pieces have been fumbling around since the start of the game. How can White force the win?



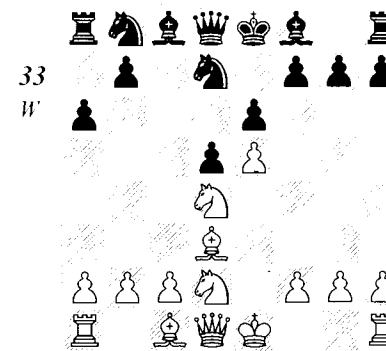
Black has just played 22...♖h6-f4, which was brutally punished. If White can somehow infiltrate Black's position with his queen then the game will be over. How did White do this?



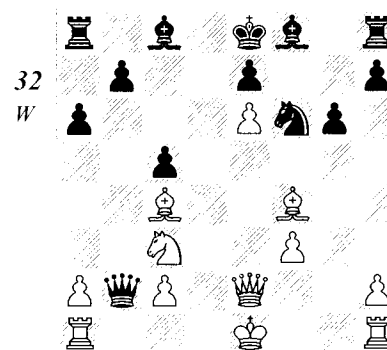
White's king is trying to get involved in the action, a very risky policy in the opening. Yet White is threatening to win the black knight on d4. What is Black's best move in this position?



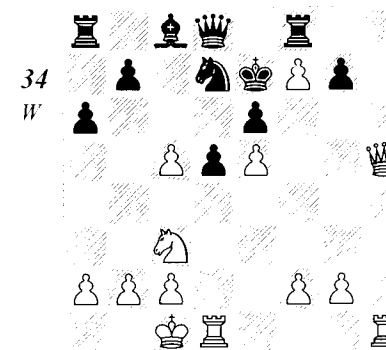
Black's king has been playing Russian Roulette for a while and now it is time to pay the price. How can White force checkmate?



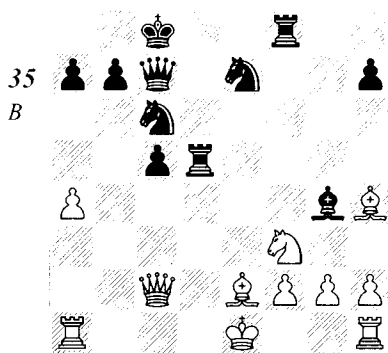
White is ahead in development with a dangerous pawn on e5. White tried to exploit these factors with the move 8 ♖xe6. Analyse this move and try to find the best defence for Black. After doing this, assess who is better.



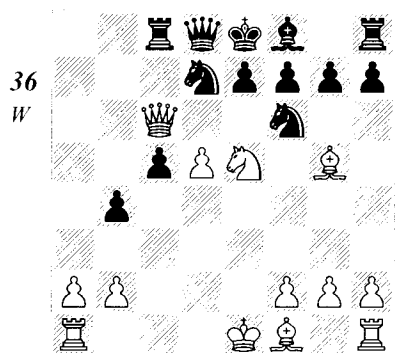
White's e6-pawn is suffocating Black's position. How did White violently finish Black off?



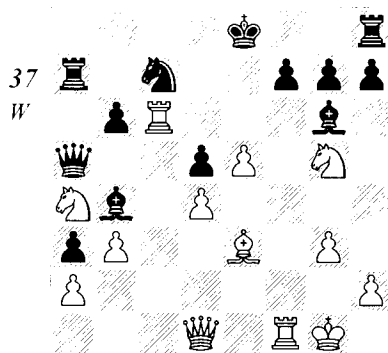
Black's king is looking rather sorry for itself, stuck in the middle of the board without any right to castle. White needs to get more pieces attacking it to put it in serious danger. How did White do this?



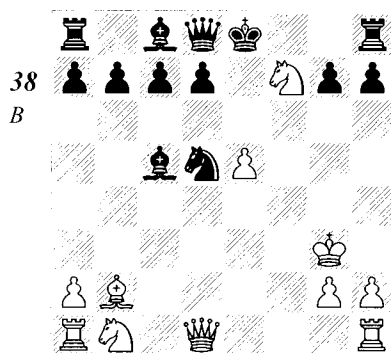
As Bob Marley once sang, “You got to strike the hammer while the iron is hot”; and those lyrics are relevant to this position. If White can castle, his king will be safe. What should Black play, to put a stop to White’s plans?



Black is struggling to find any coordination in his camp. How did White use this factor to hammer the nail in Black’s coffin?



If Black is given time, then he will be able to castle, and his position will not be too bad. As usual in such situations, White must act fast and strike while he still has the chance. What should White play?



If Black moves his queen, then White will capture the strong black knight on d5. What is Black’s best move?

Solutions

1) Korchnoi – Petersons

USSR Ch (Kiev) 1964/5

32 ♖xe7+! 1-0

This attractive move creates a picturesque position. Black resigned in view of 32...♙xe7 33 ♖g7+ ♙e8 34 ♜f6#.

2) Nimzowitsch – Håkansson

Kristianstad 1922

27 ♖xd7+!

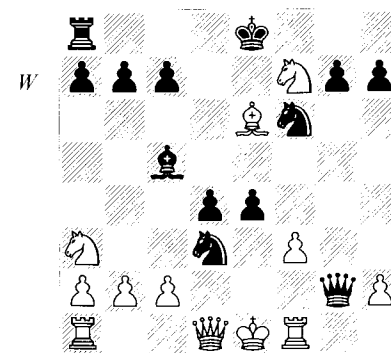
This simple combination highlights just how cramped Black’s position is.

27...♜xd7 28 ♜e6# (1-0)

3) Barnes – Morphy

London 1858

16...♜d3+! (D)



Making room for the bishop to move to b4 with check.

17 ♖xd3

An admission of defeat but White’s other option was worse: 17 cxd3 ♙b4+ 18 ♖d2 ♖xd2#.

17...exd3 18 0-0-0 ♙xa3 19 ♙b3 d2+

Black has a winning position and White resigned on move 24.

4) Shirov – Lapinski

Daugavpils 1990

16 ♖f8+!

Or 16 ♙xc7+ ♙e8 17 ♖f8#.

16...♙xf8

16...♖e8 17 ♙xc7#. Black’s only developed piece is his knight on c6! An embarrassing position.

17 ♙xc7# (1-0)

5) Suba – Sax

Hastings 1983/4

16 ♙f7+! 1-0

Black resigned because White is able to force mate in two more moves: 16...♜xf7 17 ♖xc6+ ♙d7 (17...♙d8 18 ♜xf7#) 18 ♖xd7#.

6) Azpiri – Castellanos

corr. 1993

16 ♖d7+! 1-0

Black resigned rather than continue 16...♙f8 17 ♖d8+! ♙xd8 18 ♜d7#.

7) Korchnoi – Gheorghiu

London 1980

47 ♜d7!

Exploiting the pin on Black’s f8-bishop. Korchnoi instead played 47 ♜c6? and the game was later drawn.

47...♙xd7

47...♜xd7 47 ♖xf8#.

48 ♖xf7+

White wins the whole house.

8) Sammour Hasbun – Maldonado

Connecticut (Foxwoods Open) 2003

24 e6! ♖c6

24...♖c1+ 25 ♖e2 ♖xh1 26 ♔a4# shows just what bishops are capable of doing!

25 ♔a4

White is easily winning.

9) I. Zaitsev – Storoshenko

corr. 1971

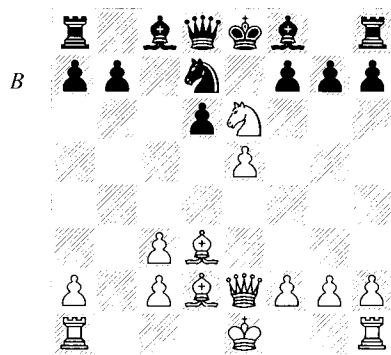
26 ♖b5+! ♜xb5 27 ♜b4+ ♖b6 28 ♜a4# (1-0)

A beautiful final position!

10) Kasparov – West

USSR – Australia (telex) 1977

11 ♜xe6! (D)



Devastating.

11...♖b6

11...fxe6 12 ♖h5+ g6 (12...♖e7 13 ♔g5+ ♜f6 14 exf6+ gxf6 15 ♔xf6+ ♖xf6 16 ♖h4+ ♜f7 17 ♖xd8 +-) 13 ♔xg6+ hxg6 14 ♖xg6+ ♖e7 15 ♔g5+ ♜f6 16 ♖xf6+ +-.

12 ♜c7+! 1-0

Black resigned as he will lose his queen or rook; for example, 12...♖xc7 (12...♖d8 13 ♜xa8 +-) 13 exd6+ ♖d8 14 dxc7+ +-.

11) Réti – Tartakower

Vienna (friendly game) 1910

9 ♖d8+!

This move enables White to give a devastating double check.

9...♖xd8 10 ♔g5++ ♜c7

10...♖e8 11 ♖d8#.

11 ♔d8# (1-0)

12) Dvoretzky – Zilbershtein

Moscow 1966

21 ♖a7!

This is the quickest way to win, and the most attractive-looking. 21 ♔d2! also wins, when the black queen will have to allow 22 ♔b5+ next move, which is the end.

21...♖xa7

Otherwise Black loses his queen or 22 ♔b5 will be checkmate anyway.

22 ♔b5# (1-0)

13) Short – Seirawan

Lucerne Wch 1989

32 ♖e6+!

White's rooks are also pretty useful!

32...♜f7

32...♜xe6 33 ♔g6# would have put an end to Black's suffering.

33 ♖e7+ ♜g8 34 ♖g3 1-0

Black resigned since mate is imminent.

14) Fedorov – Shirov

Polanica Zdroj 2000

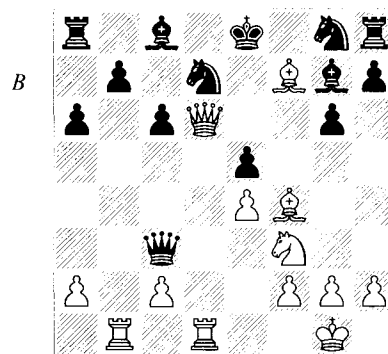
23...♖g2! 0-1

This vacates the g3-square for the black queen. White resigned since if he does not capture the rook then either 24...♖g3 or 24...♖f2+ followed by 25...♖g3 will be fatal for White, while 24 ♔xg2 loses to 24...e2+ 25 ♖xe2 ♖xe2 26 ♖xe2 ♖xg2+.

15) Tal – Tringov

Amsterdam IZ 1964

15 ♔xf7+! (D)



f7 is often a weak square when Black has failed to castle, and this is no exception. Black gets mated on the light squares.

15...♜xf7 16 ♜g5+ ♜e8 17 ♖e6+ 1-0

White mates in two more moves: 17...♜d8 18 ♜f7+ ♜c7 19 ♖d6#.

16) Ruiz – M. Romero

corr. 1991

1 ♜c7+! ♖xc7

1...♖xc7 2 ♖xc7 ♖xc7 3 ♔d8#.

2 ♔xd7 ♖xc4 3 ♔d8# (1-0)

17) Liogky – Efimov

Asti 1994

30 ♜xd5!

The knight wants to have a piece of the action.

30...♖a5

Others:

a) 30...♖xb3 31 ♜c7#.

b) 30...♖c6 is the best attempt at a defence, but 31 ♜xe7 ♜xe7 32 ♖e3+ ♜e6 (32...♜d6 33 ♖e5#) 33 ♔xe6 ♖xe6 (after 33...fxe6 34 ♖g5+ +- the black rook drops) 34 ♖xe6+ fxe6 35 ♖xd8 ♜xd8 +- is an elementary win for White.

31 ♖b5+! 1-0

Black will either lose his queen or his king.

18) Petroff – Szymanski

Warsaw 1853

15 ♔f5!

Black now loses his queen or gets mated. White could have also won with 15 ♔h5! ♖e6 16 ♔xf7+! ♖xf7 (16...♜xf7 17 ♜g5+) 17 ♜d6+.

15...♜xf5

15...♖xf5 16 ♜d6+ +-.

16 ♜f6++ ♜f8 17 ♖e8# (1-0)

19) Teller – Tartakower

Hastings 1926/7

17...♖xe2+!

White's king will never find a home now.

18 ♜xe2

18 ♖xe2 ♗xc1+ –+.

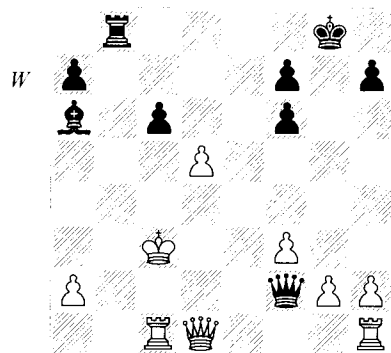
18...♙a6+

All of a sudden the remaining black pieces all spring to life.

19 ♖d2

19 ♖e1 ♗e3+ and mate next move.

19...♗f2+ 20 ♖c3 ♖b8! (D)



21...♗b2# is the idea.

21 ♖b1 ♗c5+ 22 ♖d2 ♗d4+ 23 ♖c2

Others:

a) 23 ♖e1 ♗e8+.

b) 23 ♖c1 ♗c3+ 24 ♗c2 ♗e3+ 25 ♖d1 (25 ♗d2 ♖xb1+ 26 ♖xb1 ♗xd2) 25...♙e2+! 26 ♖e1 ♙d3+ –+.

23...♗c4+ 24 ♖d2 ♗d3+ 0-1

20) Ždanovs – Ionin corr. 1991-3

17 ♙xe5!

Black's king is still in mortal danger, as this move shows.

17...♖c8

Admitting defeat, but capturing the bishop also leads to mate; for example, 17...fxe5 18 ♙fg5+ ♖f5 19 h3!

(the idea is 20 g4+ and 21 e3#) 19...h5 20 ♖f3! and Black cannot stop 21 g4+, mating.

18 ♙eg5+! 1-0

One possible line is 18...♖f5 19 g4+! ♖xg4 20 ♙d4+ ♖h5 21 ♙h4#.

21) Ljiljak – Goddard corr. 1963

17 ♙xe6!

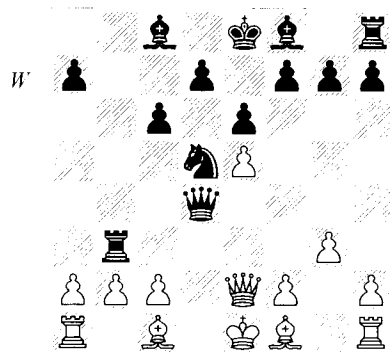
Thematic in such positions; White strikes right through the centre.

17...fxe6 18 ♖xe6+ ♖f7 19 ♗c4! 1-0

Black resigned in view of the upcoming double check; for example, 19...♗xa2 20 ♖f6++! ♖e8 (20...♖e7 21 ♖a6+ –+) 21 ♙c7+ ♖d8 22 ♖xf8#.

22) Anand – Vaisser Paris rpd 1994

12...♖xb3! (D)



Removing White's only active piece and quickly developing an unstoppable initiative.

13 axb3 ♙b4+ 14 ♙d2

14 c3 ♙xc3 15 bxc3 ♙xc3+ 16 ♙d2 ♙xd2+ 17 ♗xd2 ♗xa1+ –+.

14...♙xd2+ 15 ♗xd2 ♗e4+ 16 ♗e2 ♗xh1 –+

Black went on to win on move 30.

23) Gongora – B. Fernandez Havana 1996

1 ♙db5!

A standard idea in many Sicilian positions. White sacrifices a knight to infiltrate into the heart of Black's position.

1...axb5 2 ♙xb5 ♗d8

2...♗c6 3 ♙d6+ ♖f8 4 ♖xf7+ ♖g8 5 ♖xg7+! ♖xg7 6 ♗e7+ ♖g8 7 ♗f7#.

3 ♙d6+ ♖f8 4 ♖xf7+ ♖g8 5 ♗f4!

Black is in all sorts of trouble. The main threat here is ♖xg7+ and ♗f7#.

5...♙xe5 6 ♖xg7+! ♖xg7 7 ♗xe5+ ♗f6

7...♖g8 8 ♙c3 +–.

8 ♙h6+ 1-0

24) Illescas – Kamsky Manila IZ 1990

16 ♙xf7!

A standard sacrifice in such positions. The weak point in Black's position was the f7-square, on which White crashes through.

16...♖xf7 17 ♙g5+ ♖e8

17...♖g8? 18 ♗xe6#.

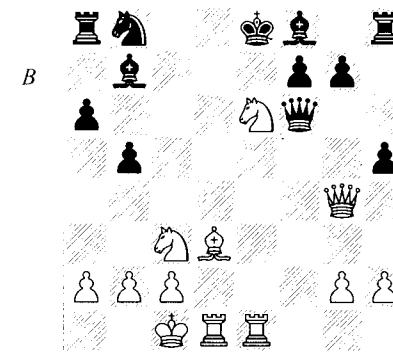
18 ♗xe6+ ♗e7 19 ♗xd5

White regains the piece with a winning position. The game continued:

19...♙d8 20 ♙e6+ ♖c8 21 ♖c1+ ♙c5 22 ♙g5 ♗f7 23 ♗d6 ♙b8 24 ♖xc5+ ♙c6 25 ♙e7 1-0

25) Folling – Lindblom Gausdal 1971

16 ♙xe6! (D)



Blasting the centre open.

16...hgx6 17 ♙xb5+!

Making way for the other rook.

17...♖e7

17...axb5? 18 ♙c7#.

18 ♙xf8+ ♗e6

18...♖xf8? 19 ♖e8#.

19 ♙xe6 fxe6 20 ♙c4 +–

White has emerged from the complications with an extra pawn and a big initiative. Black's e6-pawn is especially weak.

26) Yanofsky – Dulanto Buenos Aires OL 1939

22 ♖xe6+!

The only move, but a good one!

22...♖xe6 23 ♖e1+ ♙d6

Others:

a) 23...♙d7 24 ♗xf7+ and Black loses his queen.

b) 23...♖f5 24 ♖e5+ ♖f4 25 g3+ ♖f3 26 ♖e3#.

c) 23...♖d5 24 c4+ ♖c6 25 ♖f6+ is like the game continuation.

24 ♖f6+ ♖c5 25 ♜e5+ ♖c4 26 b3+ ♖d3

26...♖xc3 27 ♜e2+ ♖d3 (27...♖b4 28 ♖d4+ and ♖a4# follows soon) 28 ♜e3+ ♖c2 29 ♖c3+.

27 ♖d6+ ♖c2

27...♖xc3 28 ♜e3+ ♖b2 29 ♜e2+.

28 ♜e2+ ♖xc3

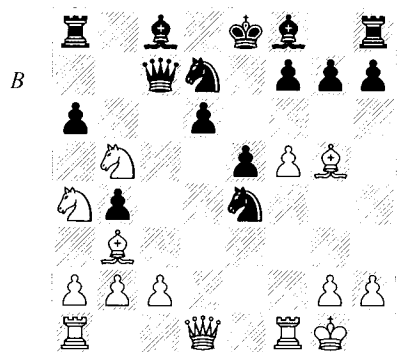
28...♖c1 29 ♖d2+ ♖b1 30 ♜e1#.

29 ♖d2# (1-0)

27) J. Wilson – A. del Corral

Spain 1995

1 ♖b5! (D)



Black is weak on the light squares; White makes a route so his queen can enter the action via d5.

1...♖c6

After 1...axb5 White forces mate with 2 ♖xf7+! ♖xf7 3 ♖d5+ ♖e8 4 ♖e6+ ♖e7 5 ♖xe7#.

2 ♖c7+!

This leads to mate.

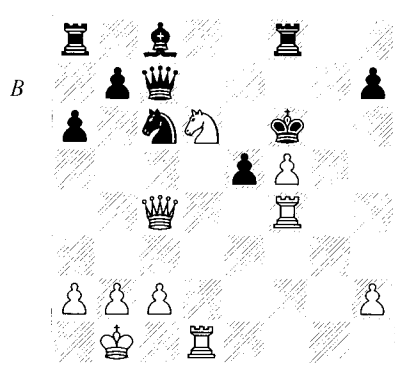
2...♖xc7 3 ♖xf7+ 1-0

Black resigned due to 3...♖xf7 4 ♖d5+ ♖e8 5 ♖e6+ ♖e7 6 ♖xe7#.

28) Shirov – Van Wely

Monaco Amber rpd 2000

23 ♜xf4! (D)



The opening of the a1-h8 diagonal for the white queen causes fatal damage on Black's dark squares.

23...exf4

23...b5 is a better defence but the black king will always be weak; for example, 24 ♖c5 ♖d7 and now either 25 ♜h4 or 25 ♜g1 causes Black problems. 25 ♜h4 looks best; for example, 25...♖a7 26 ♖d5 ♜ad8 27 ♜xh7 +.

24 ♖c3+ ♖g5

24...♖e7 25 ♖g7+ ♖d8 26 ♖xf8+ +.

25 ♜g1+ ♖h4 26 ♖f3! 1-0

29) Bogda – Ferreira

Paraguay Ch 1976

19 ♖f6+! 1-0

This knight jump forces Black to make a serious concession. He decided

to resign rather than see 19...gxf6 (or 19...♖xf6 20 ♜d8#) 20 ♖xe6+ fxe6 21 ♖h5# played out on the board.

30) Seirawan – Browne

Lone Pine 1979

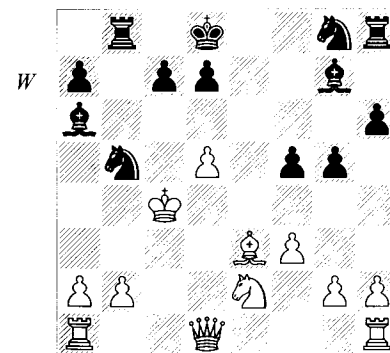
16...♖xc4+!

Black needs to play forcefully, a policy which is often used when trying to exploit an opponent's exposed king.

17 ♖xc4 ♖a6+ 18 ♖b5

18 ♖c5 d6# is also rather embarrassing for White.

18...♖xb5! (D)



0-1

This quiet move is the trickiest move to spot, as Black does not follow up the queen sacrifice with a check or capture. White is in dire straits:

a) 19 b4 ♖c3+ +- with a big mate-in-gain.

b) 19 ♖d3 ♖c3+ 20 ♖c2 ♜xb2+ 21 ♖xb2 ♖xd1+ 22 ♖c1 ♖xe3 +.

c) 19 ♖d4 ♖xd4+ 20 ♖c3 ♖e2+ 21 ♖d2 ♜xb2+ 22 ♖e1 ♖c3+ and White either loses most of his army or

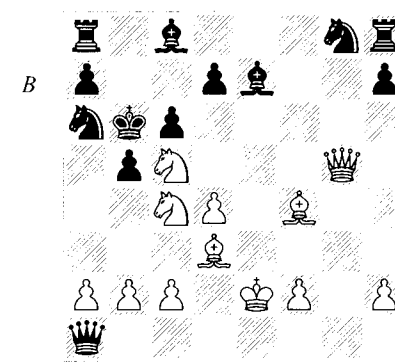
gets mated after 23 ♖f2 ♖f4+ 24 ♖g3 ♜xg2#.

d) 19 ♖b4 ♖c3+ 20 ♖a5 ♖xd1 +- and Black will remain a considerable amount of material up.

31) Repp – Paschitta

corr. 1991

19 ♖c4+! (D)



Enabling the white queen to swing over towards Black's king.

19...bxc4 20 ♖a4+

Another benefit of 19 ♖c4+ – now the other white knight has a square to move to.

20...♖b7 21 ♖b5+!!

A brilliant finish.

21...cxb5 22 ♖e4+ d5 23 ♖xd5# (1-0)

32) Alekhine – Levenfish

St Petersburg 1912

15 ♖b5!

Forward! Other moves leave Black with the advantage.

15...♖xa1+

15...axb5 16 ♖xb5+ ♕d8 (16...♙d7 17 exd7+ ♖xd7 {17...♙d8 18 ♙e5 +-} 18 ♙e5 +- ♖b4+ 19 ♖f1) 17 ♖d1+ ♙d7 18 ♙e5 and now Black's best try appears to be 18...♖xa2! (if 18...♖b4+ then 19 ♖f1 +-), but the quiet move 19 0-0!, which is a bit tricky to spot, puts an end to any resistance; e.g., 19...♖xe6 (19...♙g7 20 ♙xd7 +-) 20 ♙xd7 ♖xd7 21 ♙c7+ ♖xc7 22 ♖xe6 +-.

16 ♖f2 ♖xh1 17 ♖c7+ ♕d8 18 ♖d2+

18 ♖d3+ leads to the same thing.

18...♙d7 19 exd7 1-0

Black resigned in view of 19...e5 (19...♖xd7 20 ♙e6) 20 ♖e6+ ♖e7 21 d8♖+ ♖xd8 22 ♖xd8+ ♖f7 23 ♖xf8+ ♖g7 24 ♖e7#.

33) D. Carlsson – E. Mortensen Copenhagen 1998

8 ♖xe6!?

This move occurs more commonly in French Defence pawn-structures. In this position it seems that Black can defend with precise play.

8...fxe6 9 ♖h5+ g6?

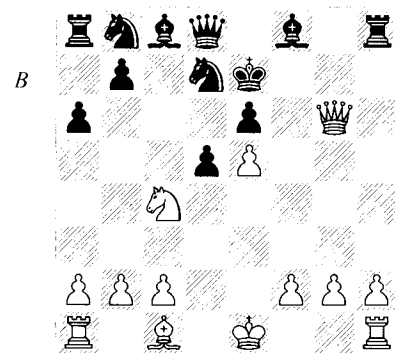
After this Black is lost. 9...♖e7! is much better, and indeed OK for Black, since all the violent attempts for White backfire:

a) 10 ♖c4? dxc4! 11 ♙g5+ ♖f6 12 exf6+ gxf6 13 ♙xf6+ ♖xf6 14 ♖h4+ ♖f7 15 ♖xd8 ♙b4+! 16 c3 ♖xd8 +- and things have gone seriously wrong.

b) 10 ♖e4? dxe4 11 ♙g5+ ♖f6 12 exf6+ gxf6 13 ♙xf6+ ♖xf6 14 ♖h4+ ♖f7 15 ♖xd8 ♙b4+! +-.

c) 10 ♖f3! h6! 11 ♖h4+ (11 ♖h4 ♖c5! 12 ♖g6+ ♕d7 13 ♖xh8 ♖xd3+ 14 cxd3 ♙b4+ 15 ♙d2 ♙xd2+ 16 ♖xd2 ♖xh8 17 ♖f7+ ♕d8 is unclear; Black is slightly tied down but his king is under no danger and he does have two minor pieces) 11...♖f7! 12 ♖xd8 ♙b4+ (Black points out the fact that White's king is also still in the middle of the board!) 13 c3 ♖xd8 14 cxb4 ♖c6 =. Black is doing fine.

10 ♙xg6+ hxg6 11 ♖xg6+ ♕e7 12 ♖c4! (D)



Making room for the dark-squared bishop to arrive on g5.

12...♙h6 13 ♙g5+ ♖f8

Admitting defeat but the other option led to mate: 13...♙xg5 14 ♖g7+ ♖e8 15 ♖d6#.

14 ♙xd8 +-

White's material advantage is overwhelming.

34) Alekhine – Asgeirsson Reykjavik simul 1931 19 ♖xd5!

Allowing more of White's forces to enter the final charge.

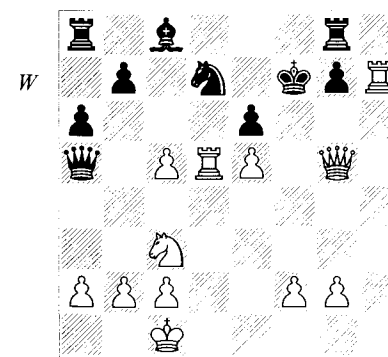
19...♖a5

Black tries to give his king some space to run to. Accepting the sacrifice would have led to mate: 19...exd5 20 ♖xd5+ ♖e6 21 ♖f4+ ♖e7 22 e6 ♖f6 (the main threat was 23 ♖d5+ ♖xe6 24 ♖e1+ ♖e5 25 ♖xe5#) 23 ♖e5 (the threat is now 24 ♖g6#) 23...♖xf7 24 ♖g6+ ♖e8 25 ♖h8+ +-.

20 ♖g5+

The alternative 20 ♖h4+ is also very strong: 20...♖xf7 21 ♖xd7+! ♙xd7 22 ♖e4! (now Black has to give up his queen to avoid mate) 22...♖c7 23 ♖d6+ ♖xd6 (23...♖g8 24 ♖h7#; 23...♖g6 24 ♖h5#) 24 cxd6 +-.

20...♖xf7 21 ♖h7 ♖g8 (D)



22 ♖d4

Re-routing the rook towards Black's king. 22 ♖d3 has the same intentions.

22...♖xc5 23 ♖xd7+! ♙xd7 24 ♖e4

This plan was not possible before as it would have allowed Black to play

...♖e1#, but now the black queen has moved to c5.

24...♖b4 25 ♖d6+ ♖f8 26 ♖f6+!

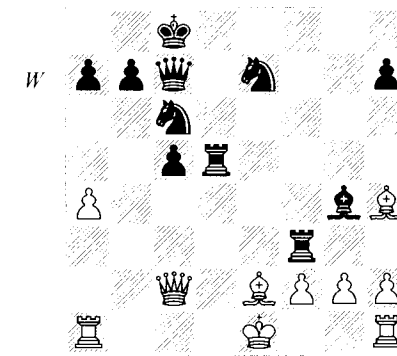
A nice finish.

26...gxh6 27 ♖f7# (1-0)

35) Wagman – Grassi Lago d'Orta 1979

20...♖xf3! (D)

A great move; now the d4-square is ready for a black knight to jump into and White's kingside is also opened up. 20...♖xf3! is also strong; it too vacates the d4-square for the black knight, and play might continue 21 gxf3 (21 ♖xf3 ♖e5+ +-) 21...♖d4 22 ♖xh7 ♖e5 23 ♖xe7 ♖xf3+ 24 ♖f1 ♖xal+ -+.



21 gxf3

21 ♖xf3? ♖e5+ +- makes things easy for Black, as the rook on a1 drops.

21...♖a5+

21...♖d4 22 ♖e4 ♙f5 +- is simple and very strong.

22 ♖f1 ♙h3+ 23 ♖g1 ♖d2 24 ♖e4 ♖xe2! 25 ♖xe2 ♖d4 26 ♖e3 ♖c3!

A nice finish.

27 ♖d1
27 ♖xc3 ♜e2#.
27...♜xf3+ 0-1

36) Vogel – Barlov
W. Germany 1981

1 ♙b5!

In positions such as this, where Black's pieces are still sleeping, fast development is more of a priority than preserving material. The big threat is ♙xf6.

1...♖xc6

Black has to try grabbing some material. Might as well get mated with an extra queen – it looks better...

2 dxc6 1-0

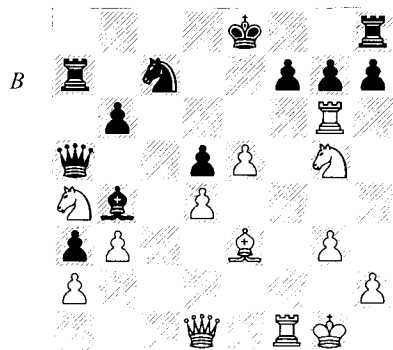
Black resigned in view of:

a) 2...♖c7 3 cxd7+ ♜xd7 (3...♙d8 4 ♜xf7#) 4 ♙xd7+ ♙d8 5 ♙f4 and Black's king will not last long.

b) 2...♜xe5 3 c7+ ♜fd7 4 cxd8 ♖+ ♙xd8 5 0-0-0+.

37) Sulskis – Gleizerov
Calcutta 2002

23 ♖xg6! (D)



Black's light-squared bishop is a good defender and must be removed! White may be able to get away with capturing a pawn by 23 ♜xb6?, but why win a pawn when you can win the king? After 23...♖b5 24 ♖c1 0-0 a long game awaits White.

23 e6! is also good, opening up the centre. Play might continue 23...fxe6 24 ♖xb6 ♙e7 25 ♜f3+- and as in the game Black's king is struggling.

23...fxg6

23...hxg6 24 ♖g4! (bringing up the heavy artillery) 24...♖a6 (24...0-0 25 ♖h4+-; 24...♖a8 25 ♜xf7 0-0 26 ♖xg6+-) 25 ♖xf7 ♙e7 26 ♜xb6!+-.

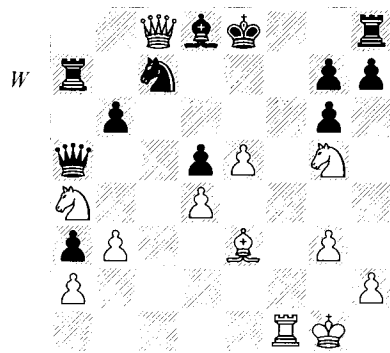
24 ♖g4

Black's king will not survive long, stuck in the centre with little defence.

24...♙e7

24...♖a8 25 ♜e6! ♜b5 26 ♙g5+-.

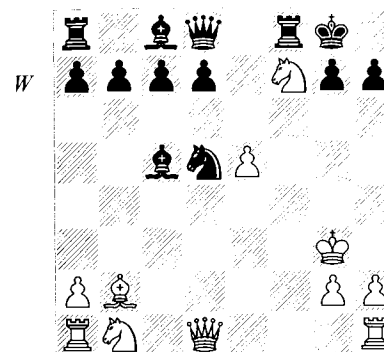
25 ♖c8+ ♙d8 (D)



26 ♜e6 ♜xe6 27 ♖xe6+ ♙e7
27...♖e7 28 ♖c6+ ♖d7 29 e6+-.
28 ♖c8+ ♙d8 29 ♙g5

29 ♖c6+ also wins.
29...b5 30 ♖c6+ 1-0

38) Hoffman – Petroff
Warsaw 1844
12...0-0!! (D)



As Black's queen cannot enter the attack, he decides that it is worth sacrificing it, so the dormant rook on h8 can have a piece of the action. 12...♜e3 and 12...♖e7 both leave Black with an advantage, but 12...0-0!! is more to the point, and who could resist playing such a move?

13 ♜xd8 ♙f2+ 14 ♖h3 d6+ 15 e6
15 g4 ♜f4#.

15...♜f4+ 16 ♙g4 ♜xe6 17 ♜xe6

17 g3 is better but the same result occurs after 17...♜xd8+ 18 ♙g5 ♖f5+ 19 ♙g4 (19 ♙h4 ♖f4+) 19...♖f6+ 20 ♙h4 ♖f4+ 21 ♙g5 ♜e6+ 22 ♙h5 g6+ 23 ♙h6 ♖h4+ 24 gxf4 ♙e3#.

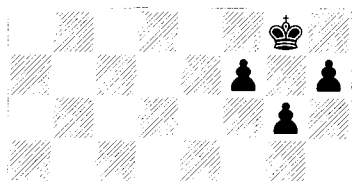
17...♙xe6+ 18 ♙g5 ♖f5+ 19 ♙g4
h5+ 20 ♙h3 ♖f3# (0-1)

2 Attacking the Castled King

This chapter is the largest in the book because I believe that the themes seen within this chapter are the most common in over-the-board chess. In most games both players will castle, so it is a good idea to know some common tactics that arise in such positions.

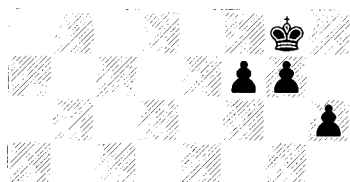
When attacking a king that is castled it is worth looking out for the following themes:

1) **Any weakness in the enemy's camp should be targeted.** This could be a pawn around the opponent's king which has moved. Pawn moves create weaknesses; the following diagrams give some basic examples of this.



The move ...g6 has created weaknesses around the black king. The squares f6, g7 and h6 are especially weak now. White may think about placing a piece on f6 or h6, which would not be possible if the black pawn were still on g7. The long a1-h8

diagonal has also been weakened; if White can take over this diagonal with a combination of queen and bishop Black might be in serious trouble.

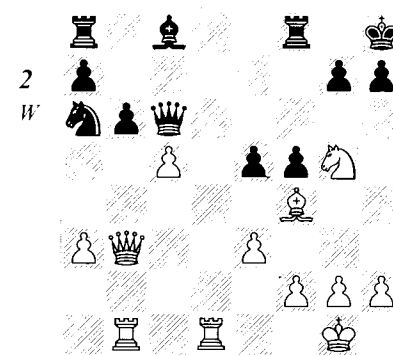


The move ...h6 has created some targets for White. White might be able to sacrifice on h6 at some point, opening up the black king. The g6-square has also been weakened.

Obviously the above examples depend upon the set-up of pieces. In many cases a player can target such weaknesses by manoeuvring his pieces towards his opponent's weak areas.

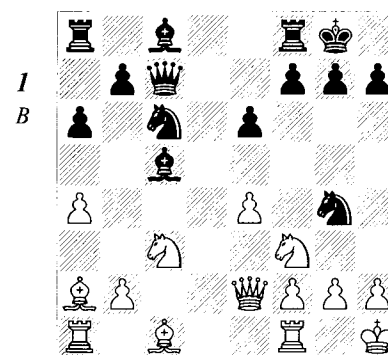
2) As well as considering where your own pieces are placed, it is also important to consider where your opponent's pieces are. **An attack will have a greater chance of success when your opponent's pieces are either undeveloped or stuck on the other side of the board.**

3) **Familiarize yourself with the most common sacrifices which occur against a castled king;** for example, the Greek Gift and Smothered mate. A player will only be able to learn more of these sacrifices by experience.

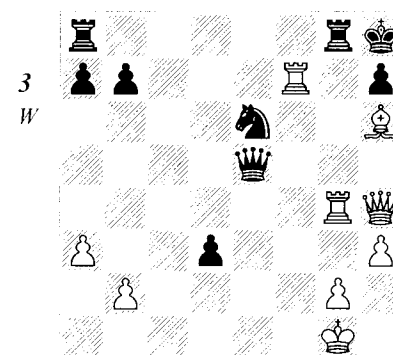


This position is a standard case of smothered mate. White forces mate by means of a clever knight manoeuvre. How?

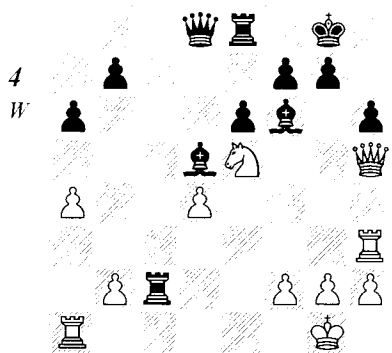
Puzzles



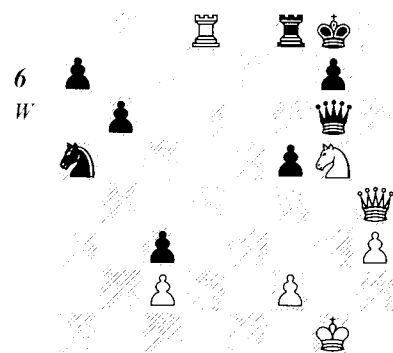
Being alert to possibilities in all positions is at the heart of chess. How can Black force White to resign here?



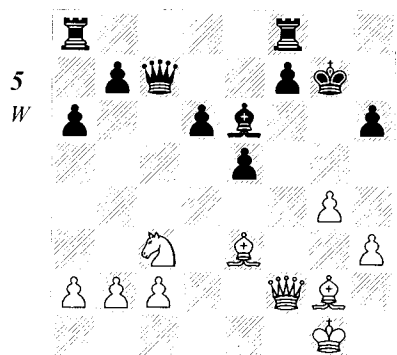
With so many white pieces hovering around the black king, it is not surprising that White can force checkmate here. How should he go about this?



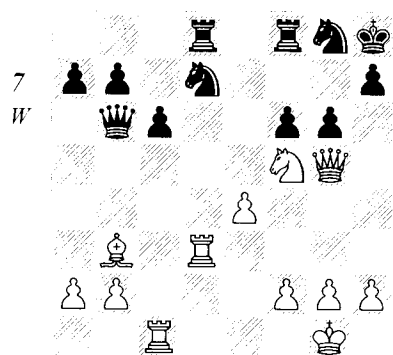
White obviously has a dangerous attack, with three pieces positioned around the black king. How can he force mate?



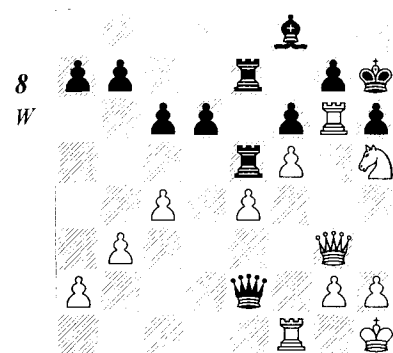
With three white pieces so dangerously placed around the black king, White should have sensed that there was a finish in the position. What should he play?



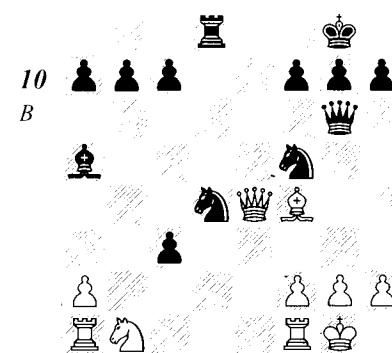
Black's king is lacking protection, especially on the dark squares. How should White exploit this?



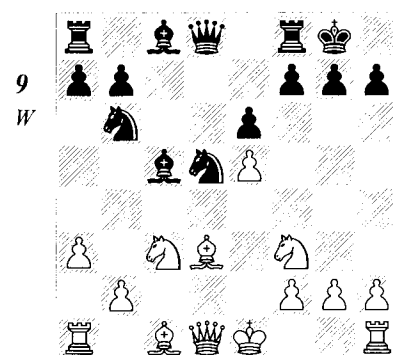
White clearly has a dangerous attack. How can he polish Black off?



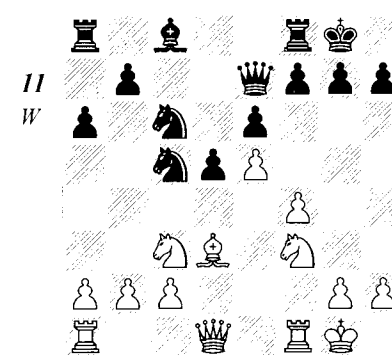
There are a number of weaknesses around the black king here, of which the g6-square particularly stands out. This combined with White's three attacking pieces is enough for White to force the win. How did he achieve this?



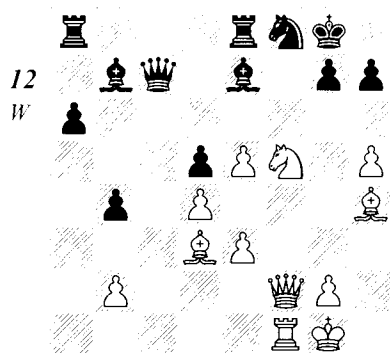
Black's knights are controlling the board, aiming at both the kingside and queenside; White is also behind in development. How did Black finish him off?



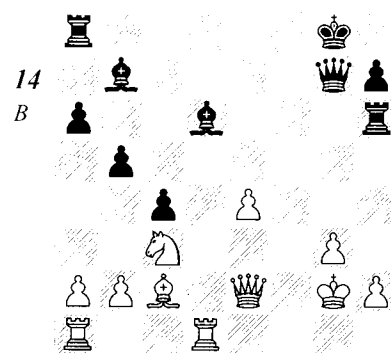
All the pieces guarding Black's king have moved to the queenside, leaving the black king without any proper defence. How can White launch a decisive attack to take advantage of Black's sloppy play?



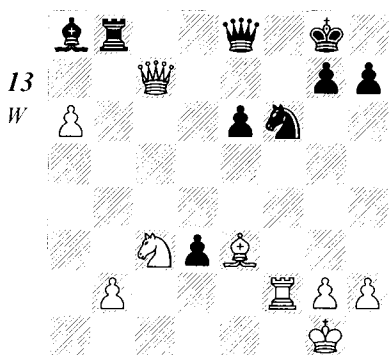
How did White achieve a winning position here by utilizing a common theme?



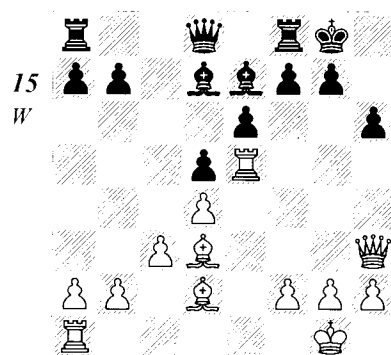
White can win back some material with 28 ♖xe7+ but this leaves him a piece down. With the line-up of white pieces on the kingside it is no wonder that White has a better move. What is that move?



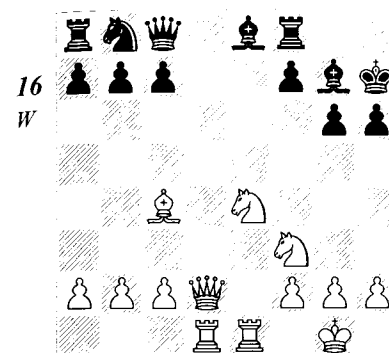
White's king is under serious pressure from Black's bishops, queen and rook. How did Black bring home the bacon?



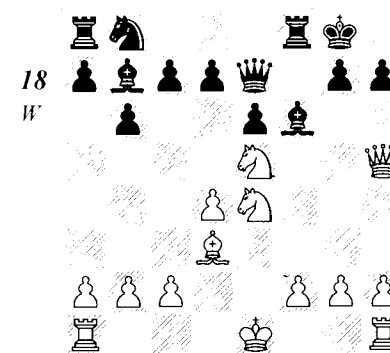
Black has just played the careless ...♖d7-f6. How did White refute this move?



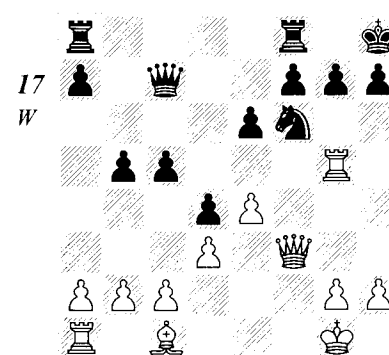
Which standard sacrifice breaks through Black's defences here? Analyse until the end.



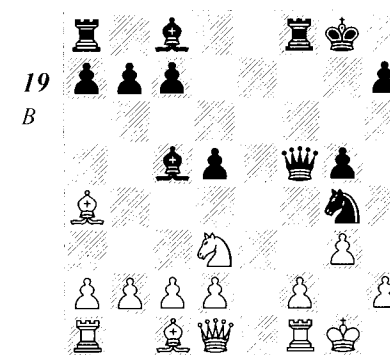
White is well-placed to start an assault on the black king. As in many similar positions, f7 turns out to be the real weakness in Black's position. What should White play?



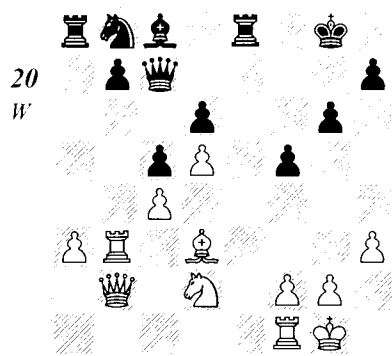
All of White's pieces are ideally placed around Black's king. Another factor in White's favour is that Black's queenside is still sleeping. How can White exploit these factors with his next move?



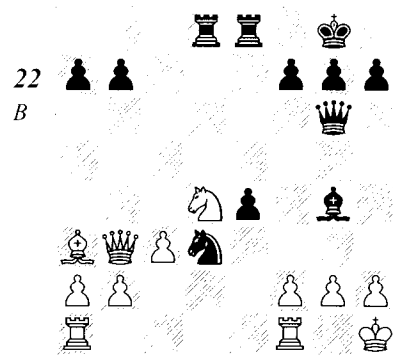
Black is under serious pressure; the dark squares around his king are especially weak. White could play the simple 20 ♕f4 followed by 21 ♕e5, when Black is struggling, but White chose a stronger move. What was it?



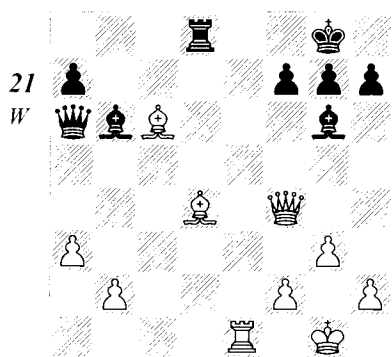
White is very weak on the light squares around his king; he is also behind in development. These factors should set alarm bells ringing. Black to play and win.



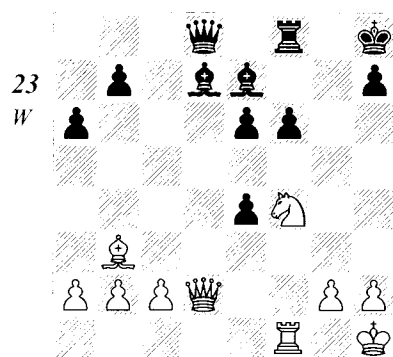
Black's kingside is very weak on the dark squares; he is also behind in development. What move should White now have played?



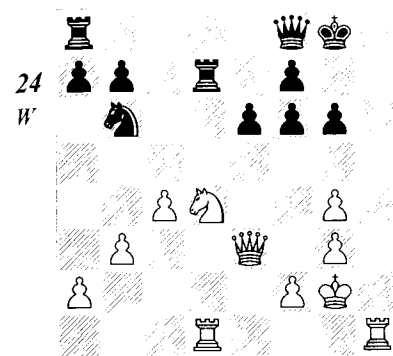
Black's pieces are all well placed; White also has no pieces defending his king, so it is not surprising that Black can win here. What should he play?



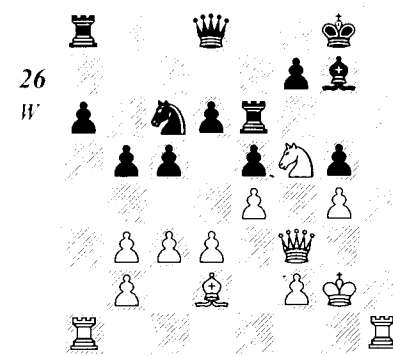
How can White combine the power of his bishops with Black's weak back rank to deliver mate?



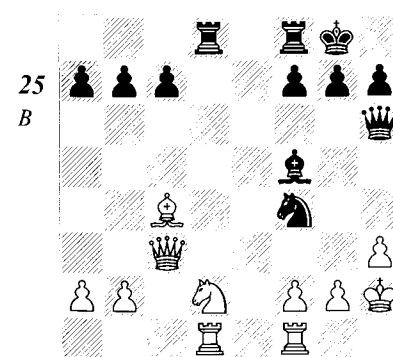
Black's king is lacking cover and White can force a draw straight away with 1 ♖g6+ hxg6 2 ♜h6+ ♔g8 3 ♜xg6+, but can he play for more?



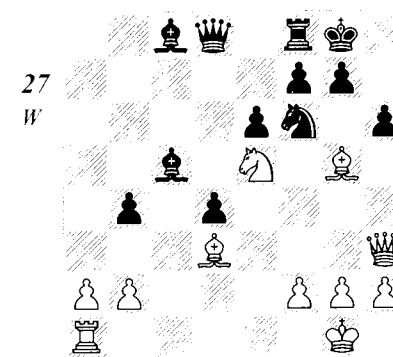
White has an open h-file on which to attack. His pieces, especially the d4-knight, are also better placed than their counterparts. How did White break through Black's defences?



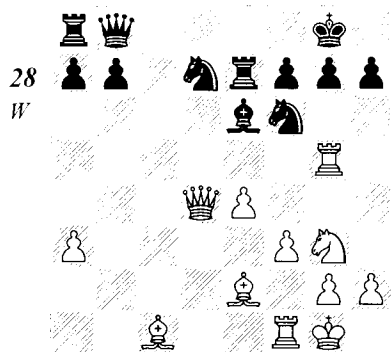
White has a definite advantage here due to his strong knight on f5, well-placed queen on f3 and the open h-file. The f7-square is also rather weak. How did White use these factors to make a decisive breakthrough?



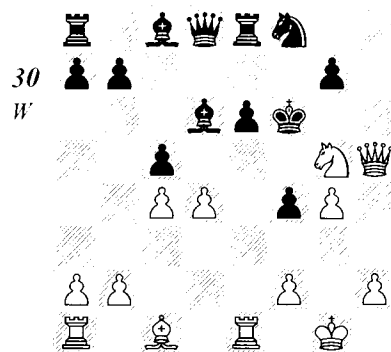
Black's attack on the kingside appears dangerous and White has a major weakness: the h3-pawn. How did Black win?



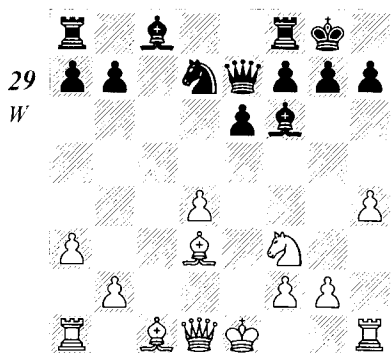
Black's position is under considerable pressure here; the knight is pinned to the queen. Black has weakened his kingside with the move ...h6 and White has four pieces all staring towards the black kingside. What should White play?



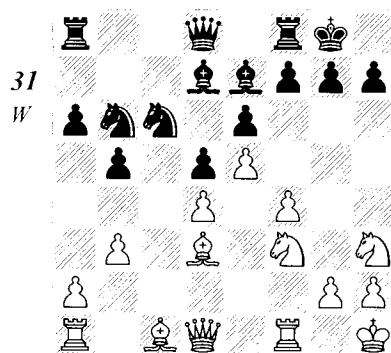
The first thing that stands out in this position is how weak Black is on the dark squares. The calm 21 ♖b2 leaves White with a big advantage, but with Black's queen and rook stuck out of the game on a8 and b8 there is a better move. What is it?



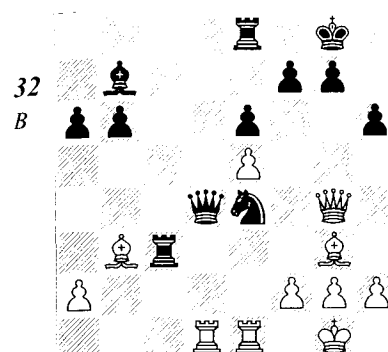
It is clear that Black's king is rather exposed but it is not clear how White should continue the attack. What move did White play that ensured him a won game?



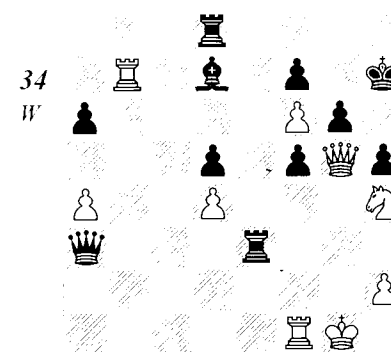
Black has just castled, which was a critical error as it allows White to unleash a standard sacrifice against the black king. What is that sacrifice? Try to calculate the variations to the end.



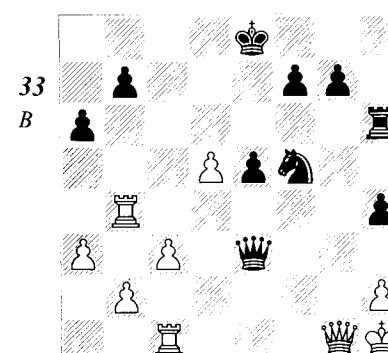
White has a lot of pieces all ready to jump upon the black kingside. What is the best move for White here?



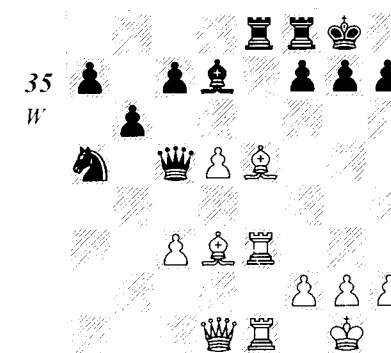
Black is a pawn up and would like to exchange off material to reach an ending, where converting the pawn into a win would be simpler. How did Black achieve his aims?



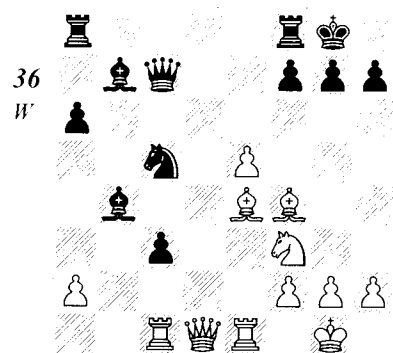
Black has only pawns to defend his bare king, while White has a queen and a knight ready to attack at any moment. How did White make the decisive breakthrough?



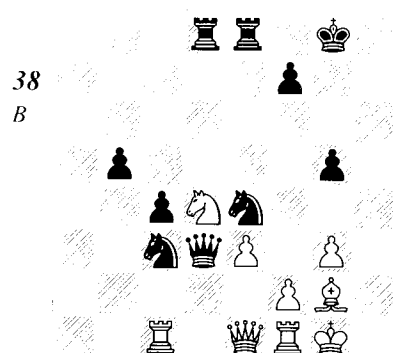
Black has three pieces all actively placed around the white king, which lacks adequate pawn-cover. How did Black win?



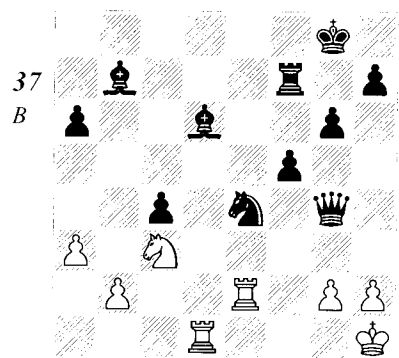
Black has just played 24... ♖a3-c5??. which was a huge blunder. White's pieces are all well-placed while Black's pieces are off-side. White's next move brings up a common theme. What was it?



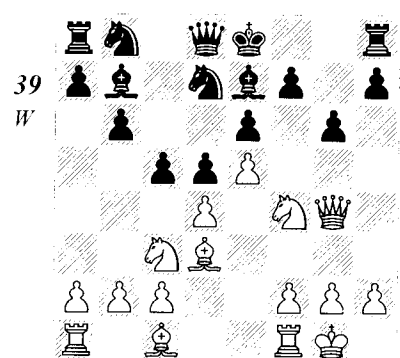
This puzzle is a rare example of Tal (Black here) being on the receiving end of a devastating attack. What should White play?



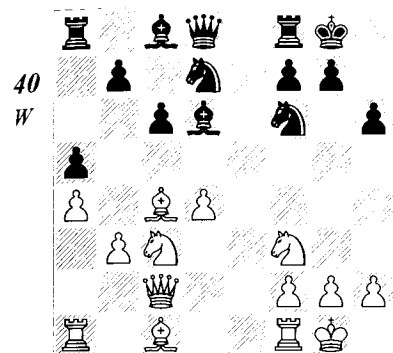
Black's pieces are well-placed here, controlling the centre of the board. How did he shatter White's defences?



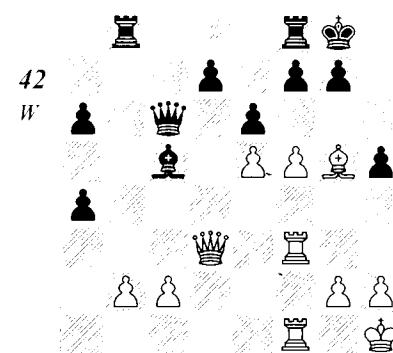
Nearly all Black's pieces are staring over at the white king. The black bishops are looking especially menacing. Black sensed the danger and found a forcing line that won the game. What was it?



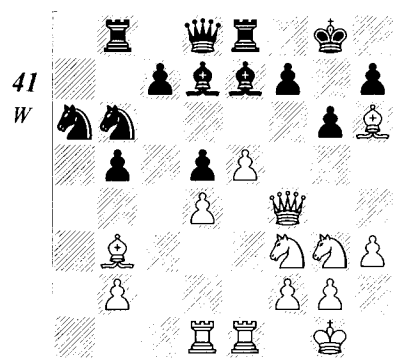
Black has played the serious concession ...g6, which weakened several squares on his kingside. Most of White's army are also pointing that way, which starts the alarm bells ringing. What should White play? Try to analyse until the end.



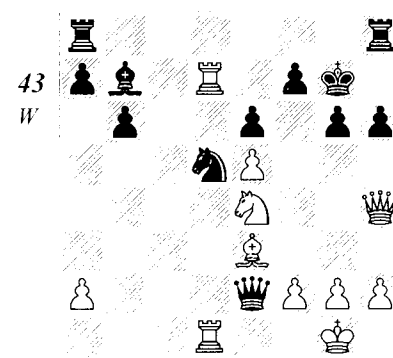
Black has made the committal move ...h6 on the kingside. This move has created extra weaknesses around the black king. How did White demolish Black's position with the use of a standard motif?



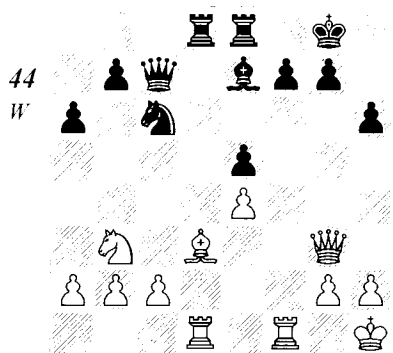
Black's king is in mortal danger. How did White break through?



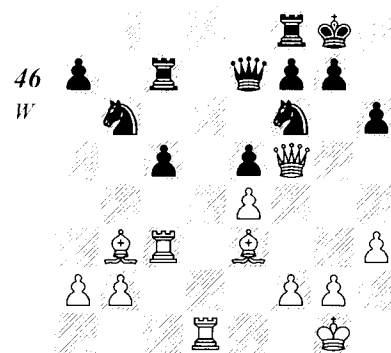
White has amassed his forces near to the black king, which has been seriously weakened by the move ...g6. This has made the squares f6 and g7 especially weak. What should White play?



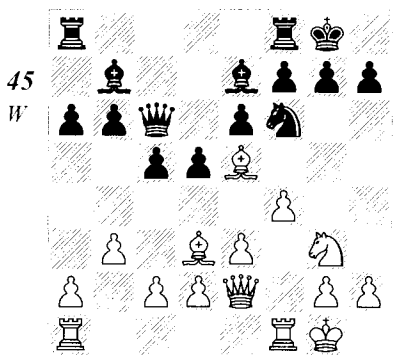
White has four pieces hovering around the black king. How can he use these to force mate?



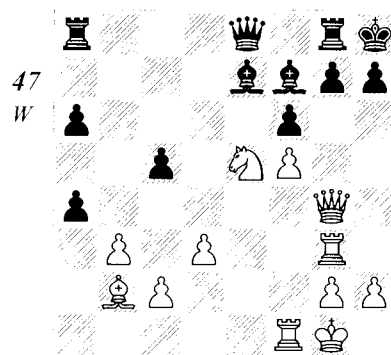
When trying to pull off a successful attack, it is very important to try to find weaknesses in the enemy's position. Here there is one weakness that shouts out. How can White achieve a winning position?



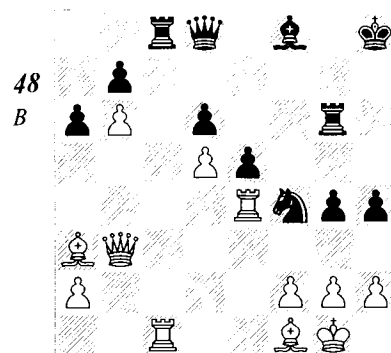
Black's kingside has been compromised by the move ...h6. How can White capitalize on this?



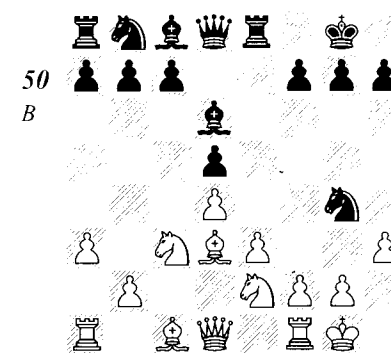
The idea first seen in this game has since occurred numerous times in practice and is well worth remembering. How should White conduct the king-side attack? Analyse until the end.



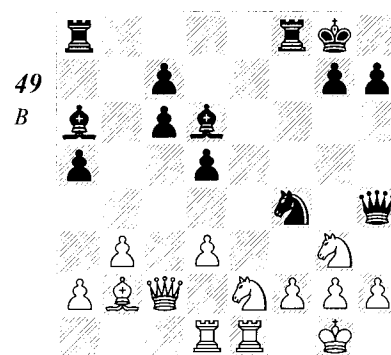
White exchanged on f7 here, which gave him a small advantage. Yet there was a better and more dynamic option. What was that move, and the subsequent follow-up?



The game has reached a critical point. White is about to infiltrate Black's position on the queenside but Black is attacking on the kingside. How did Black ensure that his attack was the more successful?



White has just played 10 h3, expecting the black knight to retreat. Black on the other hand had a different idea. With the two black bishops, queen and e8-rook all looking towards the white king, what plan did Black conjure up?



Black has a strong cluster of pieces around the white king, and the open f-file is a major attacking avenue. How should Black conduct the attack?

Solutions

1) P. Littlewood – Penrose

British Ch (Chester) 1979

13...♘d4! 0-1

White threw in the towel due to 14 ♖xd4 (after 14 ♖c4 ♖xf3 → Black is a clear piece up with an attack) 14...♖xh2#.

2) Capablanca – Matisons

(variation)

Karlsbad 1929

22 ♖f7+ ♖g8

22...♖xf7 23 ♖d8+ ♖e8 24 ♖xe8+ ♖f8 25 ♖xf8#.

23 ♖h6++ ♖h8 24 ♖g8+!

This idea has been played in many games and should be a part of every player's attacking technique.

24...♖xg8 25 ♖f7#

3) Shirov – Grishchuk

Linares 2001

32 ♖xh7+! 1-0

Black resigned due to 32...♖xh7 33 ♖g7+ ♖h5 34 ♖xh5#.

4) Najdorf – Kotov (variation)

Mar del Plata 1957

24 ♖xf7+ ♖h7

24...♖h8 is treated in the same way: 25 ♖xh6+! gxf6 26 ♖g6#.

25 ♖xh6+! ♖xh6 26 ♖g6#

5) Timman – Van Wely

Breda (6) 1998

20 ♖xh6+! ♖g6

20...♖xh6 21 ♖f6+ ♖h7 22 ♖e4+

♖g8 23 ♖g5+ ♖h8 24 ♖h6+ ♖g8 25 ♖h7#.

21 ♖h4 1-0

Mate cannot be stopped.

6) Ivanov – Dimitrov

Sofia 1957

1 ♖h8+! ♖xh8 2 ♖xf8#

7) Alekhine – Lasker

Zurich 1934

26 ♖xg6! 1-0

Black resigned due to 26...hxf6 27 ♖h3+ ♖h6 28 ♖xh6#.

8) Treybal – Henneberger

The Hague 1928

1 ♖xh6+!

Opening up the king's position.

1...gxf6

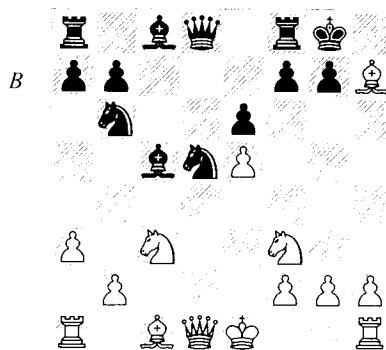
Or: 1...♖xh6 2 ♖g6#; 1...♖g8 2 ♖xf6+ ♖f7 3 ♖g6#.

2 ♖xf6+ ♖h8 3 ♖g8# (1-0)

9) Lugovoi – Kallio

Gausdal 2003

13 ♖xh7+! (D)



The standard Greek Gift. This theme crops up frequently, and leads to a won position here.

13...♖xh7 14 ♖g5+ ♖g6

14...♖g8 15 ♖h5 ♖e8 16 ♖xf7+ ♖h8 17 ♖h5+ ♖g8 18 ♖h7+ ♖f8 19 ♖h8+ ♖e7 20 ♖xg7#.

15 ♖c2+ f5

15...♖h5 16 ♖h7+ ♖g4 17 h3#.

16 exf6+ ♖xf6 17 ♖ce4+ ♖e7 18 ♖xc5+

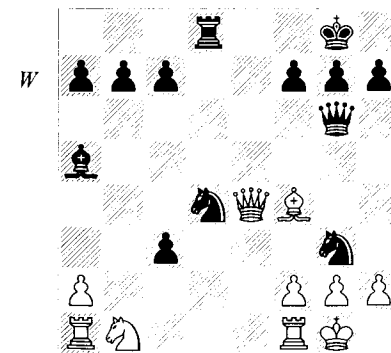
White has a decisive advantage. The game finished as follows:

18...♖e8 19 ♖d6+ ♖d7 20 ♖df7 ♖e7 21 ♖b5+ ♖c7 22 ♖f4+! ♖xf4 23 ♖c1+ ♖b8 24 ♖e5+ 1-0

10) Marache – Morphy

New York 1857

19...♖g3! (D)



Making the most of Black's knights and the undefended white queen.

20 ♖xg6

Otherwise ...♖de2+ will be killing anyway.

20...♖de2# (0-1)

11) El Taher – Sorial

Cairo Z 2000

12 ♖xh7+!

This standard sacrifice wins easily.

12...♖xh7 13 ♖g5+ ♖g6

13...♖g8 14 ♖h5 ♖d8 15 ♖h7+ ♖f8 16 ♖h8#.

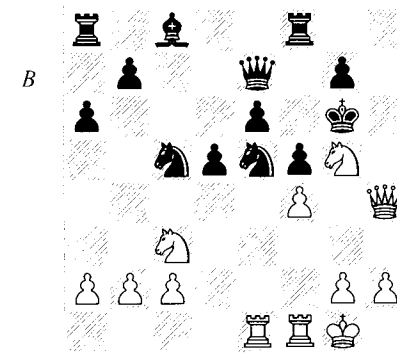
14 ♖g4

This move is a common follow-up to the Greek Gift.

14...♖xe5

14...f5 15 ♖h4+-, 16 ♖h7# is next up.

15 ♖h4 f5 16 ♖ae1! (D)



A calm move making maximum use of all the white pieces.

16...♖e4

Black's only move: e.g., 16...♖c6 17 ♖xd5!+-.

17 ♖h7+ ♖f6 18 ♖ce4+ dxe4 19 ♖xe4+ ♖f7

19...fxe4 20 fxe5+-.

20 fxe5 ♖e8 21 ♖d1+-

White has control of the board, an extra pawn and duly went on to win on move 33.

12) Vallejo Pons – Draško*Saint Vincent 1999***28 ♖h6+! ♖h8**

Black must capture the knight either now or next move. After 28...gxh6! 29 ♖f7+ ♖h8 30 ♖f6+ ♖xf6 31 ♖xc7 ♖e7 32 ♖d6 White's active pieces and strong central pawns leave him no worse.

29 ♖f7 ♖e6??

For 29...gxh6! see the previous note.

30 ♖g8+! 1-0**13) Ivanchuk – Van Wely***Prague rpd 2002***32 ♖xf6!**

Opening up the black king.

32...♖xb2

32...gxf6 loses to 33 ♖h6.

33 ♖f2 +-**14) D'Costa – Wells***British League (4NCL) 2002/3***23...♖xh2+!**

A logical move, destroying White's pawn-structure from its base.

24 ♖xh2 ♖xg3+ 25 ♖h1 ♖h3+ 26 ♖g1 ♖c5+ 0-1

15) Ristić – Marković*Serbian Ch (Dimitrovgrad) 2003***19 ♖xh6!**

Removing the defensive protection from Black's king.

19...gxh6 20 ♖xh6 1-0

Black resigned due to 20...f5 (otherwise 21 ♖h7#) 21 ♖g6+ ♖h8 22 ♖e3 (a typical plan in these sort of attacks) 22...♖h4 23 ♖h3 ♖e7 24 ♖g3

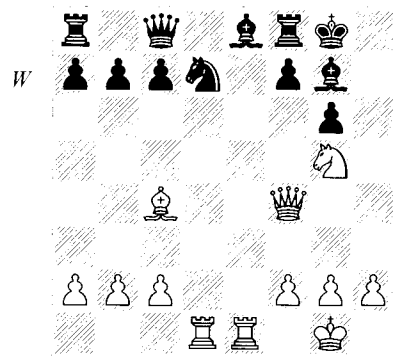
♖f7 25 ♖xh4+, when White is clearly winning.

16) Tal – T. Petrosian*USSR Ch (Moscow) 1974***19 ♖eg5+! hxg5 20 ♖xg5+ ♖g8**

20...♖h8 is met by 21 ♖f4 +-. The ♖h4-h7 manoeuvre is always a major problem for Black.

21 ♖f4 ♖d7 (D)

21...♖h6 22 ♖xe8! +-.

**22 ♖xd7!**

The black knight was heading for f6 where it would be a good defender, so White gets rid of it.

22...♖xd7 23 ♖xf7+ +-**17) O. Jackson – Lim Chin Lee***British Ch (Scarborough) 1999***20 ♖xg7!**

White breaks through on the dark squares.

20...♖xg7 21 ♖h6+! +- ♖g6

21...♖xh6 leads to mate after 22 ♖xf6+ ♖h5 23 ♖f1! (with the simple plan of 24 ♖f3, 25 ♖h3+ and 26 ♖h4#)

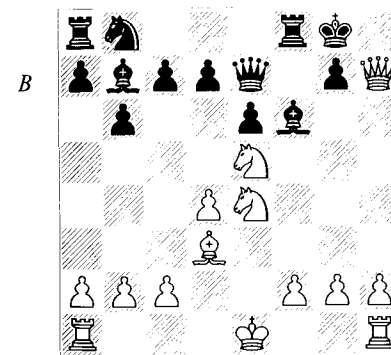
23...♖d8 (23...♖g8 24 ♖f3 +-) 24 g4+! ♖xg4 25 ♖f4+ ♖h5 26 ♖h4#.

22 ♖f4 ♖xf4

Or 22...e5 23 ♖g3+ ♖g4 24 ♖xg4+ ♖f6 25 ♖g5+ ♖g7 26 ♖e7+ ♖h8 27 ♖f6#. The rest is simple.

23 ♖xf4

Black resigned on move 27.

18) Ed. Lasker – Thomas*London (casual game) 1912***11 ♖xh7+!! (D)**

Leading to a beautiful final position.

11...♖xh7 12 ♖xf6++ ♖h6

12...♖h8 does not help matters in view of 13 ♖g6#.

13 ♖eg4+ ♖g5 14 h4+ ♖f4 15 g3+ ♖f3 16 ♖e2+ ♖g2 17 ♖h2+ ♖g1 18 ♖d2# (1-0)

I would have preferred 18 0-0-0#.

19) Velička – Souleidis*Gelsenkirchen 1998*

14...♖xh2! 15 ♖xh2 ♖h3+ 16 ♖g1 ♖xg3+!

Moves like this are sometimes difficult to spot unless you have seen the idea before.

17 ♖h1 ♖h3+ 18 ♖g1 ♖f6 +-

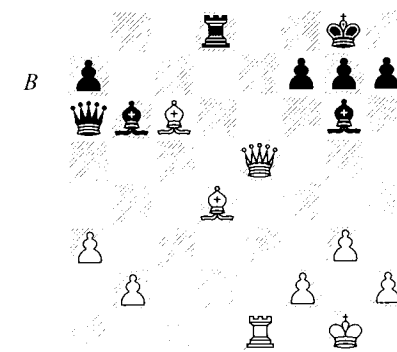
Just planning to play ...♖h6. White has no adequate defence to this plan.

20) Karpov – Rashkovsky*USSR Ch (Moscow) 1973***23 ♖xf5**

This would have won a pawn, as Black cannot take the bishop:

a) 23...gxf5 24 ♖g3+ ♖f8 (24...♖f7 25 ♖g7#) 25 ♖h8+ ♖e7 26 ♖e1+ ♖d8 27 ♖xe8#.

b) 23...♖xf5 24 ♖xb7 with mate on g7.

21) Mirković – Stefanovski*Kladovo 1990***23 ♖e5! (D)****23...f6**

The only way to stop White's mate threats on g7 and e8.

24 ♖d5+ ♖h8 25 ♖xf6! ♖g8 26 ♖e7 1-0

White's pieces are harmonized perfectly.

22) Juarez – Lputian

Manila IZ 1990

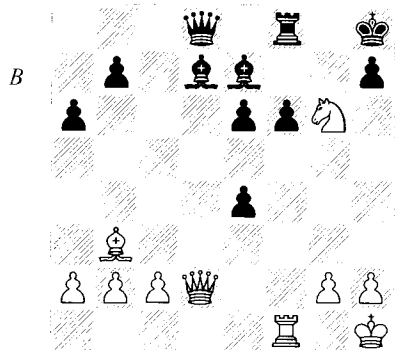
22...♖xd4! 0-1

White resigned in view of 23 cxd4 ♕f3! 24 gxf3 (24 ♖g1 doesn't help matters: 24...♗xf2#) 24...exf3 25 ♖g1 ♗xf2#.

23) Feigin – Solodovnichenko

Russia 1996

1 ♗g6+! (D)



1...hxg6

1...♗g7 2 ♗xf8 +–.

2 ♖h6+ ♗g8 3 ♖xg6+ ♗h8 4 ♖f5!

+–

It is mate on either h5 or h6.

24) Bronstein – Ratner

USSR Ch (Moscow) 1945

24 ♗xe6!

Destroying the pawn-cover in front of Black's king.

24...♖xd1

Or: 24...fxe6 25 ♖xd7 ♗xd7 26 ♖xe6+ ♖f7 27 ♖h8+ +–; 24...♖e7 25 ♖h8+ ♗xh8 26 ♖h6+ ♗g8 27 ♖g7#.

25 ♗xf8 ♖xh1 26 ♗xh1 ♖xf8

White has a winning position and went on to win quickly.

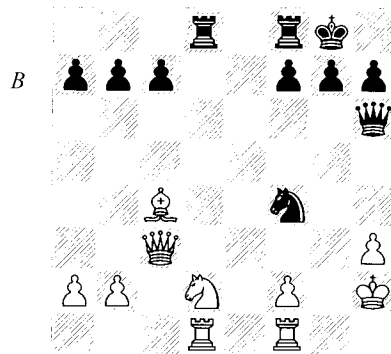
25) Saint-Amant – Morphy

Paris 1858

18...♗xh3!

A textbook finish!

19 gxh3 (D)



19...♖d3!

A brilliant move to interfere with the queen's defence of the h3-square.

20 ♖xd3

20 ♗xd3 ♖xh3+ 21 ♗g1 ♖g2#.

20...♗d3 21 ♗xd3 ♖d6+ 22 f4 ♖xd3 0-1

26) Pillsbury – Tarrasch

Monte Carlo 1902

27 ♗xg7!

This first move in the combination does not look natural as it swaps off the strong knight for Black's bad bishop.

However, White had seen a little further...

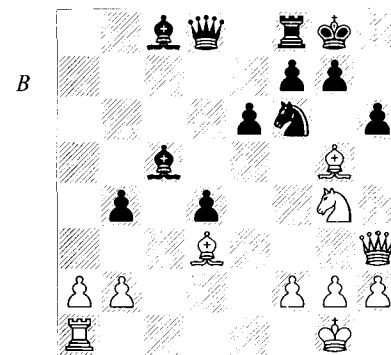
27...♗xg7 28 ♖h7+! ♗xh7 29 ♖xf7+ 1-0

Black resigned due to 29...♗h8 (or 29...♗h6 30 ♖h1#) 30 ♖h1+ ♖h6 31 ♖xh6#.

27) Capablanca – Levenfish

Moscow 1935

20 ♗g4! (D)



Bringing the knight closer to the black king. On g4, the knight hits two weak points in the black position, the f6-knight and the h6-pawn.

20...♗e7

Not 20...hxg5? 21 ♗xf6+ ♖xf6 22 ♖h7#.

21 ♗xf6

The immediate 21 ♗xh6+ is also strong, and forces mate.

21...gxf6

21...♗xf6 22 ♗xh6+! will lead to a common mating position: 22...gxh6 23 ♖xh6 ♖e8 24 ♗h7+ ♗h8 25 ♗g6+ ♗g8 26 ♖h7+ ♗f8 27 ♖xf7#.

22 ♗xh6+ ♗g7 23 ♖g4+! ♗h8

23...♗xh6 24 ♖h4+ ♗g7 25 ♖h7#.

24 ♖h5 ♗g7 25 ♗xf7! ♖h8

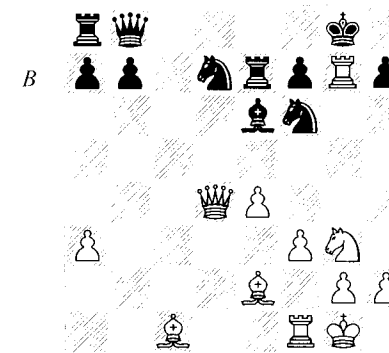
25...♗xf7 26 ♖h7+ ♗f8 27 ♖h8#.

26 ♖g6+ 1-0

28) Botvinnik – Keres

The Hague/Moscow Wch 1948

21 ♖xg7+! (D)



Viciously opening up the dark squares around Black's king.

21...♗xg7 22 ♗h5+ ♗g6

22...♗g8 23 ♗xf6+ ♗xf6 24 ♖xf6 ♖e8 25 ♗h6 +–.

23 ♖e3 +–

This quiet move will lead to mate.

29) Stoppa – Bardel

Grenoble 2002

12 ♗xh7+!

The Greek Gift once more. The black king is opened up to an attack from the white queen and h1-rook.

12...♗xh7 13 ♗g5+ ♗xg5

Or: 13...♗g8 14 ♖h5 and Black is mated on h7: 13...♗g6 14 ♖d3+ +–.

14 hxg5+ ♖g6

14...♗g8 15 ♖h5 f5 16 g6 +-.

15 ♖h5+ ♗f5 16 ♖h4!

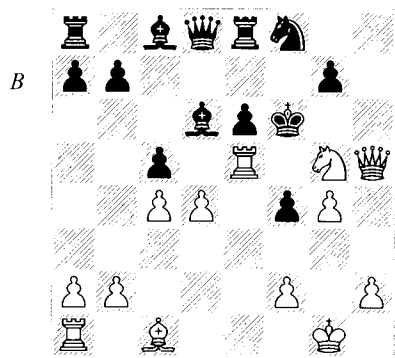
A nice idea introducing a new mate threat which Black is powerless to stop.

16...e5 17 ♖g4+ ♗g6 18 ♖h6+! gxh6 19 gxh6+ +-

30) Wells – Dumitrache

Balatonbereny 1997

18 ♖e5!! (D)



Now ♖f7# is a real threat. 18 ♖e5 should be a move that enters a player's mind. The knight and queen are already attacking, so an additional white piece needs to enter the picture to finish Black off. Again three attacking pieces is the magic number.

18...♗d7

Defending f7. Black has nothing better: 18...♗xe5? 19 dxe5+ ♗xe5 (or 19...♗e7 20 ♖f7#) 20 ♖f7++ +-.

19 ♗xf4

Bringing another piece into the attack.

19...♗xe5 20 ♗xe5+ ♗e7

Now White should have played 21 dxc5!, when victory is certain due to White's control over the dark squares. Then 22 ♗d6+ is one major threat (22...♗d8 23 ♖f7+ or 22...♗f6 23 ♖e4#).

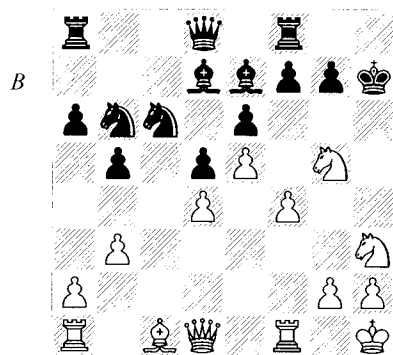
31) Jehle – Kobler

Goetzis 1997

14 ♗xh7+!

This should be a familiar idea.

14...♗xh7 15 ♖fg5+ (D)



The Greek Gift is even stronger here as White already has a pawn on f4. This pawn serves a couple of purposes: a stable hold on g5, the move f5 is a possibility and in some cases the f1-rook can swing around to g3 or h3.

15...♗g6 16 f5+ 1-0

Black resigned as he probably anticipated the following continuation: 16...♗h6 (16...exf5 17 ♖f4+ ♗xg5 18 ♖h5#) 17 ♖g4 g6 (17...exf5 18 ♖h4+ ♗g6 19 ♖h7#) 18 ♖xf7+! ♗g7 19 ♖xg6#.

32) Van Wely – Piket

Tilburg 1998

21...♖xg3!

The rest is simple for a player of Piket's strength.

22 ♖xg3

22 hxg3 ♖xf2+ 23 ♗h2 ♖c3 +-.

22...♖xd1 23 ♖xd1 ♖xg3 24 hxg3

Black went on to convert the extra pawn into victory. White resigned on move 38.

33) S. Haslinger – Gormally

British Ch (Edinburgh) 2003

28...♖g3+! 29 hxg3

29 ♗g2 h3#.

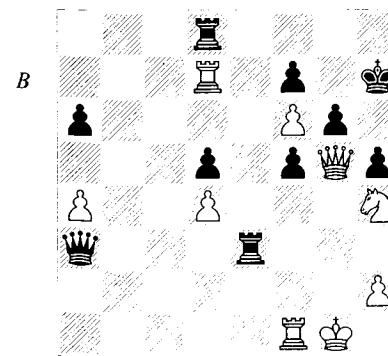
29...♖f3+ 30 ♖g2 hxg3+ 31 ♗g1 ♖e3+ 0-1

White resigned because of the line 32 ♗f1 ♖h1+ 33 ♖xh1 ♖f2#.

34) Vaganian – Shirov

Istanbul OL 2000

28 ♖xd7! (D)



The d7-bishop was a good defender of the f5-pawn, but now that it is gone

White can break Black's pawn defence.

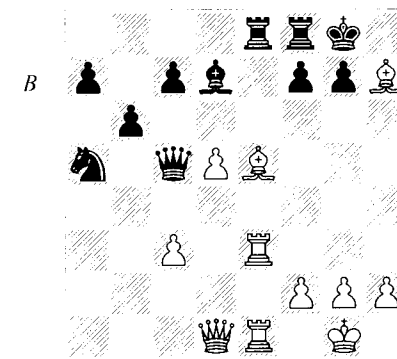
28...♖xd7 29 ♖xf5! 1-0

Black resigned since mate is imminent: 29...gxf5 (29...♖e2 30 ♖h6+ ♗g8 31 ♖g7#) 30 ♖g7#.

35) J. Polgar – Karpov

Hoogeveen 2003

25 ♗xh7+! (D)



The double bishop sacrifice exposes the black king to White's army.

25...♗xh7 26 ♖h5+ 1-0

Black resigned in view of 26...♗g8 27 ♗xg7! (the e3-rook is perfectly placed, ready to swing over to g3 to deliver mate) 27...♗xg7 (27...f5 28 ♗e5 ♖xe5 29 ♖g3#; 27...f6 28 ♗xf6 ♖xf6 29 ♖g3+ ♗f8 30 ♖h8+ ♗f7 31 ♖g7#) 28 ♖g3+ ♗f6 29 ♖g5#.

36) Ivanov – Tal

Latvia jr 1950

22 ♗xh7+!

A logical move if we compare the positioning of each army's pieces. The

white pieces are all lurking around Black's king, while Black's pieces are over on the queenside, far from their king.

22...♖xh7 23 ♖g5+ ♖g8

23...♖g6 24 ♖c2+ f5 25 exf6+ ♖xf6 26 ♖xc7 +.

24 ♖h5 ♖fe8 25 e6 1-0

Tal threw in the towel in view of the continuation **25...♖xf4 26 exf7+ ♖f8 27 ♖h7#**.

37) Abein – Zhukova

Dresden 2003

25...♖g3+!

Opening the a8-h1 diagonal.

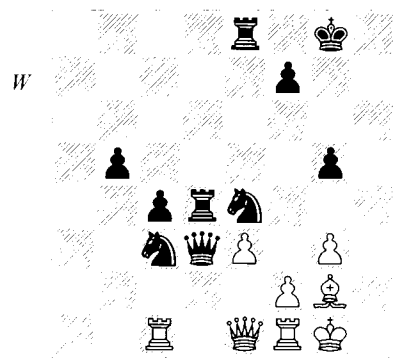
26 hxg3 ♖h3+! 0-1

White resigned due to **27 ♖g1 ♖c5+ 28 ♖f2 ♖xg2#**.

38) Kasimdzhanov – Kasparov

Batumi rpd 2001

27...♖xd4! (D)



The d4-knight was White's only good piece, so Black removes it.
28 exd4 ♖e2+ 29 ♖h2 ♖d2! 0-1

The big threat is **...♖h7+**. Possible continuations: **30 ♖c6 ♖e6 31 ♖d5 ♖f3+ -+; 30 ♖d5 ♖xf1+ 31 ♖xf1 g4 32 ♖g2 ♖h7 33 ♖h1 ♖h3+** and the ending is easily winning for Black.

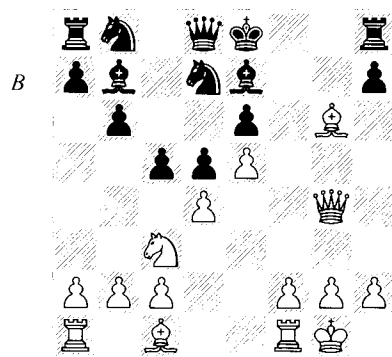
39) Zapata – An. Rodriguez

Santos 2003

10 ♖xe6!

A typical move in such positions and one that both colours should always keep an eye open for.

10...fxe6 11 ♖xg6+! (D)



The white bishops come into their own, striking out towards the black king.

11...hxg6 12 ♖xg6+ ♖f8 13 ♖h6+ ♖xh6 14 ♖xh6+ ♖f7 15 ♖h7+ ♖e8 16 ♖g6+ ♖f8

When playing such a combination it is always nice knowing that the perpetual check is in hand, as a bail-out option.

17 f4!

As soon as the f1-rook enters the game it is the end for Black.

17...♖e8 18 ♖h6+ ♖f7

18...♖g8 19 ♖f3.

19 ♖h7+ ♖f8 20 f5 +-

The game finished as follows:

20...♖f6 21 fxe6 ♖xe6 22 exf6 ♖f7 23 ♖h6+ ♖e8 24 ♖ae1+ ♖d8 25 ♖e7 1-0

40) G. Georgadze – Rolf

Senden 1995

1 ♖xh6! gxh6 2 ♖g6+

This theme is rather common and has occurred in many games. White's powerful light-squared bishop on c4 makes it all possible.

2...♖h8 3 ♖xh6+ ♖g8

3...♖h7 4 ♖xd6.

4 ♖g5

Bringing another piece over towards Black's king.

4...♖f4

Black tries to eliminate a white attacker; it is not clear what else he can do.

5 ♖ce4

Another piece heads the right way!

5...♖xg5 6 ♖xg5 ♖b6 7 ♖g6+ ♖h8 8 ♖xf7 1-0

Black resigned in view of ♖h6+.

41) Korchnoi – Rovner

Leningrad Ch 1957

26 ♖h5!

A lovely move. The idea is to control the f6- and g7-squares in anticipation of White's next move. **26 ♖g5!** is also strong; for example, **26...♖e6 27 ♖h5** gives White a large attack.

26...♖b4

Or:

a) After **26...♖e6 27 ♖g7** White wins the exchange and the game.

b) **26...gxh5 27 e6!** (**27 ♖g3+ ♖g4 28 hxg4 h4** is good for White but Black can struggle on) **27...♖xe6 28 ♖xe6 +-.**

27 e6! ♖xe6

27...fxe6 28 ♖e5 +-.

28 ♖xe6! fxe6 29 ♖e5

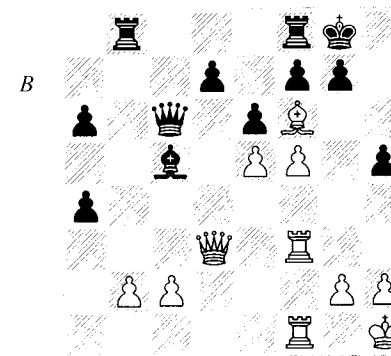
The knight on h5 shows its usefulness. If it were still on g3 then **...♖f6** would be possible.

29...♖f8 30 ♖xf8 +-.

42) Kasparov – Kengis

Riga 1995

20 ♖f6! (D)



Opening the g-file for White's rook and queen.

20...♖b5

Trying to swap the queens off. After **20...gxh6 21 ♖g3+ ♖h8** (**21...♖h7 22 fxe6+**) **22 ♖e2**. Black cannot prevent ♖xh5#.

21 ♖g3 g6

21...♖xd3 22 ♜xg7+ ♔h8 23 ♜g5+ ♔h7 24 ♜xh5+ ♔g8 25 ♜h8#.

22 ♜d1

Calm moves like this are always important to spot during combinations. White is effectively asking Black 'So what are you going to do now?', having worked out that Black has no defence.

22...exf5 23 ♜xf5

Not 23 ♜xh5?? ♜xf1#.

23...♞b6 24 ♜xh5 1-0

43) Cortlever – Donner

Beverwijk 1950

28 ♔xh6+!!

To gain the g5-square for the white knight. In the game, White missed his chance: he played 28 ♖c3? and the game was drawn in the end.

28...♞xh6 29 ♜f6+!

The real point behind 28 ♔xh6+.

29...♖xf6 30 exf6+ ♔h7 31 ♖g5+ ♔g8 32 ♞d8+ +-

The end is nigh.

44) Hartston – Penrose

London 1965

1 ♜xf7!

The first move that should be looked at! f7 was only defended by the king and with opposite-coloured bishops such aggressive moves need to be analysed.

1...♔xf7 2 ♔c4+ ♔f8

2...♔f6 3 ♜f1#.

3 ♜f1+ ♔f6 4 ♜xf6+

This is the move that needed to be seen when playing 1 ♜xf7. It should be the first move analysed, following

the rule: look at all checks and captures!

4...gxf6 5 ♜g8+ ♔e7 6 ♜e6+ ♔f8 7 ♜xf6+ ♜f7 8 ♜xf7#

45) Em. Lasker – Bauer

Amsterdam 1889

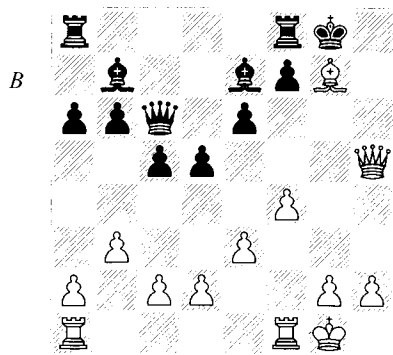
14 ♖h5! ♖xh5

Otherwise White captures on f6 and moves his queen to h5 with a winning attack; e.g., 14...♞fd8 15 ♖xf6+ ♔xf6 16 ♔xf6 gxf6 17 ♜g4+ ♔h8 18 ♔xh7! ♔xh7 19 ♞f3 +-.

15 ♔xh7+!

The real point of White's last move. White sacrifices both his bishops to open up the black king.

15...♔xh7 16 ♜xh5+ ♔g8 17 ♔xg7! (D)



The double bishop sacrifice! White gives up both bishops to mate the black king.

17...♔xg7

After 17...f5 18 ♔e5 +- the game will be over very soon, so Black has to accept the sacrifice.

18 ♜g4+ ♔h7 19 ♞f3 e5 20 ♞h3+ ♜h6 21 ♞xh6+ ♔xh6 22 ♜d7 +-

White wins another piece and with it the game.

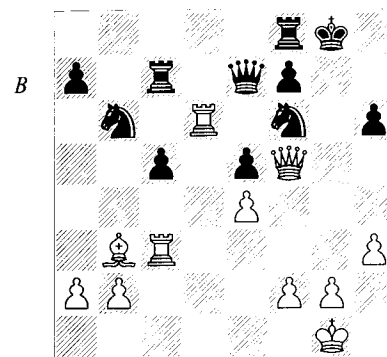
46) Av. Bykhovsky – Oltean

Berlin 1990

24 ♔xh6!

A common motif in such positions.

24...gxxh6 25 ♞d6! (D)



This is the most difficult move to spot. Now it's game over.

25...♖bd7

25...♜xd6 26 ♜g6+ ♔h8 27 ♜xh6+ ♖h7 (27...♔g8 28 ♞g3+ ♖g4 29 ♞xg4+ ♜g6 30 ♞xg6#) 28 ♜xd6 +-.

26 ♜g6+ ♔h8 27 ♜xh6+ ♖h7

27...♔g8 28 ♞g3+ +-.

28 ♞g3 1-0

Black resigned in view of 28...f6 29 ♞e6 ♜f7 30 ♞c6 and 28...♞g8 29 ♞xg8+ ♔xg8 30 ♞g6+.

47) Nimzowitsch – Rubinstein

Senmerring 1926

24 ♖g6+!

This move is natural when the king is lacking so many squares but it is the follow-up that is important.

24...♔xg6

24...hxg6 25 ♞h3#.

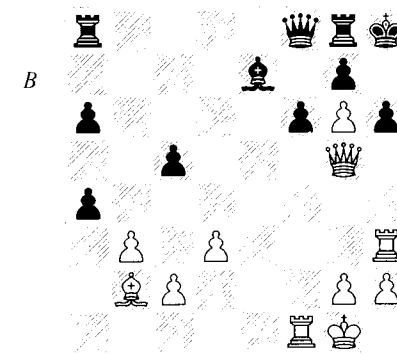
25 fxg6 h6

It looks like Black may have survived the worst, but White always has dangerous sacrifices on f6 and h6. Black is too passive to prevent this; for example, 25...♜xg6 26 ♜xg6 hxg6 27 ♞h3#.

26 ♞h3

26 ♔c1 is also worth considering, with the idea 26...axb3 27 ♔xh6 gxxh6 28 g7+ ♔h7 29 ♜f5+ ♜g6 30 ♜xg6#.

26...♜f8 27 ♜g5!! (D)



The trickiest move to spot. Now h6 and f6 are under too much pressure.

27...a3

Trying to throw a spanner in the works, but...

28 ♔xf6! ♔xf6 29 ♞xf6 a2

Or: 29...♜xf6 30 ♞xh6+ gxxh6 31 ♜xh6#; 29...gxf6 30 ♞xh6+ ♔g7 31 ♞h7#.

30 ♖xf8 a1 ♖+ 31 ♖f1 +-

White's next move is ♖xh6+, forcing mate.

48) Gormally – McShane

London 1997

27... ♖h3+!

After this the position simplifies, and Black reaches a won ending.

28 gxh3 gxh3+ 29 ♖h1 ♖g5 30 ♖xh4+

The only sensible way to avoid mate.

30... ♖xh4 ♢

Black is clearly in charge now.

31 ♖xh3

After 31 ♖xc8 ♖e4+! 32 f3 ♖d4 33 ♖xf8+ ♖g7 +- something big will be landing on g1.

31... ♖xh3 32 ♖xh3 ♖xc1+ 33 ♖xc1

Black went on to convert his advantage into victory. White resigned on move 40.

49) A. Fernandes – Santos

Portuguese Ch 1979

1... ♖xg2!

This combined with Black's next move brings the white king within Black's firing range.

2 ♖xg2 ♖xf2+!

At the cost of two pieces, Black gets a winning attack.

3 ♖xf2 ♖xh2+ 4 ♖e3

Or: 4 ♖f1 ♖f8+ +-; 4 ♖f3 ♖f8+ 5 ♖g4 (5 ♖e3 ♖f2+ 6 ♖d2 ♖f4+ 7 ♖c3 ♖c5#) 5... ♖c8+ 6 ♖g5 ♖h6#.

4... ♖e8+ 5 ♖e4

5 ♖d2 ♖h6+ 6 ♖c3 ♖b4+ 7 ♖d4 ♖e3#.

5... ♖f4+ 6 ♖f3

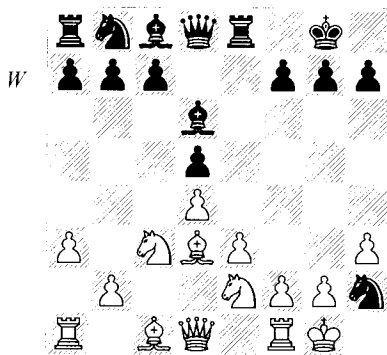
Or: 6 ♖d4 ♖xe4+! 7 dxe4 ♖f2+ 8 ♖c3 ♖c5#; 6 ♖xf4 ♖xc2 7 ♖e2 ♖xe4+ +-.

6... dxe4+ 7 dxe4 ♖xe2+ 8 ♖xe2 ♖g3# (0-1)

50) Van Wely – Acs

Hoogeveen 2002

10... ♖h2! (D)



A very interesting idea – the knight jumps straight into the white camp.

11 ♖e1

Otherwise Black just wins the exchange.

11... ♖f3+!!

The real point to the combination: the black knight sacrifices itself to open up the position of the white king. 11... ♖xh3?! is tempting but after 12 e4 White's pieces come to life while Black's are looking rather funny on the kingside.

12 gxf3 ♖g5+ 13 ♖h1

Not: 13 ♖f1?? ♖xh3#; 13 ♖g3? ♖xg3 14 e4 ♖f4+ +-.

13... ♖h4

13... ♖xh3?! is another interesting idea but the game continuation is stronger. Play might have continued 14 ♖g3 ♖h4 15 ♖ce2 ♖g4+ 16 ♖g2 ♖h3+ 17 ♖g1 ♖xf3, when Black has good compensation for the sacrificed piece. White's pieces are tied up while Black has a pair of good bishops and the strong idea of swinging the rook on e8 around to g6 or h6.

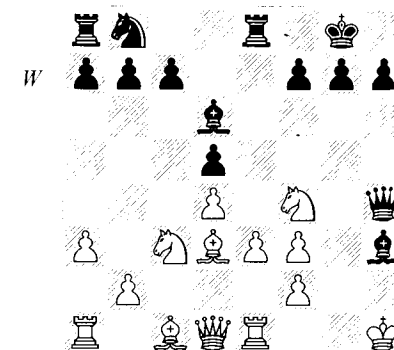
14 ♖f4?!

White should certainly avoid 14 f4? ♖xh3+ 15 ♖g1 ♖g4 +- , when the bishop finds a nice resting-place on f3.

White's other option is 14 ♖g1!?, when Black can obviously force a draw immediately with 14... ♖g5+, but let us see what happens if he tries for more: 14... ♖xh3 15 f4! (the only defence, so as to block out the d6-bishop) 15... ♖g4! 16 ♖b3 (this looks like the best square for the queen: it wants to capture on d5 where it will give the white king extra protection; not 16 ♖c2? ♖e6! 17 ♖g3 ♖h6 +-) 16... ♖f3 17 ♖g3 ♖xf4 18 ♖ce2 ♖d6 19 ♖xb7 ♖d7 ♢ and Black has the preferable game. His attack is much easier to

play. For a start the d7-knight is now ready to join the attack via f6 and g4.

14... ♖xh3 (D)



Black has a nice attack for the piece. It is not clear what White should play.

15 ♖xd5?!

Probably a bit greedy, but Black's position was already the easier to play as he had the simple plan of ... ♖e6 and ... ♖g6/h6.

15... ♖e6! +-

Bringing another piece into the attack. White's defensive task is too difficult now.

16 ♖xe6 ♖f5+! 17 ♖g1 ♖h2+ 18 ♖f1 ♖g3 0-1

White resigned as he cannot stop mate; for example, 19 fxg3 ♖h3#.

3 Strike in the Centre

In chess the centre is the most important part of the board. If a player has total control of this part of the board, he is often well on the way to victory. This is one reason why a player must always be alert to breaks in the centre.

I found this chapter the hardest to find examples for, as the first move will not necessarily win on the spot like most of the examples given in the other five chapters. Most of the puzzles given here are examples of thematic plans in action, where the first move may be obvious but the follow-up is not so clear. It is therefore more important for the reader in this chapter to analyse each position as deeply as possible; finding the first move will not normally be enough to solve the puzzles in this chapter.

The following game shows an example of a thematic break in the centre which helped White on his way to victory.

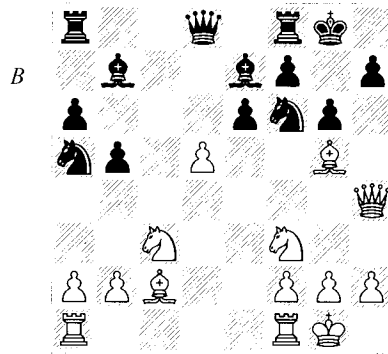
N. Pert – Ganguly

British Ch (Torquay) 2002

1 d4 d5 2 c4 dxc4 3 e3 ♘f6 4 ♙xc4 e6 5 ♘f3 c5 6 0-0 a6 7 ♙b3 cxd4 8 exd4 ♘c6 9 ♘c3 ♙e7 10 ♙g5 0-0 11 ♗d2 ♘a5 12 ♙c2 b5 13 ♗f4 ♙b7 14 ♗h4

Another game showing the power of the central strike was Tkachev-Le-siège, New Delhi (FIDE) 2000, which continued 14 ♖ad1 g6 15 ♙h6 ♘h5 16 ♗g4 f5 17 ♗h3 ♖c8 18 d5! ± and White was well on his way to victory.

14...g6 15 d5! (D)



This move performs several useful functions for White. It opens up the d-file for a white rook, and most importantly the coordination of the black pieces is severely impaired.

15...♙xd5 16 ♘e4 ♙xe4 17 ♙xe4 ♖a7 18 ♖ad1 ♘d5 19 ♗fe1 f6

For the sacrificed pawn White has serious pressure on the kingside and down the d- and e-files.

20 ♙h6 ♖e8?

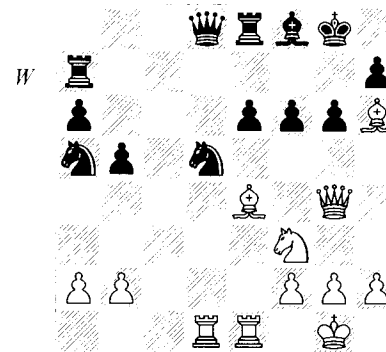
20...♖f7 is better but White has the advantage after 21 ♙b1.

21 ♗g4!

White is now winning.

21...♙f8 (D)

21...f5 22 ♙xf5 exf5 23 ♗d4 +.



22 ♙xg6! hxg6 23 ♗xg6+ ♙g7

23...♙h8 24 ♖xd5 +.

24 ♖xd5

The game finished as follows:

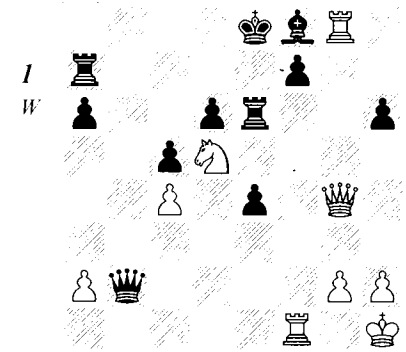
24...♗xd5 25 ♗xe8+ ♙h7 26 ♙xg7 ♖xg7 27 ♖c3!

The rook joins in!

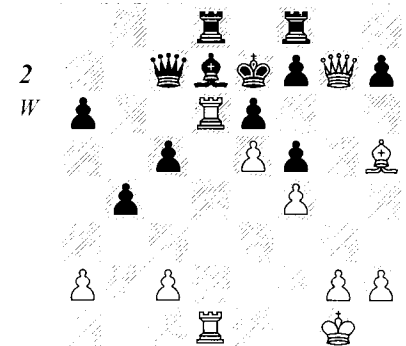
27...♘c4 28 ♘g5+! ♖xg5 29 ♗f7+ ♙h6 30 ♗xf6+ ♙h7 31 ♗f7+ 1-0

It is quite shocking how quickly Black's position fell apart after 15 d5!. This move worked because White's pieces were already perfectly placed while Black had weakened his kingside with 14...g6. Again common themes to watch out for.

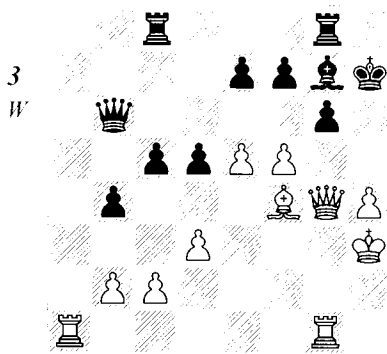
Puzzles



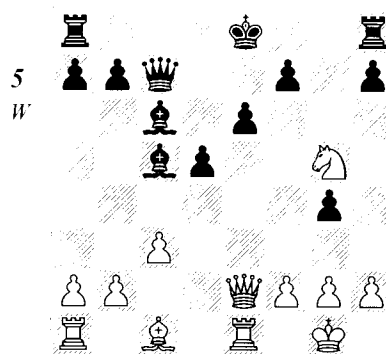
White's pieces are all taking part in the game while Black's are merely occupying space. How can White make the crucial breakthrough?



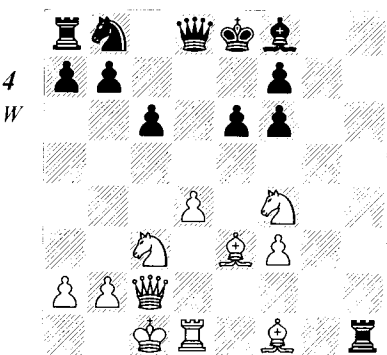
Black's position is very cramped while White's pieces are occupying great squares. It is no wonder then that White has a decisive breakthrough. What should he play?



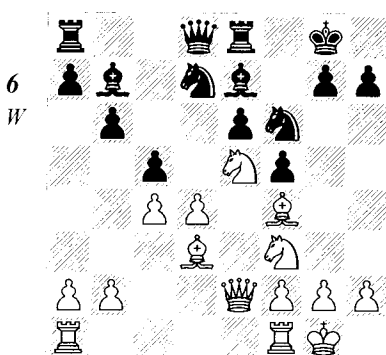
White's pieces are aggressively placed on the kingside while Black is rather cramped. What move would you play if you were White?



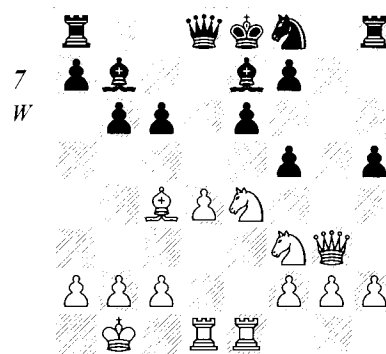
If it were Black to move then he would be fine after castling queenside, but unfortunately for him it is White to go first. What should White play?



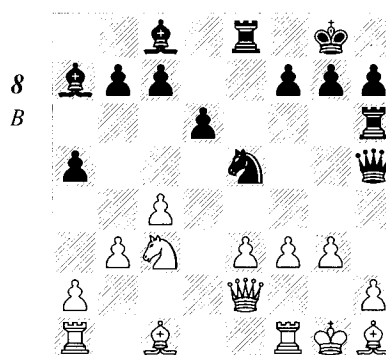
From White's perspective, the position needs to be opened up. White is well ahead in development and Black's king is stranded in the centre with little hope of escaping anywhere. What should White play?



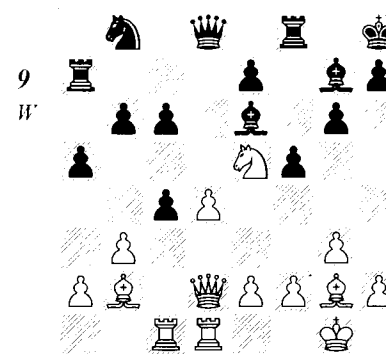
White is strong in the centre while Black has seriously weakened himself with the move ...f5. How did White force the win with the use of a very clever tactic?



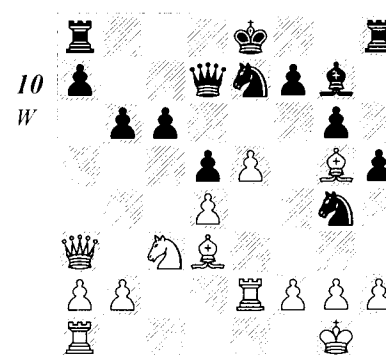
It would seem that White has to retreat his knight, when Black would have a chance to organize his position. However, White has a stronger option – what is it?



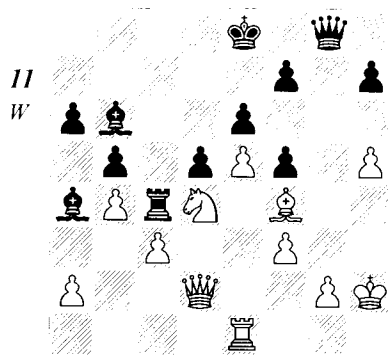
White's position is under considerable pressure from Black's well-placed pieces. After Black's next move White immediately resigned. What was this move?



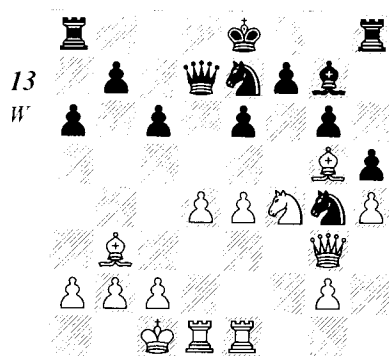
What should White play here, and how should he follow it up?



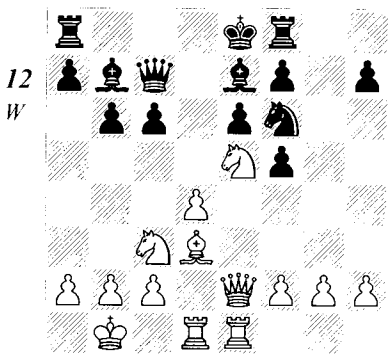
Black is in some difficulties here as he cannot castle because he would drop his e7-knight. White found a clever combination to force the win. What was it?



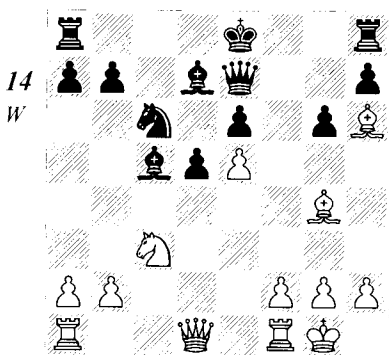
White has the more pleasant position. This is due to her better placed pieces, which control the centre, and Black's light-squared bishop which is stuck on a4. What would you play as White?



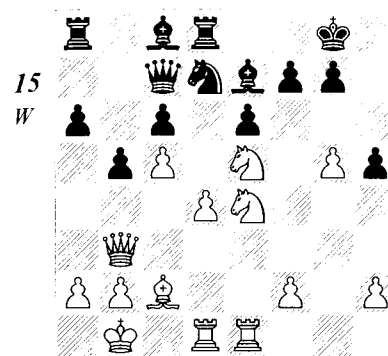
White's pieces are perfectly placed for a break in the centre. What should White play? Analyse the resulting position as deeply as possible.



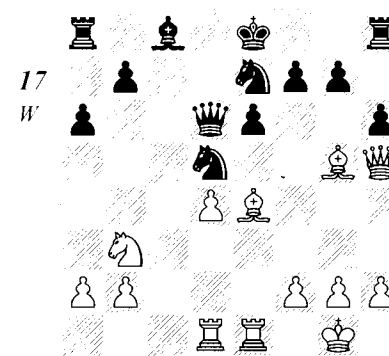
White's position is quite pleasant but Black wishes to castle, when he would not have any serious problems. How can White change the character of the position to his advantage?



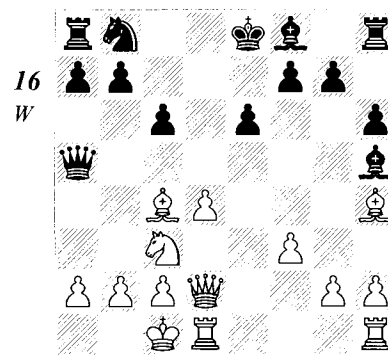
Black is finding it hard to find a safe haven for his king. How should White capitalize on this? Analyse the resulting position as deeply as possible.



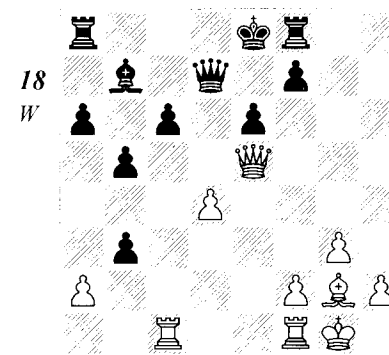
White is clearly in charge with domination of the centre of the board. How did White change his positional advantage into a tactical advantage?



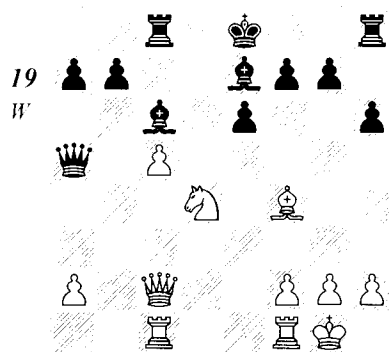
All of White's pieces are developed while Black's king is still stuck in the centre. How can White crash through before Black has time to castle?



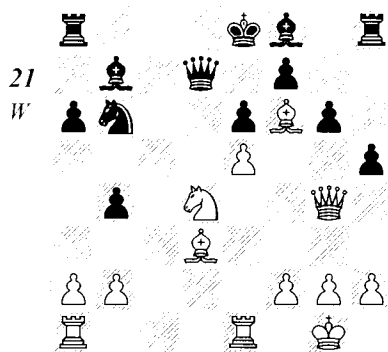
White is well ahead in development while Black's king is still a long way from castling. How should White use these factors to his advantage?



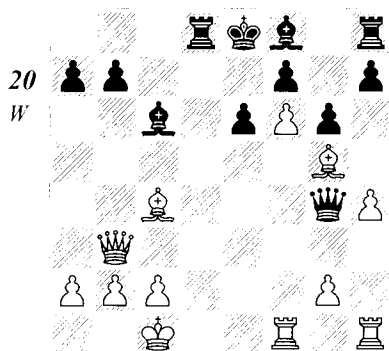
Black has just captured on b3. A normal response to this would be axb3, but does White have any other moves? Analyse White's other options and decide what move you would play.



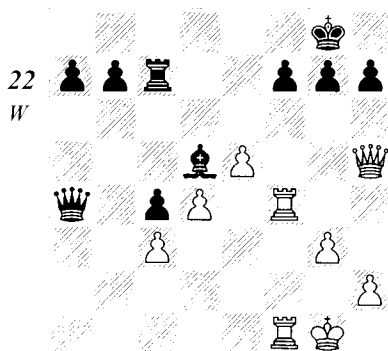
Black has just played 18...♖a8-c8, which is a serious mistake. He should have been thinking more about his king safety than pawn-structure. How did White punish Black for this mistake?



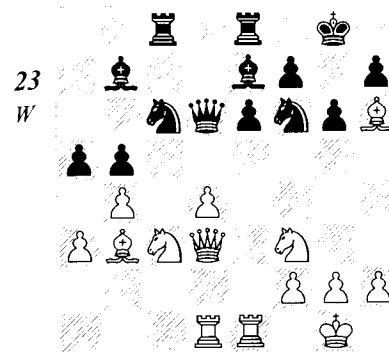
Black has played the opening very badly; White's bishop on f6 is an exceedingly annoying piece for Black. What is White's best move here?



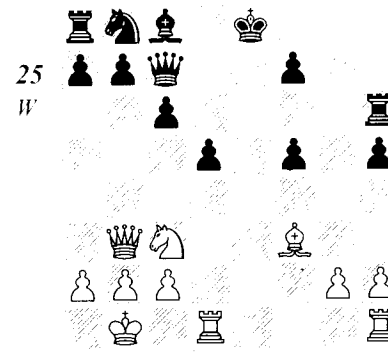
Black's king is looking rather sorry for itself. What should White play? Analyse until the end.



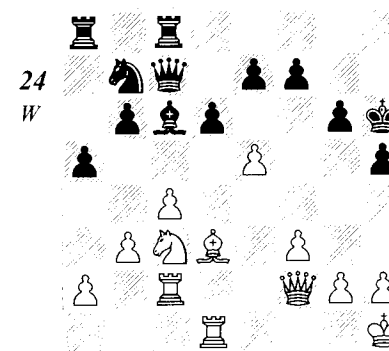
Black is trying to blockade the light squares with his bishop. How did White break through?



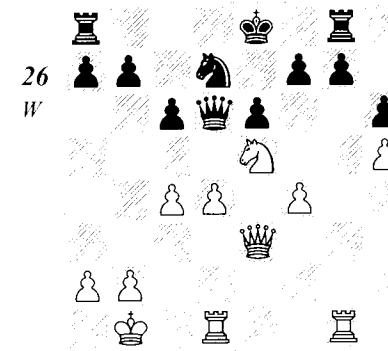
What is White's best plan here? And how should he put it into action?



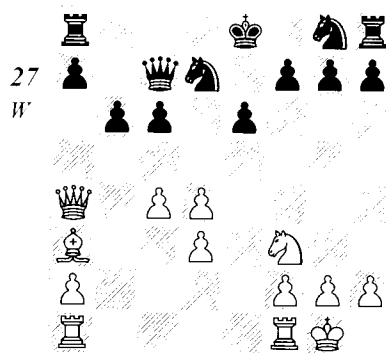
White sacrificed a pawn with d5 a couple of moves ago to reach the present position. White obviously has a lot of pressure, with his better development and the open black king. How did White now crash through?



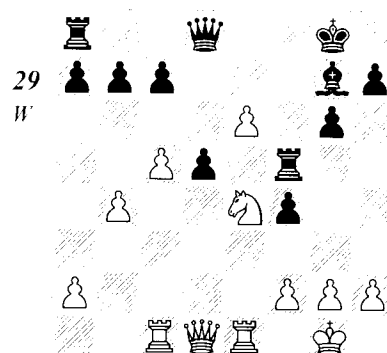
All of Black's pieces are sleeping on the queenside. On top of this his kingside has been weakened by the move ...h5. If you were playing White here, what would you do?



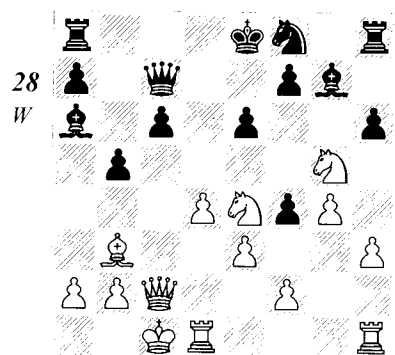
White felt that it was time to take some action in the centre with 25 d5. Assess the resulting variations and decide whether it is the move that you would play.



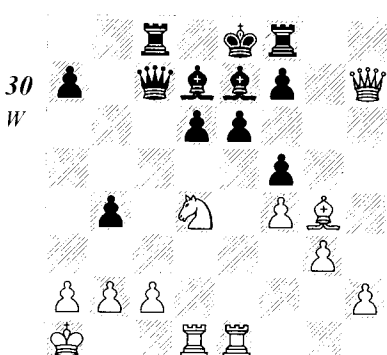
What is the best way for White to exploit his lead in development?



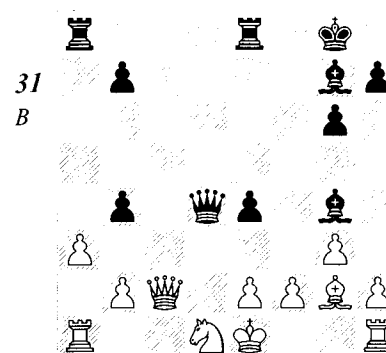
White's e6-pawn is clearly a menace to Black, but at the moment the pawn on its own will hardly cause too much damage to Black's position. How did White bring other forces to the aid of the pawn?



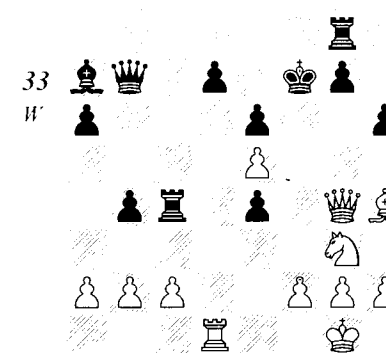
Black's position is a mess. There is no piece coordination and the black king is still stuck in the middle. It is no wonder therefore that White can break through. How should White proceed?



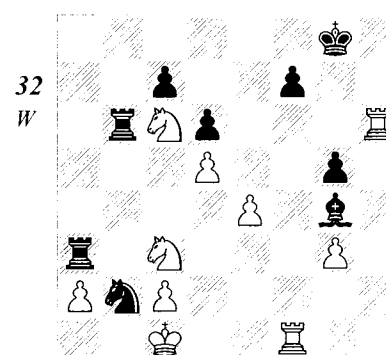
White's pieces are all ready for a breakthrough in the centre. What is that breakthrough? Analyse until the end.



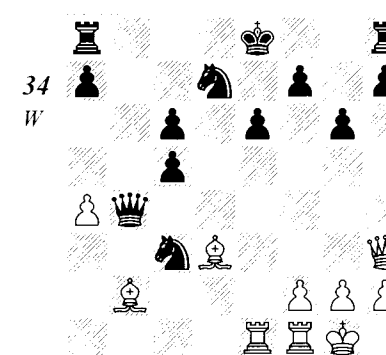
Black is a pawn down but has a nice initiative due to the two bishops, extra space, and pressure on White's queenside and centre. The e4-pawn is particularly annoying for White. What is the best plan for Black?



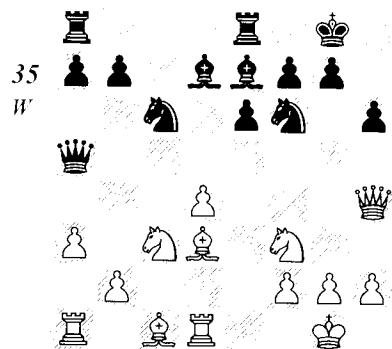
Black's king looks like it is reasonably protected but White's next move shows that this is an illusion. What did White play, and how should he follow up his attack?



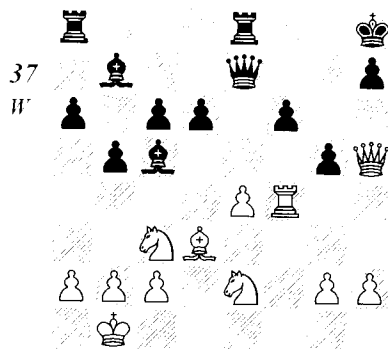
The position seems to be rather unclear. With White's next move though the situation dramatically changes. Black's king comes under threat and another trump appears in the position for White. What did he play?



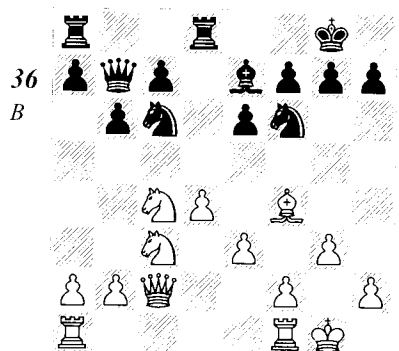
The black king is ready to castle; White would then find it hard to launch a successful attack against it. What should White play, and how should he follow up his attack?



White's pieces are all dangerously placed around Black's king. What should White play, and how should he follow it up?



White has sacrificed the exchange to reach this position. How can he prove that the sacrifice was right? Analyse as deeply as possible.



Black has managed to swap off White's light-squared bishop, which is White's strongest piece in such positions. How did Black use this factor to his advantage and obtain the better position via a combination?

Solutions

1) Firman – Lemmers

Bucharest 2003

32 ♖xe6+!

Forcing mate.

32...fxe6 33 ♜gxf8+ ♔d7 34 ♜f7+ 1-0

It is mate in a couple of moves; e.g., 34...♗c6 35 ♜c8+ ♜c7 36 ♜fxc7#.

2) Mos – Torok

corr. 1988

23 ♜xe6+!

Starting a forcing sequence which leads to a won position for White.

23...♙xe6 24 ♖f6+ ♗e8 25 ♖xe6+ ♗e7 26 ♖c6+ ♜d7 27 e6! 1-0

Black is paralysed by the pins.

3) Urban – Janak

Brno 1968

29 e6!

This move cuts across the black queen's defence of g6, while weakening the defensive pawn set-up which has been adopted by Black.

29...♙xb2 30 exf7 ♜h8

30...♜g7 31 ♖g5 gxf5 32 ♖h5+ ♖h6 33 ♖xh6#.

31 fxg6+ ♗g7 32 ♜ae1 +-

It is rather odd that the black pawns which were protecting the black king have now been swapped with white pawns!

32...♙f6 33 h5 ♜xh5+?

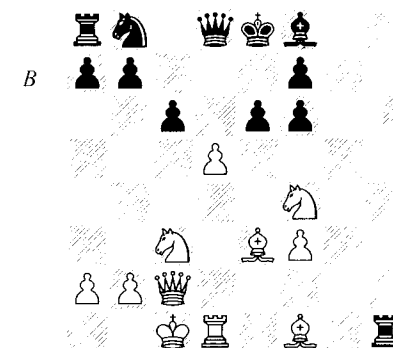
A bad move but the position was hopeless anyway.

34 ♖xh5 ♜h8 35 ♖xh8+ ♗xh8 36 f8♖# (1-0)

4) Henris – Potaux

Le Touquet 2002

15 d5! (D)



Natural and good.

15...♜xf1

Other moves are even worse; for example:

a) **15...cxd5? 16 ♙b5+ ♜c6 17 ♜xh1 +-.**

b) **15...exd5?! 16 ♜fxd5! cxd5 (or 16...♜d7 17 ♖e4+ +-) 17 ♙b5+ +-.**

16 ♜xf1 cxd5 17 ♜e1 ♙e7?

Black should try 17...d4 18 ♜d1 e5 19 ♜fd5!? (or 19 ♜cd5), when he has some chances to survive.

18 ♖h7 ♜d7? 19 ♜xe6! +- fxe6 20 ♖g6+ ♗f8 21 ♙h6# (1-0)

5) Mauro – Volkov

e-mail 2003

16 ♜xe6!

Correctly opening up the centre to get at Black's exposed king.

16...fxe6 17 ♖xe6+ 1-0

Possible finishes: 17...♙e7 18 ♙g5; 17...♙f8 18 ♙h6+; 17...♗e7 18 ♗xe7+ ♙e7 19 ♙g5 +–.

6) Alekhine (blindfold) – Feldt

Tarnopol 1916

15 ♖f7!

This move wraps things up.

15...♙xf7

Other moves also lose since White simply captures on e6 with his queen, threatening mate. 15...♙xf3 16 ♗xe6 ♖f8 allows a standard smothered mate after 17 ♖h6++ ♙h8 18 ♗g8+ ♖xg8 19 ♖f7#.

16 ♗xe6+!

An aesthetically pleasing move to play, but 16 ♖g5+ is just as strong, and similar to the game.

16...♙g6

Or 16...♙f8 (16...♙xe6 17 ♖g5#) 17 ♖g5, when Black has to give up most of his army to avoid being mated straight away: 17...♖e5 18 dxe5 ♙d5 19 cxd5 ♗xd5 20 ♖xh7+ ♖xh7 21 ♗xd5 and it is time to call it a day.

1-0

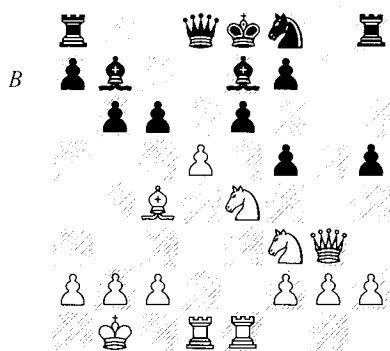
Black resigned without waiting for 17 g4! cxd4 (17...♙e4 18 ♖h4#) 18 ♙xf5#.

7) Kotov – Kalmanok

Moscow 1936

1 d5! (D)

White opens up the centre to attack the black king – a typical plan in such positions and one which we will see more of in this chapter.

**1...cxd5**

After 1...fxe4 2 dxe6 +– Black will either lose his queen or get mated on f7, while 1...exd5 allows 2 ♖f6#.

2 ♙b5+ ♖d7 3 ♖e5!

The speed with which the black position falls apart is rather surprising.

3...♗c7

3...♙c8 is also hopeless: 4 ♗g7 (4 ♖c6 wins the black queen) 4...♗f8 5 ♗xd5! (opening the e-file) 5...fxe4 (or 5...exd5 6 ♖f6+ ♙xf6 7 ♖xd7+ ♙e7 8 ♖f6#) 6 ♖xd7 exd5 7 ♖f6#.

4 ♙xd7+ ♙d8

4...♙f8 5 ♖g6+ +– costs Black his queen.

5 ♗g7 ♗f8 6 ♖g5 ♗c5 7 ♙xe6 1-0**8) Karolyi – Hector**

Copenhagen 1985

18...♖xc4! 0-1

Black will break through on e3; for example, 19 bxc4 (19 ♗xc4 ♗xh2#) 19...♗xe3! 20 ♙xe3 (20 ♗g2 ♗e1+ 21 ♗f2 ♗xh2#) 20...♙xe3+ 21 ♗xe3 (or 21 ♗f2 ♗xh2+ 22 ♙f1 ♗xh1#) 21...♗xh2#.

9) Wirthensohn – Lin Ta

Novi Sad OL 1990

17 d5!

A thematic break opening up the long diagonal.

17...cxd5

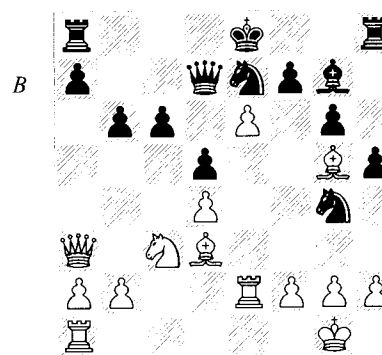
17...♙f7 18 ♗h6!! ♙g8 (18...♙xh6 19 ♖xf7+ ♙g8 20 ♖xh6#; 18...♙f6 19 dxc6 +–) 19 ♗xg7+ ♙xg7 20 ♖g4+ ♙g8 21 ♖h6#.

18 ♖xg6+ 1-0

Black resigned due to 18...♙g8 19 ♖xf8 or 18...hxg6 19 ♗h6+ ♙g8 20 ♗xg7#.

10) Penrose – Blau

Hastings 1957/8

18 e6! (D)

This move serves two functions: it weakens the g6-pawn and it gives White's e2-rook more scope.

18...fxe6 19 ♖xd5! ♖f5

Or: 19...♗xd5 20 ♗xe7#; 19...exd5 20 ♗xe7+ +–; 19...♖xd5 20 ♙xg6+ +–; 19...cxd5 20 ♙b5! ♖c6 21 ♙xc6 ♗xc6 22 ♗e7#.

20 ♙xf5 gxf5 21 ♗xe6+ ♗xe6 22 ♖c7+ 1-0**11) Xie Jun – Zhukova**

New Delhi FIDE wom 2000

37 ♖xf5!

Correctly sacrificing to open up the centre against Black's king, which is still lingering there.

37...exf5 38 e6!

Allowing the white rook to enter the game.

38...d4

38...fxe6 39 ♗xd5 +– is fatal; for example, 39...♗xf4 40 ♗xe6+ ♙f7 41 ♗d7+ ♙f8 42 ♗e8#.

39 exf7+ ♙xf7 40 ♗e2 ♙c7?

Black's position is hopeless but this speeds up the end.

41 ♗e7# (1-0)**12) Gdanski – Babula**

Odorheiu Secuiesc Z 1995

15 d5!

This move causes Black the most problems; White makes the best use of his centralized pieces.

15...♖e4?

Not the best defence. Others:

a) 15...cxd5? 16 ♙b5+ ♖d8 17 ♖xf7+! (ripping through the middle of Black's position) 17...♗xf7 18 ♗xe6 ♗f8 (18...♗g7 19 ♗xf6 +–) 19 ♖xd5 +–.

b) 15...♖xd5? 16 ♖xd5 and now:

b1) 16...cxd5 17 ♙b5+ ♖d8 18 ♖xf7+! ♗xf7 19 ♗xe6 ♗c8 (19...♗f8 20 ♖xd5+ +–; 19...♗g7 20 ♖xd5+ +–) 20 ♗xf7 +–.

b2) 16...exd5 17 ♖xf5 ±.

c) 15...exd5! is Black's only defence but White has a large advantage after 16 ♖xf5 ♙d8. Black will always have problems down the e-file.

16 ♖xe4

16 dxc6! +- is even stronger, when Black has to play 16...♙c8, with a horrible position.

16...fxe4 17 dxc6 ♖xc6 18 ♖xc6 ♙xc6 19 ♖xe4 +-.

White went on to win on move 31.

13) Sutovsky – Azmaiparashvili

Moscow rpd 2002

20 d5!

This destroys Black's position.

20...cxd5

20...e5 21 ♖e6! (opening up the d-file for White's rook) 21...fxe6 22 dxe6 ♙c8 (22...♙c7 23 ♙d7 +-) 23 ♖xe7 ♖xe7 24 ♙d7+ +- ♖f8 (24...♖f6 25 ♙f3#) 25 ♙f3+ ♖f6 26 ♙f1 and 27 ♙xg7 is next.

21 exd5 e5

21...♖f5? doesn't help matters: 22 dxe6! ♙xd1+ 23 ♙xd1 ♖xg3 24 exf7+ ♖f8 25 ♖xg6#.

22 ♖xe7 ♙xe7?

A better attempt is 22...♖xe7 23 d6+ ♖f8 24 ♖h3 ±, although White holds a nice advantage due to the d-pawn and weakened black king.

23 d6 ♙d8?

Black was in trouble anyway but 23...♙d7 puts up sterner resistance: 24 ♙c3 ♙c8 25 ♖xf7+!? ♖xf7 26 ♙b3+ ±.

24 ♖xf7+! 1-0

Black resigned owing to 24...♖xf7 25 ♙b3+ ♖f8 (25...♖f6 26 ♙e6#) 26 ♖xg6+ ♖e8 27 ♙e6+ ♙e7 28 ♙xe7#.

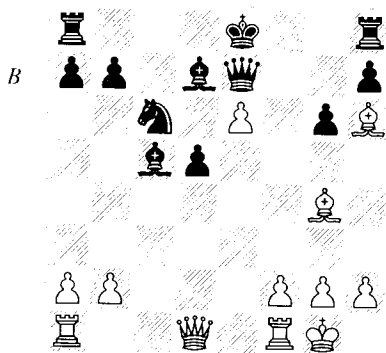
14) F. Rayner – S. Williams

Hastings Challengers 1999/00

15 ♖xd5!

Opening up the centre and the black king.

15...exd5 16 e6! (D)



This pawn will become a major thorn in Black's side.

16...♖c8

A horrible move to play, but it is forced. 16...♖xe6 does not help matters; for example, 17 ♖xe6 ♙xe6 18 ♙e1 ♖e5 19 ♖g7! ♖xf2+ 20 ♖xf2 ♙f7+ 21 ♖g1 ♙xg7 22 ♙xd5 +-..

17 ♙xd5

When playing a sacrifice such as this, it is close to impossible for a human player to work out all the lines to the end – White is playing on instinct here. This instinct serves him well: Black's king will always be a target while White has plenty of open lines

to attack on. The e6-pawn is also a monster. Basically White has plenty of play for the invested material.

17...♙h4

Possibly better is 17...♖d6 18 ♙ac1! ♙c7, though White can play the simple 19 g3 or 19 ♖f3 with the threat of 20 ♙xc6!, while 19...♖xh2+ is met by 20 ♖h1 ♙b8 21 ♙fe1! and e7 is coming.

18 ♙xc5 ♙xh6

18...♙xg4 19 ♙fe1 ♙h4 and now both 20 ♖g5 and 20 ♖g7!? leave White well on top.

19 ♙fe1?!

White should play 19 ♖f3! ±; for example, 19...♖d8 20 ♙b5+ ♖e7 21 ♙b4+! ♖e8 22 e7 +-..

After 19 ♙fe1?! White maintained pressure throughout the rest of the game and eventually won on move 30. Defending such positions is always more difficult than attacking them, so if given the choice, attack!

15) Burgess – Bank Friis

Bellinge 1991

19 ♖xf7!

The start of an attractive combination which works because Black is so cramped and weak on the light squares.

19...♖xf7 20 ♙xe6+! ♖xe6

20...♖f8 21 ♖b3 +-..

21 ♖d6+ ♖e5

21...♖d5 22 ♖b3#.

22 ♖f5+

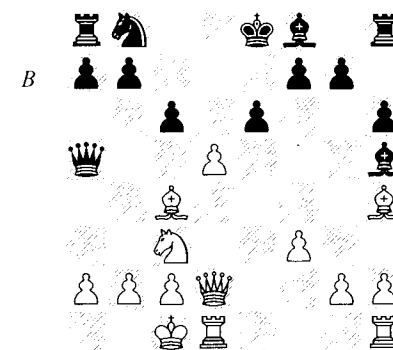
22 ♙xe5+ also leads to mate after 22...♖d7 23 ♖f5#.

22...♖d5 23 ♙xe5# (1-0)

16) Čabrilo – Kostić

Bela Crkva 1996

1 d5! (D)



Opening up lines to the black king. Such a move should be one of the first things that is looked at in positions like this.

1...♖b4

Others:

a) 1...cxd5 2 ♖xd5! (or 2 ♖xd5!) 2...♙xd2+ 3 ♙xd2 (even without the queens Black is still in mortal danger) 3...exd5 4 ♖b5+ ♖c6 (4...♖d7 5 ♙e1+ +-) 5 ♙e1+ ♖d7 6 ♙xd5+ ♖c7 7 ♙xh5 +-. White is a safe pawn up with the bishop-pair and more active pieces.

b) Trying to block the bishop's route with 1...g5 does not help either as White just keeps playing in the centre with 2 dxe6! gxf4 3 exf7+ ♖xf7 4 ♙he1+ ♖e7 5 ♙xe7+ ♖xe7 6 ♙d6+ ♖e8 7 ♙e1+ +-..

2 dxc6!

2 dxe6 also wins, even though it allows Black to castle: after 2...0-0 3 e7 White will win a piece.

2...♗xc6

Black cannot castle now: 2...0-0 3 ♖xb7 +.

3 ♖d7+ ♕f8 4 ♖xb7 +

17) Geller – Suetin

Moscow 1981

17 ♗xe7! ♗xe7 18 d5!

A thematic move in isolated queen's pawn positions. The d-pawn is used to open the centre to White's advantage.

18...exd5

After 18...e5 19 ♗b1! ± White wins the black e5-pawn, while 18...0-0 19 dxe6 ♖xc6 20 ♗h7+ ± is also quite tasty for White.

19 ♗xd5 ♖f6

19...♗g6 allows White a nice finish: 20 ♗xf7+! (check and a capture!) 20...♗xf7 (20...♗xf7 21 ♖d8+ ♗xd8 22 ♖xf7 +-) 21 ♖xe7+ ♗xe7 22 ♖xg6 +.

20 ♗xf7+! 1-0

Due to 20...♗xf7 21 ♖d8+ ♗xd8 22 ♖xf7 +.

18) Züger – Markus

Bad Ragaz 1991

25 d5!

White opens up the centre, in particular the d-file, to his advantage. This plan is so effective because the black king is stuck in the centre.

25...♗c8

The only move, 25...cxd5? 26 ♖c7 +-; 25...f6? 26 ♖h5+ (or 26 dxc6!) 26...♗f7 27 ♖xf7+ ♖xf7 28 dxc6 ♗c8 29 axb3 +.

26 dxe6 fxe6

Again the only move (not 26...♖xe6 27 ♖c5 +-).

27 axb3

This recapture gives White an advantage, but there are other interesting options: 27 ♗e4 ± or 27 ♖cd1!? ± ♗e7 28 axb3 and White now has the added bonus of the open d-file.

27...♖f5 28 ♖e3 ±

Black's king is always under threat from White's pieces. White went on to win on move 35.

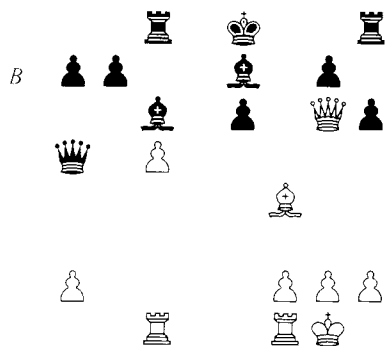
19) B. Goldstein – H. Meyer

corr. 1964

19 ♗xe6!

Natural and good.

19...fxe6 20 ♖g6+ (D)



20...♗d7?

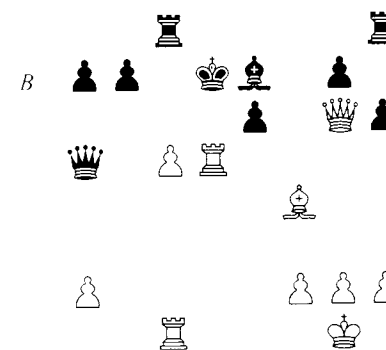
20...♗d8? also loses: 21 ♖fd1+ ♗d5 22 ♖xe6 +.

Black's only chance was 20...♗f8! 21 ♗e5 ♗f6! (21...♗g8? allows 22 ♖c4! +, when White's rook entering the attack signals the end for Black) 22 ♗xf6 and then:

a) 22...gxf6? 23 ♖xf6+ ♗g8 and now the decisive move is 24 ♖c4! +.

b) The only defence is 22...♗c7!, when White holds just a small advantage.

21 ♖fd1+ ♗d5 22 ♖xd5+! (D)



Black is lost after this.

22...exd5 23 ♖f5+ ♗c6

23...♗e8 24 ♖xc8+ and 23...♗d8 24 ♖xd5+ ♗e8 25 ♖h5+ ♗f8 (or 25...♗d8 26 ♖d1+) 26 ♖f5+ ♗g8 27 ♖xc8+ win for White.

24 ♖e6+ ♗d6

Desperate. 24...♗b5 25 ♖b1+ ♖b4 (25...♗a4 26 ♖xd5 +-; 25...♗c4 26 ♖e2+ +-; 25...♗xc5 26 ♖xe7+ ♗c4 27 ♖e2+ ♗d4 28 ♗e5+ ♗c5 29 ♖c2+ ♖c3 30 ♖xc3#) 26 ♖d7+ ♗a5 27 ♗c7+ ♖xc7 28 ♖xc7+ ♗a4 29 ♖xb4+ +.

25 ♖xd6+ ♗b5 26 ♖xd5 +

26 a4+! is also winning: for example, 26...♖xa4 (26...♖xa4 27 ♖a1+ 27 ♖d7+ ♖c6 28 ♖xb7+, etc.

26...♗a6 27 ♖b1 b6 28 ♖d3+ ♗b7 29 ♖d7+ ♗a6 30 c6 1-0

20) Svidler – R. Scherbakov

Russian Ch (Krasnoyarsk) 2003

20 ♗xe6!

Quite a simple move to find because White needs to open up lines towards the black king.

20...fxe6

After 20...♖xc6, 21 ♖e1 +- is terminal.

21 ♖f4!

The queen needs to be moved away from g4. 21 f7+ ♗d7 22 ♖f4 is an equivalent option for White.

21...♖e2 22 f7+ ♗d7 23 ♖d4+

23 ♖d1+ ♗d6 24 ♖fd4 transposes to the game.

23...♗d6

Otherwise d8 drops. 23...♗d5 24 ♖xb7+ ♗d6 is hopeless for Black.

24 ♖hd1

The most thematic way to finish Black off – another white piece enters the attack. Also good are 24 ♖xd6+ and 24 ♗xd8.

24...♗d5

After 24...♗c7 White exchanges everything off, starting with 25 ♗xd8+ ♖xd8 26 ♖xd6 ♖xd6 27 ♖xd6 ♖f1+ 28 ♖d1 ♖xf7 +.

25 ♖xd5!

The final straw.

25...exd5 26 ♖xb7+ 1-0

White has a forced mate: 26...♗e6 27 ♖xd5+ ♗d7 28 ♖xd6+ ♗c8 29 ♖c6+ ♗b8 30 ♗f4+, etc.

21) Flumbort – Gonda

Budapest 2002

19 ♖xe6+!

Simplifying the position. White picks up Black's rook for his troubles.

19...fxe6

19...♖xe6 20 ♜xe6 +–.

20 ♙xg6+ ♜f7 21 ♙xf7+ ♜xf7 22 ♙xh8 +–

White won on move 33.

22) Kasparov – Hjorth

Dortmund jr Wch 1980

22 e6!

Opening up lines for the white rooks.

22...♙xe6 23 d5! ♖b5

Or: 23...♙c5 24 ♙xf7! +–; 23...g6 24 ♖h4 +–.

24 ♙h4 ♖c5+ 25 ♙f2 ♙xd5

25...♖xd5 26 ♖xh7+ ♜f8 27 ♙d4 +–.

26 ♙d4

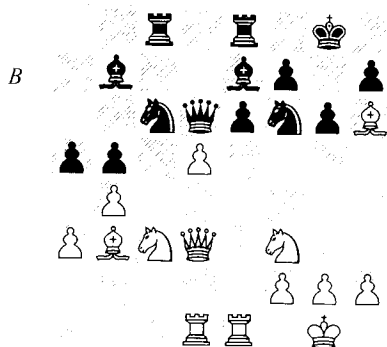
26 ♖xh7+ ♜f8 27 ♖h8+ ♜e7 28 ♖xg7 is also good.

26...♙d7 27 ♙f5! 1-0

23) H. Olafsson – Thorhallsson

Reykjavik 1995

18 d5! (D)



This thematic central break practically gives White a winning position. Taking the b5-pawn is not so clear: 18 ♜xb5? ♖b8 leaves White's queenside hanging, while 18 ♖xb5? ♜xb4 is also unclear.

18...exd5 19 ♙xd5

All of a sudden White's pieces jump to life.

19...♙xd5 20 ♙xd5 ±

The big threat is 21 ♙xf7+, which Black will find hard to stop. It is worth noting again how strong White's light-squared bishop becomes after d5 is played. The game now finished:

20...♙d8?!

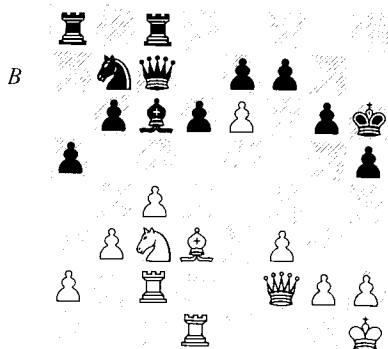
Or: 20...♖f6 21 ♙g5; 20...axb4 21 ♙xf7+! ♜xf7 22 ♖b3+ +–.

21 ♖d4 ♙f8 22 ♙xe8 +– ♙e6 23 ♙xf8+ ♙xf8 1-0

24) Sundararajan – Saravanan

Indian Ch (Mumbai) 2003

27 e6! (D)



The idea of this move is to weaken Black's kingside pawn-structure even

more – especially Black's g6-pawn, which is the base of his defence.

27...f5

A serious concession. Now g6 is very weak while White's e6-pawn is very annoying for Black. Other moves:

a) 27...fxe6 28 ♖e3+ ♜h7 29 ♖xe6 ♙g8 30 ♙e2 ♙g7 31 ♖h3 +–.

b) 27...♙c5 28 exf7 ♙xd3 29 ♙xd3 ♜g7 30 ♖d4+ ♜xf7 31 ♙e2 gives White an overpowering position.

28 ♖e3+ ♜h7 29 ♙xf5!

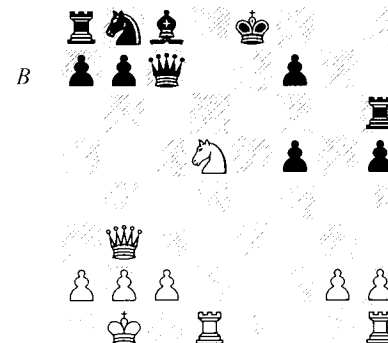
After this move Black's kingside falls apart.

29...gxf5 30 ♖g5 +– ♙h8 31 ♙d5 ♙xd5 32 ♖xf5+ ♜h6 33 ♖f4+ ♜h7 34 ♖f7+ ♜h6 35 ♙xd5 1-0

25) La Rosa – F. Müller

corr. 1987

17 ♙xd5! cxd5 18 ♙xd5 (D)



18...♖c6?

Better is 18...♖c5! 19 ♖g3! ♜f8! (other moves lose: e.g., 19...♙g6 20 ♖e5+ ♜f8 21 ♖h8+ ♙g8 22 ♖h6+ ♙g7 23 ♙f6 +–) 20 ♙c7, although

White has the advantage. A possible line is 20...♙g6 21 ♖f4 ♙c6 22 ♙d5 ♖e7 23 ♙xa8 ♙xg2 24 ♙hd1 ♙e6 25 ♙5d2 ±.

19 ♖g3

White can also win with 19 ♖b4 ♙e6 (or 19...♖d6 20 ♙he1+ ♜f8 21 ♖xd6+ ♙xd6 22 ♙c7) 20 ♙he1 ♖xd5 21 ♙xd5.

19...♙g6 20 ♙c7+ +– ♜e7

20...♜f8 21 ♙d8+ ♜e7 22 ♖h4+ ♙f6 23 ♙xc8 +–.

21 ♖a3+ 1-0

Black resigned because of 21...♙d6 22 ♙b5 +–.

26) Khalifman – Seirawan

Amsterdam (Donner mem) 1995

25 d5!

This is the correct move. White holds a steady advantage in all lines.

25...cxd5

Others:

a) 25...♖c5 26 ♙d4! ♙xe5 27 dxe6 fxe6 28 ♙d8+ ♙xd8 29 ♖xc5 ±.

b) 25...♙xe5 26 fxe5 ♖b4 (not 26...♖d7? losing to 27 d6, when 28 ♖xh6 is a nasty threat) and now 27 dxc6 ± leaves White with a nice advantage, as does 27 d6 ♖xc4 28 ♖f3 ±.

26 ♙xd7 ♖xd7

26...♜xd7 tries to improve the king's location, but it is still a target in the middle. 27 cxd5 exd5 and then:

a) 28 ♖h3+!? is interesting, with the following line in mind: 28...♜e8 29 ♙ge1+ ♜f8 30 ♙d5! ♖b4 (not 30...♖xf4? 31 ♖a3+ +–) and White has good compensation for the pawn.

b) 28 ♖f3 and then:

b1) 28...♗e8 29 ♖ge1+ ±.

b2) 28...♗c6 29 ♖c1+ (29 ♖d4 ± is also good) 29...♗d7 (29...♗b5 is asking for trouble) 30 ♖gd1 +–.

b3) 28...♗c7 29 ♖xd5 ±.

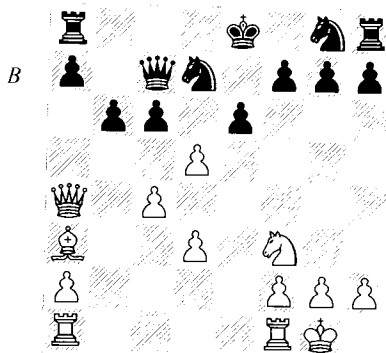
27 cxd5 ± ♖d8 28 f5 e5 29 ♖xe5+ ♗e7 30 ♖d4 +–

White won on move 38.

27) Browne – Braskot

US Open 1973

14 d5! (D)



Of course! White opens up the centre for his rooks. It is worth noting how powerful the a3-bishop is, cutting right across Black's position.

14...b5

Others:

a) 14...cxd5 15 cxd5 +– gives White the c-file as well as the e-file, and the win should not be far off.

b) 14...exd5 15 ♖fe1+ ♗d8 16 ♗d4! c5 17 ♗c6+ ♗c8 18 cxd5 ±.

c) 14...c5 15 ♖fe1 ±.

15 cxb5

This is OK but possibly better is 15 ♖b4!? c5 16 ♖xb5 ±, when Black is in all sorts of trouble; for example, 16...♗e7 17 dxe6 fxe6 18 ♗g5.

15...cxd5 16 ♖ac1 ±

White went on to win on move 26. The main problem in Black's position is actually his king, as castling is impossible due to White's strong bishop.

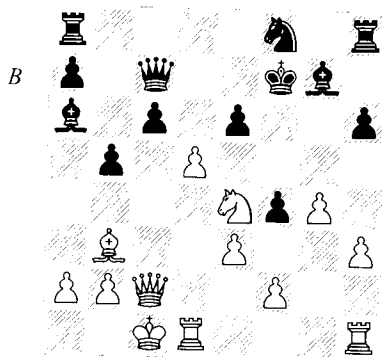
28) Hodgson – A. Martin

British Ch (Plymouth) 1992

16 ♗xf7! ♗xf7

16...♖xf7? 17 ♗d6+ +–.

17 d5! (D)



The most difficult move to spot. White opens up the centre even more.

17...♗e5

Others:

a) 17...exd5? 18 ♖xd5 +–.

b) 17...♗c8? 18 ♗d6+! ♗g8 19 ♗xc8 ♖xc8 20 dxe6 ♗e7 21 ♖d7! +–.

c) The shocking move 17...♗xb2+! seems to be Black's best chance. Play might continue 18 ♗xb2 (18 ♖xb2?! allows 18...cxd5+ 19 ♗b1 ♗d7, when

Black has chances: 18 ♗b1!? ♗e5 ± is interesting and probably very good for White; the position is similar to the actual game but with no b2-pawn, and this difference is rather insignificant) 18...♖e5+ 19 ♗b1 cxd5 is unclear; maybe White can try 20 ♖xd5!? exd5 21 exf4 ♖xf4 (21...♖xe4 22 ♖xe4) 22 ♗xd5+ with a messy position.

18 dxe6+ ♗g7

The only square for the black king. 18...♗e8 19 e7! (the pawn is on a mission!) 19...♖xe7 (19...♗xe7 20 ♖c5+ +– ♗e8 21 ♗f6+! ♗xf6 22 ♖h5+ ♗e7 23 ♖f7#) 20 ♖xc6+ +–.

19 ♖c5 ♗c8

19...♖h7 is a better attempt, trying to run to h8 with the king, but Black's position is still busted after 20 g5 – White's position is overwhelming, and Black has no constructive moves. Play might continue 20...h5 21 ♗f6! ♗xf6 22 gxf6+ ♗xf6 23 ♖d6 +–.

20 ♖d7+! 1-0

White mates after 20...♗xd7 21 ♖e7+ ♗g6 22 ♖f7#.

29) Pelletier – Gormally

Hastings 1996/7

20 ♗d6!

Bringing a pawn to d6 as well! The two connected passed pawns will be too much for Black to handle.

20...cxd6

The only move.

21 e7 ♖d7

21...♖e8 22 cxd6 is an improved version of the game for White.

22 cxd6 f3

22...♖e8 is Black's most natural defence but he is still lost after 23 ♖c7 ♖xd6 24 ♖a4! ♗f7 25 ♖xe8+ ♗xe8 26 ♖c8+ ♗d7 27 e8♖#.

23 ♖c7 ♖xd6 24 e8♖+ ♖xe8 25 ♖xe8+ ♗f8 26 ♖xb7 +–.

30) Tal – Klamann

USSR Ch (Moscow) 1957

23 ♗xf5!

Correctly sacrificing a piece to open the e-file.

23...exf5 24 ♖xe7+!

All of a sudden the black king has no piece- or pawn-cover on the e-file.

24...♗xe7 25 ♖e1+ ♗d8

25...♗e6 26 ♗xe6 +–.

26 ♖h4+ f6 27 ♖h6 ♖a5 28 ♗b3!

The hardest move to spot. Capturing on f8 is actually poor: 28 ♖xf8+? ♗c7 29 ♖xf6? (29 ♖e7? ♖e8 30 ♗e6+ ♗c8 31 ♖xd6 b3! +–; 29 ♗b3 is best) 29...b3! +–.

28...♖d5 29 ♖xf8+ ♗c7 30 ♖xf6 +–

White is two pawns up and went on to win on move 34.

31) Tatai – Karpov

Las Palmas 1977

23...♖d3!

This shocking little move leads to a decisive breakthrough in the centre.

24 exd3

Others:

a) 24 ♗e3? ♖xc2 25 ♗xc2 ♗xb2 +–.

b) 24 ♖c1 bxa3 is also winning for Black.

c) 24 ♖d2! is the best defence but Black still holds a nice edge after 24...♙xd2+ 25 ♖xd2 ♖ad8+ 26 ♖e1 ♙f3!? 27 ♖g1 ♙xg2 28 ♖xg2 ♖c8, coming to c2.

d) 24 ♙xd3 exd3 25 e3 d2+! gives Black the initiative: 26 ♖xd2 ♖ed8+ 27 ♖e1 (after 27 ♖c2?! ♖ac8+ 28 ♖b3 bxa3 ♠ Black's rooks and bishops co-ordinate perfectly together) 27...bxa3.

24...exd3+ 25 ♖d2

25 ♖e3 dxc2 ♠.

25...♖e2+!

A nice way to finish the game.

26 ♖xd3 ♖d8+ 27 ♖c4 ♖xc2+ 28 ♖xb4 ♖cd2 29 f3 ♙f8+ 30 ♖a5 ♙d7 0-1

32) E. Berg – Mannion

Hastings Challengers 2001/2

27 e5!!

Breaking through the centre at the cost of a piece.

27...♖xc3 28 e6!

The real point: the e-pawn quickly becomes a major trump for White and Black's king is all of a sudden open to attack.

28...♙f3

The only way Black can stop immediate disaster. Other lines show how much danger the black king is under: e.g., 28...fxe6 29 ♖e7+ ♖g7 30 ♖g6+ ♖h8 31 ♖h1+ ♙h3 32 ♖xh3#.

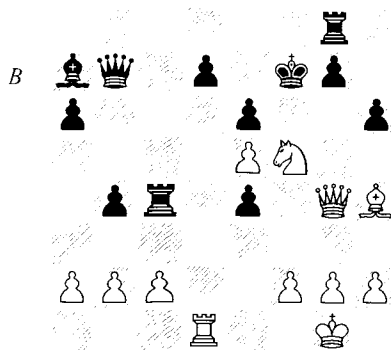
29 e7 ♖e3 30 ♖xf3 ♖e2 31 ♖e6! 1-0

Black resigned due to 31...♖xe6 32 dxe6 and White's e-pawn will queen – a triumph for the e-pawn!

33) Plaskett – Bischoff

Hastings 2000/1

25 ♖f5! (D)



The e6-pawn was doing a good job of protecting some crucial squares, so White tries to remove it, even at the cost of a piece.

25...♙c5

25...exf5 26 ♙xf5+ ♖e8 27 ♙g6+ ♖f8 28 e6 +- and it will be checkmate very soon.

26 ♙h5+ ♖f8 27 ♖d6!

So as to invade on the dark squares. 28 ♙e7# is one nasty idea.

27...exf5

Other moves do not help:

a) 27...♙xd6 28 ♖xd6 g6 (the only way to stop mate on f7 but...) 29 ♙xh6+ ♖g7 30 ♙h8+ ♖g8 31 ♙f6#.

b) 27...♖h8 (to try to run the king to h7) 28 ♙e7+ ♖g8 29 ♙g6 exf5 30 ♙f6 ♖h7 31 ♙e8#.

28 ♙xf5+ ♖e8 29 e6!

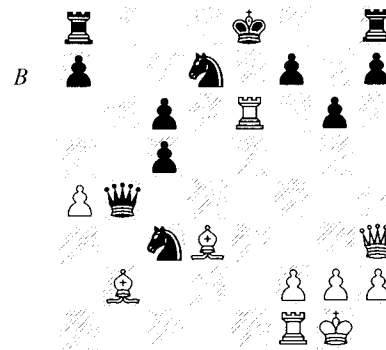
The e-pawn is used as a strong attacking force.

29...♙xf2+ 30 ♙xf2 1-0

34) Greenfeld – Beider

Israel 1995

1 ♖xe6+! (D)



Forcing the black king to move.

1...♖f8

Or: 1...fxe6? 2 ♙xc3 ♙xc3 3 ♙xg6+ +-; 1...♙d8? 2 ♖d6 +-.

2 ♙c1!

Trying to manoeuvre the bishop to h6 where it will be a constant pain to the black king.

2...h5

Stopping White's intended plan but he has another way to blast his way through. The alternative is 2...fxe6 3 ♙xe6:

a) 3...h5 4 ♙xg6 +-.

b) 3...♖g7 4 ♙e7+ ♖g8 5 ♙h6!.

c) 3...♙h4 4 ♙xd7 ♖e8 (4...♖d8 5 ♙h6+ +-; 4...♙e7 5 ♙h6+ ♖f7 6 ♙c4+ ♖d5 7 ♙xc6 +-) 5 g3 (diverting the black queen so that one of White's bishops can enter the attack) 5...♙h5 6 ♙c4 +-.

3 ♙xg6!

Opening the black king up.

3...♖c4

Capturing either white piece leads to mate:

a) 3...fxe6 4 ♙xe6 +-.

b) 3...fxg6 4 ♙f3+ ♖g7 (4...♖g8 5 ♖xg6+ ♖h7 6 ♙f7#) 5 ♖e7+ ♖g8 6 ♙f7#.

4 ♙xf7!

The final straw for Black.

4...♙g4

4...♖xf7 5 ♙f5+ ♖g7 6 ♖g6+ ♖h7 7 ♙xh5#.

5 ♙xc3 ♖xf7 6 ♖e3 1-0

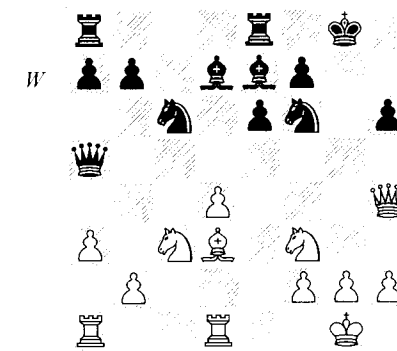
35) Gipslis – Puskeits

Berlin 1995

16 ♙xh6!

A logical sacrifice with White's light-squared bishop on the b1-h7 diagonal.

16...gxf6 (D)



17 d5!!

A tricky move to spot. White gains time for his attack through this central break.

17...♖xd5

17...exd5 18 ♖xh6 (now that the black pawn is on d5, the defensive move ...♖h5 is no longer possible) 18...♗e4 (otherwise White increases the pressure on Black's king with ♗g5) 19 ♗xe4 dxe4 20 ♙xe4 ♙f5 (20...f5 21 ♙d5+ +-) 21 b4 ♖b5 22 a4 +-.

18 ♖xh6 ♗f6 19 ♗g5

White was aiming for this position. The attacking combination of queen, knight and bishop is unstoppable.

19...♗e5

Desperately trying to cover the king-side but White can force a win.

20 ♙h7+ ♖h8

20...♗xh7 21 ♖xh7+ ♖f8 22 ♖h8#.

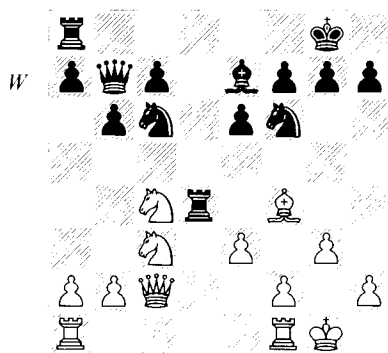
21 ♙g6+ ♖g8 22 ♙xf7+! ♗xf7 23 ♖g6+ 1-0

It will be mate next move: 23...♖h8 24 ♗xf7#; 23...♖f8 24 ♖xf7#.

36) Belavenets – Botvinnik

Leningrad – Moscow 1934

14...♙xd4! (D)



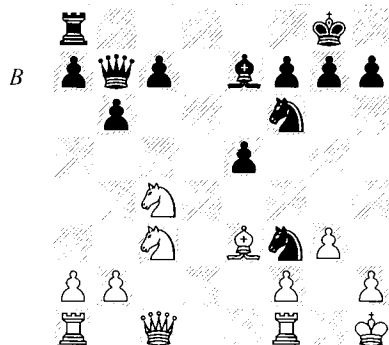
Black's knight seeks to occupy the f3-square! Attempts to win White's

f4-bishop are unsuccessful; for example, 14...♗d5?! (with the idea of playing ...g5 trapping White's bishop) 15 ♖e4 (after 15 ♗xd5 exd5 16 ♗d2 g5 17 ♙ac1 White's pressure on the c-file holds his position together) 15...g5 (consistent) 16 ♙xg5! ♙xg5 17 ♖g4 h6 18 f4 f5 19 ♖h5 and if anyone has the advantage it is White. Black has weakened his king too much.

15 exd4 ♗xd4 16 ♖c1

16 ♖a4 also leaves White in trouble: 16...♗f3+ (16...♗d5!? leads to unclear play) 17 ♖h1 (not 17 ♖g2?? ♗e1+ 18 ♖h3 ♖g2+ 19 ♖h4 ♗f3#) 17...e5 (Black does not have to rush as White has a lack of options) 18 ♙e3 a6! ♖. White is struggling for any decent moves while Black can slowly apply pressure to White's position.

16...♗f3+ 17 ♖h1 e5 18 ♙e3 (D)



18...♗g4?!

Black should play a move such as 18...h5 or 18...♙d8, slowly building up the pressure on White's position.

White has no constructive plans and is therefore in trouble despite being a rook up.

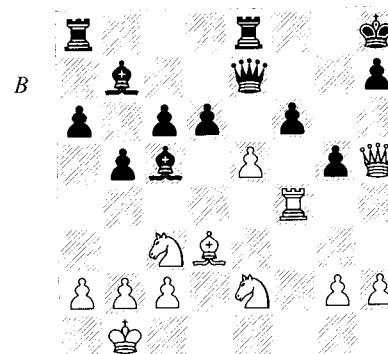
19 ♖c2 ♗d2+ 20 ♖g1 ♗xc4 ♖

Black still holds an edge but the position has lost a lot of its tension, which was in Black's favour. The game was drawn on move 40.

37) Zeziulkin – Hudecek

Litomysl 1994

1 e5! (D)



Opening up the diagonal for White's light-squared bishop. The weak point in Black's position is the h7-pawn.

1...dxe5

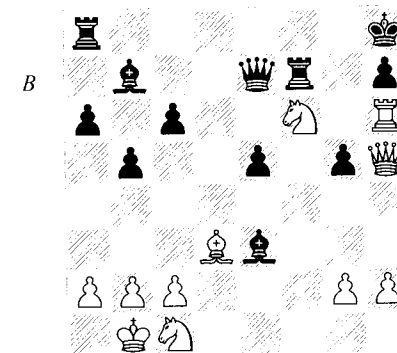
The only move. Others: 1...fxe5?? 2 ♙f7; 1...gxf4 2 exf6 ♖c7 3 f7! +-.

2 ♙xf6 ♙f8 3 ♙h6 ♙f1+ 4 ♗c1 ♙f7 5 ♗e4!

Another advantage of 1 e5! The e4-square is vacant so the white knight can use it as a base for joining the attack on the black king.

5...♙e3 6 ♗f6 (D)

Black's defence is now very awkward; another idea is 6 ♗d6!?, when White has the better of it after 6...♙af8 7 ♗xf7+ ♙xf7 8 ♙xh7+! ♙xh7 9 ♙xh7 ♖xh7 10 ♖e8+ ♖g7 11 ♖xe5+ ♖g6 12 ♖xe3.



6...e4

6...g4! is a better move. Play may continue 7 ♙xh7+ ♙xh7 8 ♗xh7 ♖g8, when White is better but Black has some chances to hold.

7 ♙xe4 g4 8 ♙xh7+ ♙xh7 9 ♗xh7 +- ♖g7? 10 ♗g5+ ♖g8 11 ♙h7+ 1-0

Black resigned as he will lose his queen after White's next move.

4 Time is Everything!

Time (as in tempi) is one of the most important aspects of chess. This is shown by the way world-class players play with the white pieces and the black pieces. In general a grandmaster will try to win with White but with Black he will be satisfied with the draw, and this difference is due to one tempo. The player with White has the advantage of the first move.

One tempo often changes the result of a game. Wouldn't it be nice to reach a critical part of the game and then play two moves in a row? Obviously it would, but then the game would not be chess!

When attacking, it is important to waste as little time as possible, because any time wasted will allow your opponent to find more defensive resources. Often this means ignoring material and just charging on forwards with the attack – in other words playing as aggressively as possible. A quick warning though: such a playing style is 'all-in' and there is no going back; also it can seriously damage your health. The next game is a brilliant example of aggressive play at its best. Yusupov, desperately needing a win, throws caution and material to the wind. Although his play may not have been objectively correct, his bravery was richly rewarded.

Ivanchuk – Yusupov
Brussels Ct rpd (9) 1991

1 c4 e5 2 g3 d6 3 ♘g2 g6 4 d4 ♘d7 5 ♘c3 ♘g7 6 ♗f3 ♗gf6 7 0-0 0-0 8 ♖c2 ♞e8 9 ♜d1 c6 10 b3 ♞e7 11 ♙a3 e4 12 ♗g5 e3 13 f4 ♗f8 14 b4 ♙f5 15 ♞b3 h6 16 ♗f3 ♗g4 17 b5 g5 18 bxc6 bxc6 19 ♗e5!?

A very risky policy as Black gets a big attack on the kingside. The game is now a race: will White win on the queenside or will Black win on the kingside?

19...gxf4 20 ♗xc6 ♞g5

Only one way to go – and that is towards the white king!

21 ♙xd6 ♗g6 22 ♗d5 ♞h5

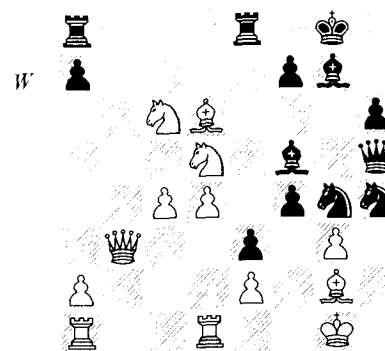
22...fxg3 23 ♙xg3 ♗h4 is another possibility.

23 h4 ♗xb4?! (D)

In such situations material is not the most important aspect but time is. Objectively though, Black should play 23...fxg3 24 ♙xg3 ♗xb4 25 ♗f4 ♞g5 26 ♗h3 ♞f6!, when he has a large attack. Yusupov missed this last move, and thought that he had nothing better than a draw by 26...♞h5 27 ♗f4 ♞g5.

24 gxf4 ♞xh4 25 ♗de7+?

This looks like the wrong knight to check with but it is always hard to



defend such positions over the board – another benefit of being the attacker! The critical line is 25 ♗de7+! ♗h8 26 ♗xf5 ♞h2+ 27 ♗f1 ♙e5!?: Black sacrifices material to get a rook to g8. Then 28 ♙xe5+? ♞xe5 29 dxe5 ♞g8 (with the threat 30...♞h1+ 31 ♙xh1 ♗h2+ 32 ♗e1 ♞g1#) 30 ♗dx3? (30 ♗g7!) 30...fxe3 31 ♗xe3 ♞f4+ 32 ♙f3 ♗xe3+ 33 ♗e1 ♞g1+ 34 ♗f2 (34 ♗d2 ♞d4+ 35 ♞d3 ♗xc4+ followed by 36...♞b2#) 34...♗g4+ 35 ♗xg1 ♞h2+ 36 ♗f1 ♞f2# is a nice line. However, 28 dxe5! should win:

a) 28...♞g8 29 ♗dxe3! (the e3-pawn must be removed) 29...♗xe3 30 ♗xe3 fxe3 31 ♞b7! and Black has run out of ideas.

b) 28...f3 29 exf3 e2+ 30 ♗xe2 ♞xg2+ 31 ♗d3 ♞xf3+ 32 ♗de3 +-. White's pieces are doing a good job of protecting the king.

25...♗h8 26 ♗xf5 ♞h2+ 27 ♗f1 ♞e6

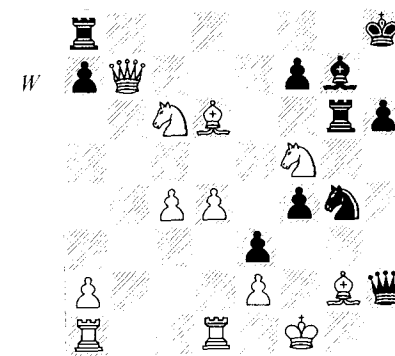
To bring the rook around to g6 where it can take part in the attack. You should always be thinking about

which pieces are sitting idle and how to improve their positioning.

28 ♞b7

White gets greedy, but the position was already difficult; for example, 28 ♞b5 ♞g6 29 ♞d5 ♞h1+!! 30 ♙xh1 ♗h2+ 31 ♗e1 ♞g1#.

28...♞g6!! (D)



A brilliant move, giving up a rook to gain time.

29 ♞xa8+ ♗h7

The threat is 30...♞h1+ 31 ♙xh1 ♗h2+ 32 ♗e1 ♞g1#.

30 ♞g8+!

The only try.

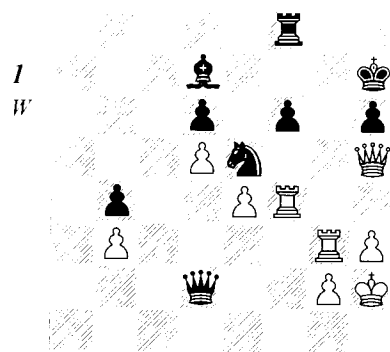
30...♗xg8 31 ♗ce7+ ♗h7 32 ♗xg6 fxf6 33 ♗xg7 ♗f2!!

Another brilliant move. The idea is ...♗h3, with unstoppable mate threats.

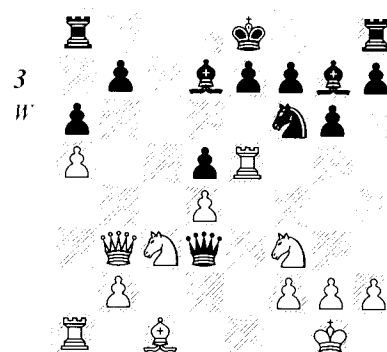
34 ♙xf4 ♞xf4 35 ♗e6 ♞h2 36 ♞db1 ♗h3 37 ♞b7+ ♗g8 38 ♞b8+ ♞xb8 39 ♙xh3 ♞g3 0-1

A powerful game and one of my personal favourites. Black just powered on towards White's king, giving little consideration to material.

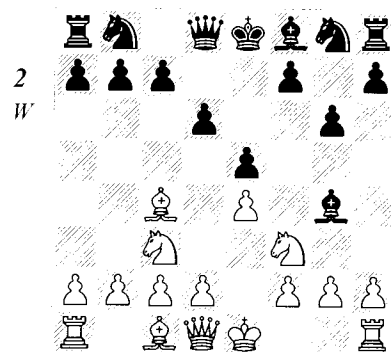
Puzzles



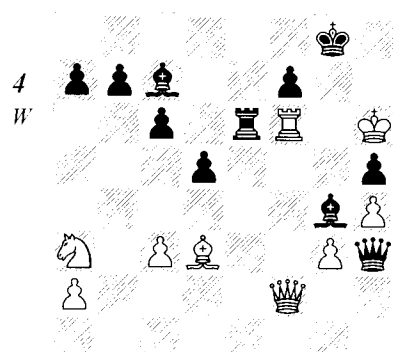
Black has just moved his queen to d2 so that after 38 ♖h4 the h6-pawn will be defended. White had other plans in store for Black though. What did White play?



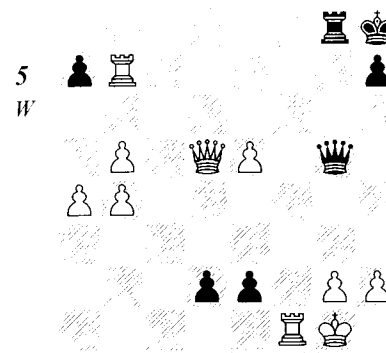
If Black is given time then he will be able to play ...e6 and castle, when he will have no problems. How can White cut across this plan?



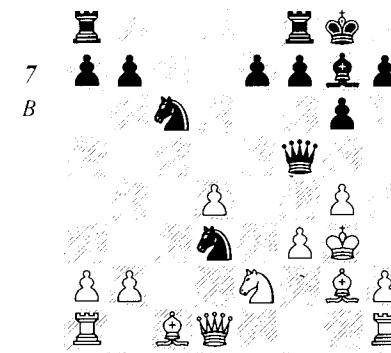
Black has wasted a lot of time in the opening playing pawn moves. How can White capitalize on this?



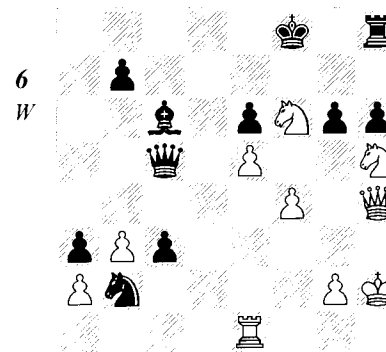
Black has just played 28...♗e5-e6, which was a mistake. White has a surprising move which would have turned the tables in his favour. White's king, rather than being weak, would have helped in the attack. What is the move that White missed in the game?



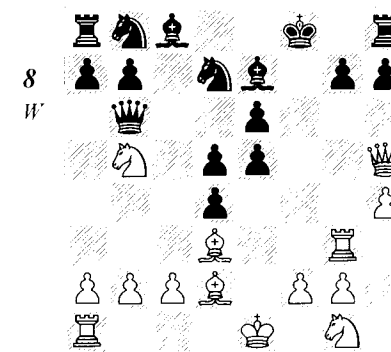
An amusing position. It seems that White is in trouble as Black's pawns look extremely strong on d2 and e2. White thought otherwise, as his next move showed. What did he play?



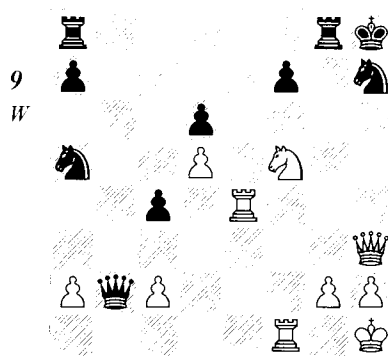
It seems that Black's only move is 16...♗b5, when White has time to organize a defence, but with White's king in such a compromising position it is no surprise that Black has a much stronger plan. What is it?



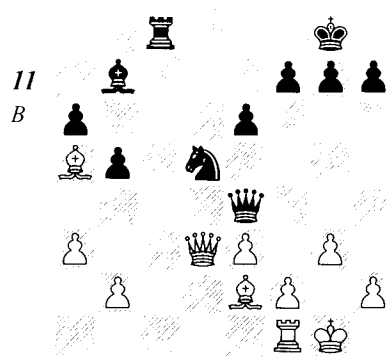
White has three pieces attacking Black's lonely king so it is no wonder that he can force mate. How?



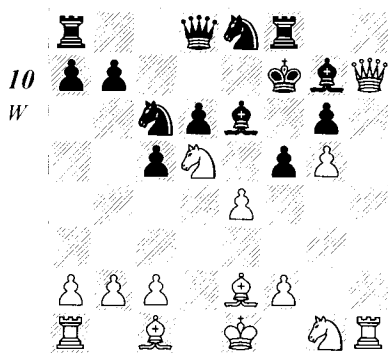
White has the initiative on the king-side but if Black is given time then he will be able to play ...e4, when his position would be fine. White found two brilliant moves that forced Black to resign. What combination did White play?



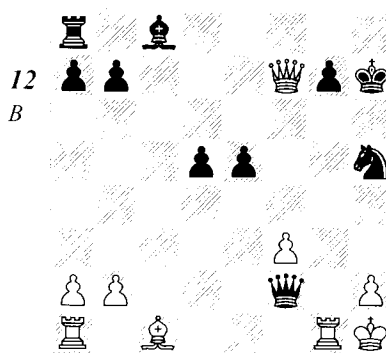
White is clearly in the driving seat with a nice cluster of pieces staring down at Black's king. 24 ♖h4 looks good but Black can struggle on with 24...♗g7. There is a better move for White. What is it?



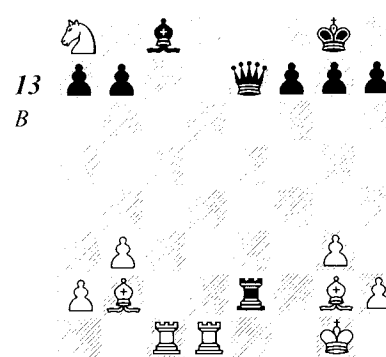
The a8-h1 diagonal looks very scary for White but if the black queen has to move off it, White should be able to consolidate. How can Black use the move to great effect?



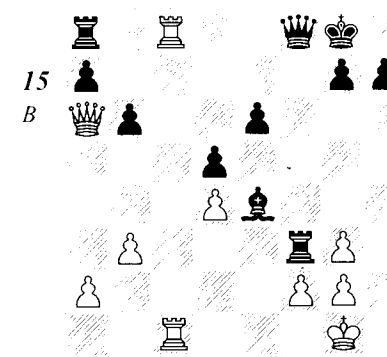
What is the best way that White can exploit the shaky position of the black king?



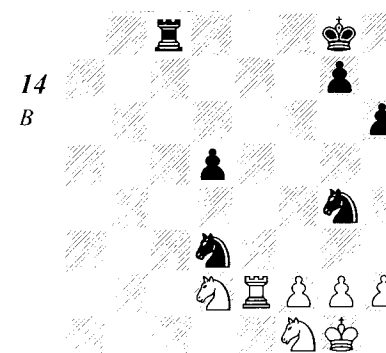
Black has two pieces still left on the sidelines, the light-squared bishop and the a8-rook. What should Black play?



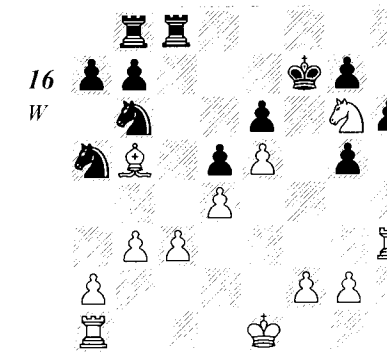
There are some dangerous factors in this position for White: the active rook on e2 and the weakened white kingside. What should Black play?



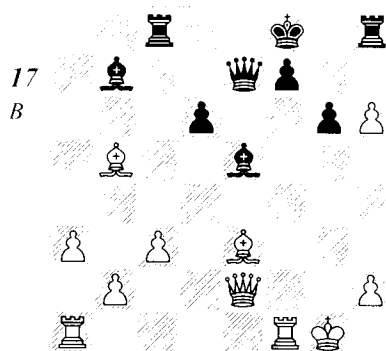
It looks like Black is in trouble as he will lose his queen, but Black had foreseen all this and had a strong, natural reply at his disposal. What did Black play?



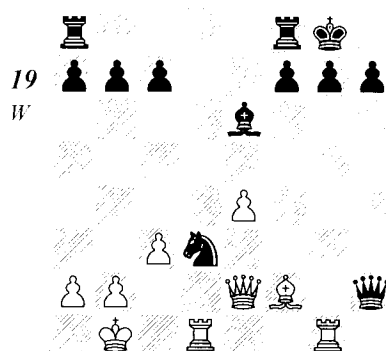
White has just played ♗e1-e2, which was an awful blunder, on which Black failed to capitalize. The white rook is lacking squares and the black knights are very active. What should Black play?



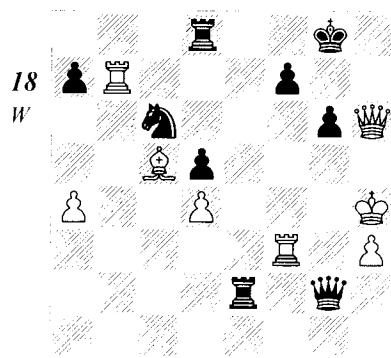
White seems to have got himself into a muddle as his knight is trapped and 21 ♗d3 allows 21...♖xc3. However, White had foreseen this position in advance, and now forced the win with powerful play. How?



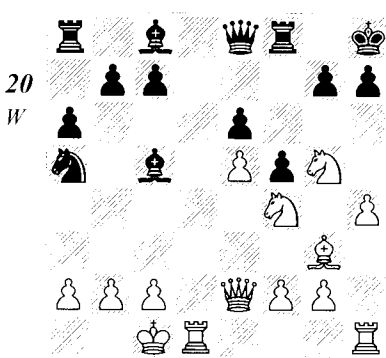
Black's bishops are very strong, both placed on open diagonals pointing towards the white king. Given time though White may be able to consolidate. How should Black continue?



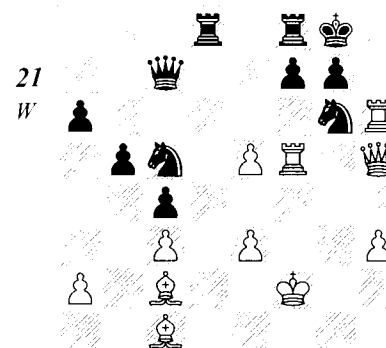
Black has just played 20...♘e5xd3. This was a very bad move as the knight was doing a good blocking job on e5. Does White have to recapture the knight or does he have a better move?



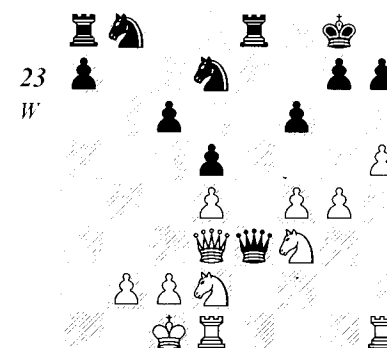
When one first looks at this position it would seem that White's king is the more exposed. White had other ideas and forced checkmate with a neat little move. What was it?



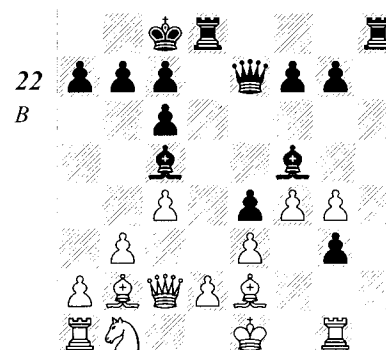
White would love to get his queen involved in the attack. How can he achieve this?



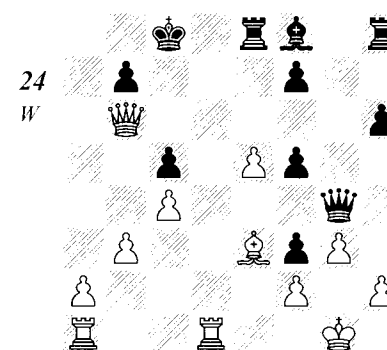
A unique position: the white rook has somehow managed to find its way to h6. How should White finish the attack off?



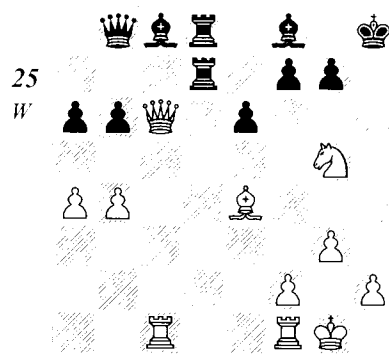
Black has just played 22...♗e7-e3, which is asking for trouble along the e-file. However, 23 ♖he1 ♗xd3 24 ♖xe8+ ♘f7 25 cxd3 ♘xe8 doesn't lead to anything for White. Can White make an improvement somewhere down this line?



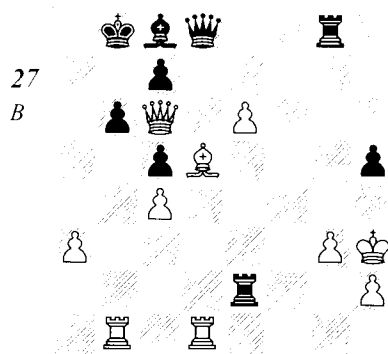
White's army is in a state of disarray. How should Black continue? Analyse until the end.



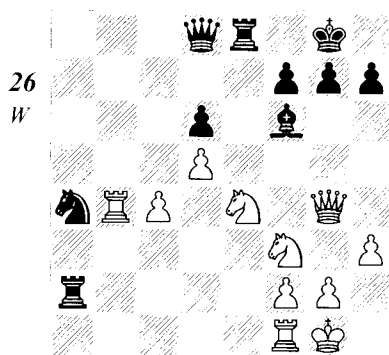
If it were Black to move then ...♗h3 would be decisive, but White had carefully analysed the position and calculated that she was winning. What is the win?



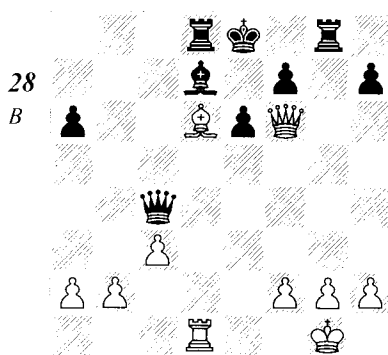
White would love to get his queen over to the kingside before Black has time to defend, but at the moment the e4-bishop is in the way. What should White play and how should he follow up?



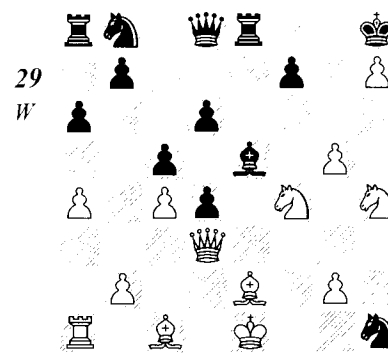
It is do or die for Black, as he is faced with disaster on the a8-h1 diagonal. What should Black play?



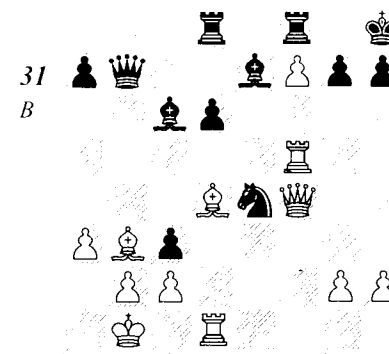
The white knights and queen work very well together in this puzzle. What should White play?



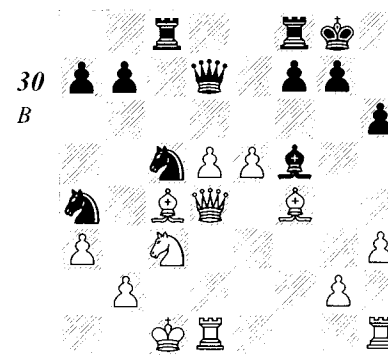
It looks like Black is in dire straits as ♔e7# is a tricky move to stop, but it is Black's move. How should Black use the tempo to save the game?



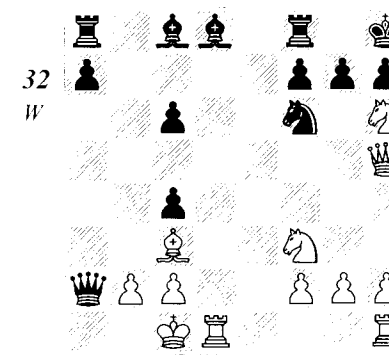
White has a significant number of pieces hovering around the black king. However, White is material down and given time, Black may be able to mount a defence. How should White continue? Analyse until the end.



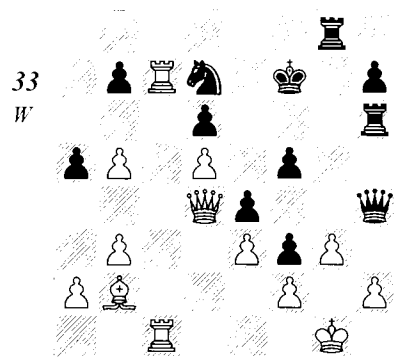
This position is hanging on a knife edge with both kings in danger. What is Black's best move here, and how should the game continue with best play?



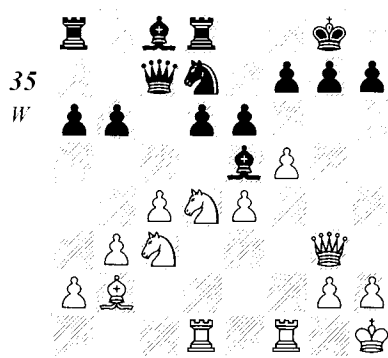
Black clearly has a strong initiative on the queenside. The light-squared bishop on f5 is a major thorn in White's side. But is the initiative worth the two central pawns that Black has invested? What should Black play?



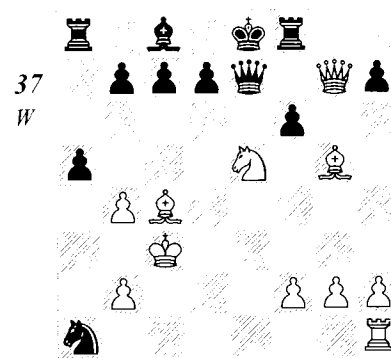
Black has many weaknesses in his position such as the weak back rank, misplaced bishops, and the weak f7-square; but given time he may be able to launch his own attack with ...♘e4. How did White brilliantly break down Black's defences?



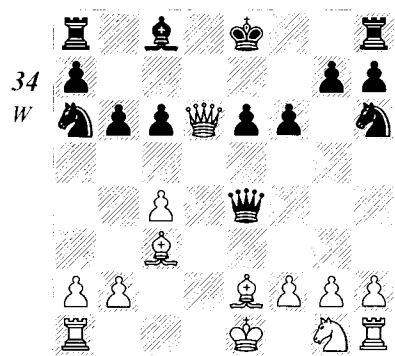
Black's attack looks like it should be winning, but White has a nice resource that holds the balance. What should White play to neutralize Black's attack, and how should the game continue?



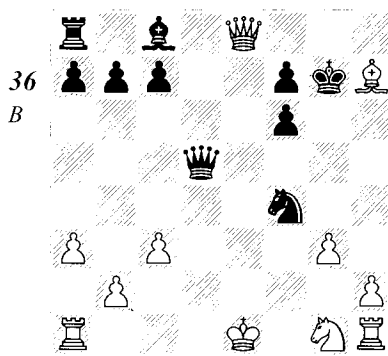
It would seem that White has to make a concession with his queen here. Is that the case, or is there a better move? Analyse as deeply as possible.



A tense situation: most of White's pieces are taking part in the attack, but Black has extra material and White's king is also exposed. Can White keep the battle going in his favour? Analyse as deeply as possible.



Black has just played 11...♘g8-h6 with the intention of playing ...♘f7, kicking the white queen away. Seeing this on the horizon, White took drastic measures to ensure Black could not implement his plan. How can White launch his attack against Black's king?



White's king has got lost somewhere; it should be safely castled by now. What is the best way that Black can exploit this, and how should the game continue?

Solutions

1) Sax – Short

*Subotica IZ 1987***38 ♖xh6+! 1-0**

Black resigned due to 38...♗xh6 39 ♖h4#.

2) Legall – Anon

*1787***5 ♖xe5! ♗xd1?**

5...dxe5 is better, but after 6 ♖xg4 White is a pawn up for nothing. However, the game would go on.

6 ♗xf7+ ♖e7 7 ♖d5# (1-0)

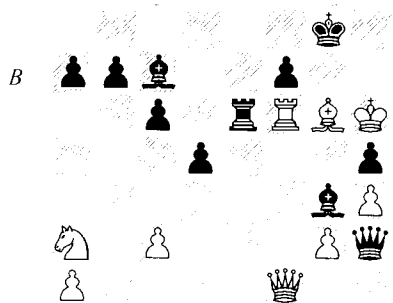
3) Bronstein – Geller

Göteborg IZ 1955

15 ♖xe7+! ♗xe7 16 ♖xd5+ ♖xd5 17 ♖xd3 +-

White has a winning position and went on to convert it into victory.

4) Dufresne – Anderssen

*Berlin 1851***29 ♗g6! (D)**

Now it is Black's king which is mated! In the game, White missed his chance: he played 29 ♖xe6? and lost quickly.

29...♗f8

Or: 29...fxg6 30 ♖f8#; 29...♖xf6 30 ♖xf6 +-.
30 ♖xf7+ ♖e8 31 ♖xc7+ ♗d8 32 ♖f7 +-

5) M. Johnson – J. Clarke

*British corr. Ch 1991***38 ♖xh7+!**

Sacrificing a rook back to eliminate the e2-pawn.

38...♗xh7 39 ♖e4+ ♗h8 40 ♖xe2 +-

White went on to win on move 52.

6) Kasparov – Bareev

*Cannes rpd 2001***40 ♖d7+! +-**

This simple combination enables the white queen to enter the game. The reader should have found this move by analysing all checks and captures.

40...♗xd7

Otherwise White wins the black queen for nothing.

41 ♖f6+ 1-0

Black resigned as mate is coming up; for example, 41...♗e8 42 ♖g7# or 41...♗g8 42 ♖g7#.

7) Potemkin – Alekhine

*St Petersburg 1912***16...♖xd4!**

Leading to a very pretty mate.

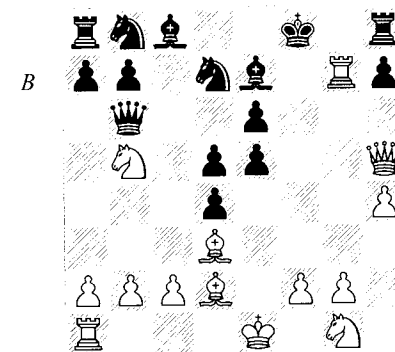
17 gxf5

Black has a simple win if White tries anything else; for example, 17 ♖xd4 ♖e5+ 18 f4 ♖xd4 -+; 17 h4 ♖e5+ -+.

17...♖xf5+ 0-1

White resigned in view of 18 ♗h3 ♖f2# and 18 ♖g4 h5+ 19 ♗h3 (19 ♖g5 ♗h6#) 19...♖f2#.

8) Liuboshits – Shagalovich

*Minsk 1956***13 ♖xg7! (D)**

Enabling the dark-squared bishop to enter the game.

13...♗xg7 14 ♗h6+ ♖g8 15 ♗g6! 1-0

Black resigned since White's threat of 16 ♗f7# cannot be prevented. If 15...hxg6 then 16 ♖xg6#.

9) Sutovsky – Smirin

*Israeli Ch (Tel Aviv) 2002***24 ♖xh7+! 1-0**

It is forced checkmate: 24...♗xh7 25 ♖h4+ ♖g6 26 ♖h6+ ♖g5 27 h4+ ♖g4 28 ♖e3+ ♖g3 29 ♖f3#.

10) Liu Wenzhe – Donner

*Buenos Aires OL 1978***16 ♖xg6+!**

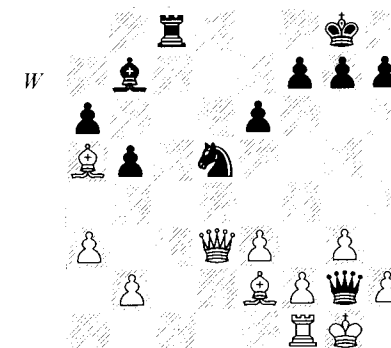
Forcing the black king away from its pawn-cover.

16...♗xg6 17 ♗h5+ ♗h7 18 ♗f7+ ♗h6 19 g6+ ♖g7

19...♗h8 20 ♖xh6+ ♖g7 21 ♖h7#.

20 ♗xh6+ ♗h8 21 ♗xf8+ 1-0

11) Glass – Russell

*Belfast 1956***1...♖g2+! (D)**

We shall see more of this mating theme. The black knight and bishop now undertake a little dance to mate the white king.

2 ♗xg2 ♖f4++ 3 ♖g1 ♖h3#

12) Pirrot – Hertneck

*Bundesliga 1989/90***21...♗g4! 0-1**

The black bishop rushes forward with crushing effect. White resigned, seeing 22 ♖xg4 ♖f1+ 23 ♖g1 ♖g3+! 24 hxg3 ♖h3#.

13) Opočensky – Alekhine

Prague 1942

23...♗h3!

Stopping ♖xc8# and gaining time to launch a decisive kingside attack.

24 ♖d8+

24 ♗xh3 ♖e3+ 25 ♖h1 ♖f3+ 26 ♖g1 ♖f2+ 27 ♖h1 ♖xh2#.

24...♖xd8 25 ♗xh3 ♖xa8 –+

14) Zarnicki – Dgebuadze

Roque Saenz Peña tt 1997

38...♗f4!

Re-routing the black knight to a more aggressive square.

39 ♖e7 ♖f8 40 ♖e1

The only square for the white rook.

40...♖c1! 41 ♖xc1

41 ♗f3 ♖xe1 42 ♗xe1 ♗e2+ 43 ♖h1 ♗xf2# is a very picturesque finish.

41...♗e2+ 42 ♖h1 ♗xf2#

15) Fedorchuk – N. Pert

Oropesa del Mar U-18 Wch 1998

27...♖xf2!

The e4-bishop is a monster; once g2 drops, so does White's position.

28 ♖h2

After 28 ♖xf8+ ♖xf8 29 ♖h2 ♗xg2! –+ White's king will not last long.

28...♗xg2

28...♖xg2+ 29 ♖h3 ♖d2 –+ is also strong.

29 ♖xa8

29 ♖xf8+ does not help: 29...♖xf8 30 ♖xa7 ♗f3+ 31 ♖h3 g5 –+.

29...♗f1+ 0-1

16) Kasparov – Korchnoi

Zurich rpd 2001

21 ♖f3+!

Forcing the black king into a mating-net.

21...♗xg6

After 21...♗g8 22 ♗e7+ +- White picks up the exchange and then the game.

22 ♗d3+ ♖h5 23 ♖h3+ ♖g4 24 f3+ ♖f4 25 ♖f2!

This was the most difficult move to spot as it does not involve a check or capture. Now 26 g3# is the threat and Black cannot stop mate.

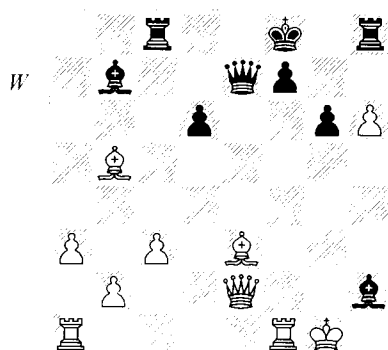
25...g4 26 g3+ 1-0

It is mate after 26...♗g5 27 f4#.

17) Wahls – Vera

Cienfuegos (Capablanca mem) 1996

22...♗xh2+! (D)



So the black h8-rook can enter the game with devastating effect.

23 ♖xh2

23 ♖xh2 ♖h4+ 24 ♖g1 ♖g3+ 25 ♖g2 ♖xg2#.

23...♖xe3+ 24 ♖f2

24 ♖f2 ♖g5+ 25 ♖h2 ♖xh6+ 26 ♖h4 ♖xh4#.

24...♖xh6 0-1

18) J. Polgar – L.B. Hansen

Vejstrup 1989

33 ♖g7+! 1-0

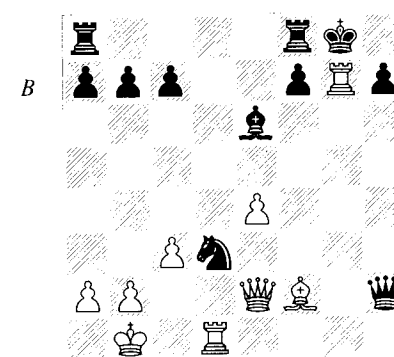
So White can capture on f7 with check.

Mate will follow soon: 33...♗xg7 34 ♖xf7+ ♖g8 (34...♖h6 35 ♖h7#) 35 ♖g7+ ♖h8 36 ♖h7+ ♖g8 37 ♖bg7#.

19) Staunton – Harrison

London (casual game) 1840

21 ♖xg7+! (D)



Now the black knight has moved. White has the option of ♗d4+.

21...♖h8

21...♗xg7 loses the queen after 22 ♗d4+ f6 23 ♖xh2.

22 ♗d4!

The combination of bishop and rook is deadly. Black cannot avoid a see-saw checkmate as we shall see.

22...♖xe2 23 ♖xf7+ ♖g8 24 ♖g7+ ♖h8 25 ♖g6+ 1-0

20) Neishtadt – Gipslis

Riga 1955

16 ♖d8!

So that the white queen can venture over to h5.

16...♖xd8 17 ♖h5 h6

Forced.

18 ♖g6!

The queen has wriggled her way into the heart of Black's position.

18...hgx5 19 hgx5+ +-

Now the h-file has been opened. Black can only sit around and wait for the end.

19...♗g8 20 ♖h5

There was another way to win: 20 ♖h8+ ♖xh8 21 ♖h5+ ♖g8 22 g6 ♖f6 (otherwise White forces mate; e.g., 22...♖e8 23 ♖h7+ ♖f8 24 ♖h8+ ♖e7 25 ♖xg7#) 23 ♖h7+ ♖f8 24 ♖h8+ ♖e7 25 ♖xg7+ ♖e8 26 exf6, when White's pawns will do the business.

20...♗c4 21 g6 ♖d2+ 22 ♖b1 ♗a3+

A 'computer check'.

23 bxa3 1-0

Or perhaps 23...♖c1+ first.

21) Chudinovskikh – Muravev

USSR 1990

1 ♖h8+!!

The rook travels a bit further!

1...♗xh8 2 ♖h7+!

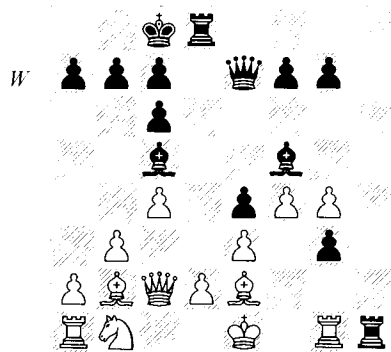
The queen follows its companion.

2...♖xh7 3 ♖h5++ ♖g8 4 ♗h7# (1-0)

22) Larsen – Spassky

Belgrade (USSR – RoW) 1970

14...♖h1! (D)



Gaining time by giving up a rook.

15 ♖xh1 g2 16 ♖f1

16 ♖g1 ♖h4+ 17 ♖d1 ♖h1 18 ♖c3 ♖xg1+ 19 ♖c2 ♖f2 –+.

16...♖h4+ 17 ♖d1 gxf1 ♖+ 0-1

Due to 18 ♖xf1 ♖xg4+, when mate will follow.

23) Naiditsch – Koneru

Wijk aan Zee 2003

23 ♖he1! ♖xd3 24 ♖xe8+ ♖f7 25 ♖de1! +–

This move changes the whole situation! ♖le7# is the threat, while Black's queen is still in trouble. The game continued:

25...♖e4

The only way to stop mate and get some material back.

26 ♖xe4 ♖xe8 27 ♖xf6+ ♖f7 28 ♖g5+! 1-0

Black resigned in view of 28...♖xf6 29 ♖e6#.

24) J. Polgar – Fernandez Garcia

Santurtzi rpd 2003

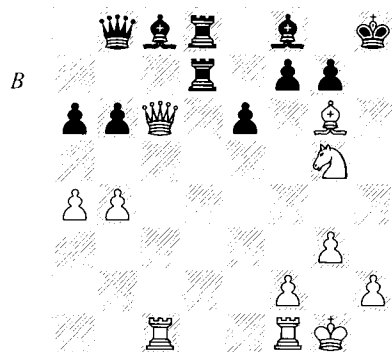
24 ♖d7! 1-0

Black resigned due to 24...♖xd7 25 ♖xb7+ ♖e6 (25...♖d8 26 ♖d1+ mates) 26 ♖d5+ ♖e7 27 ♖d6#.

25) Alekhine – Rubinstein

Karlsbad 1923

25 ♖g6! (D)



This move interferes with Black's defence and makes room for the white queen to re-route over to the black kingside.

25...♖e5

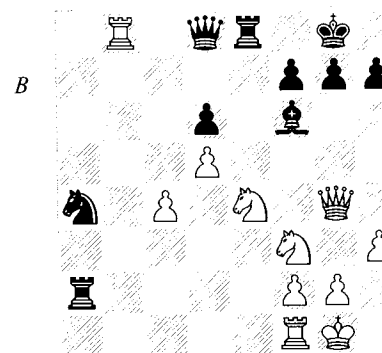
The win is now simple but capturing the bishop also leads to mate: 25...fxg6 (25...♖b7 26 ♖c4 +–) 26 ♖e4 ♖xb4 (Black tries to make room so his king can run away via f8; 26...♖d4 27 ♖xg6 +–) 27 ♖h4+ ♖g8 28 ♖h7+ ♖f8 29 ♖h8+ ♖e7 30 ♖xg7+ ♖d6 (30...♖e8 31 ♖g8+ ♖f8 {31...♖e7 32 ♖f7+ ♖d6 33 ♖fd1+ ♖e5 34 ♖f4#} 32 ♖xg6+ ♖e7 33 ♖xe6#) 31 ♖fd1+ ♖d2 32 ♖xd2#.

26 ♖xf7+ ♖xf7 27 ♖xf7 +–
White won on move 32.

26) Hebden – Pichon

Cappelle la Grande 1990

1 ♖b8! (D)



Deflecting the black queen away from its defensive duties.

1...♖xb8 2 ♖xf6+ ♖h8 3 ♖g5!

I am sure Hebden had seen this move in advance; otherwise 1 ♖b8 was not an especially good move. It should be natural to see such a move as White brings a third piece into the attack – and three pieces is the magic number.

3...♖f8

3...♖e7 4 ♖e4!.

4 ♖h5 h6 5 ♖xf7! ♖c5 6 ♖g8+!

1-0

6...♖xg8 7 ♖f7#.

27) Osloukhov – Nedobora

USSR 1990

1...♖h4+!!

This amazing resource turns the tables.

2 gxf4

2 ♖xh4 ♖xh2#.

2...♖e3+ 3 ♖f3 ♖xe6+! 4 ♖xe6 ♖xf3# (0-1)

28) Gimpel – Subin

USSR 1977

1...♖xg2+!

The only move.

2 ♖h1!

Capturing the rook gives Black a decisive advantage: 2 ♖xg2? ♖g4+ 3 ♖f1 (3 ♖h1 ♖c6+ 4 f3 ♖xf3+ –+) 3...♖b5+ –+.

2...♖g1+!

Again Black's only move.

3 ♖xg1

3 ♖xg1?? ♖g4+ –+.

3...♖c6+ 4 f3 ♖xf3+!

4...♖xd6?? fails to 5 ♖g8+ ♖d7 6 ♖d8#.

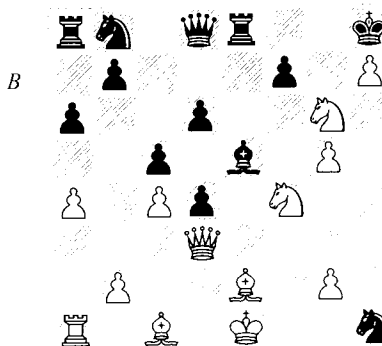
5 ♖xf3 ♖xd6 1/2-1/2

Black has survived.

29) S. Williams – Palliser

London (MSO) 2000

20 ♖hg6+! (D)



The knight and queen act as a powerful attacking force.

20...fxg6 21 ♖xg6+ ♕g7 22 ♖h3!

The most difficult move to spot; the white queen has to enter the action in order to cause the black king difficulties.

22...♗g3+ 23 ♖f1 ♕xg6

Black has nothing else; White's plan was the simple 24 ♖h6+ and h8♖ or h8♗+.

24 ♖h6+

Mate is now forced.

24...♕f5

24...♗f7 25 ♗h5+ ♕e7 26 ♖g7+ ♕e6 27 ♗g4#.

25 ♗g4+! ♕e5

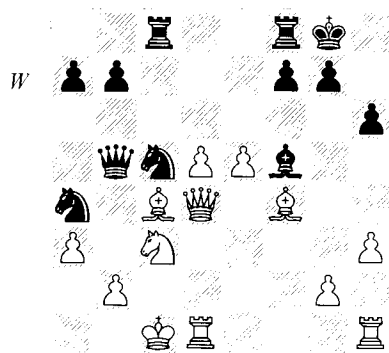
25...♕xg4 26 ♖h3#.

26 ♖g7+ ♕e4 27 ♖g6+ ♕e5 28 ♖f5# (1-0)

30) Vetemaa – Shabalov

Haapsalu 1986

20...♖b5! (D)



A shocking move. Black wants to land a knight on b3.

21 ♖d2

To stop 21...♖xb2#. Otherwise: 21 ♗xb5 ♗b3#; 21 ♗xb5 ♗b3#.

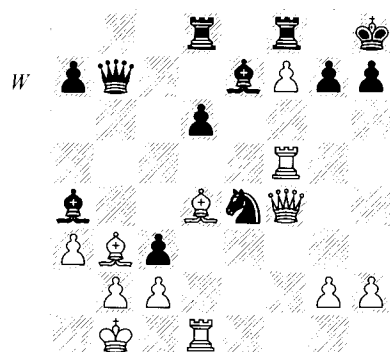
21...♗xc3 0-1

22 bxc3 allows 22...♖b1#.

31) Fischer – Geller

Skopje 1967

21...♗a4! (D)



Black had to make sure that White could not break through here. Again calculation is the key.

22 ♖g4

White has to try a counter-attack, as passive defence will do little to stop Black's plans; for example, 22 ♖h6 ♗f6 23 ♖xf6 ♗xb3 24 ♖xd6 (24 cxb3 ♖xb3 25 ♖f2 ♖xd1+ 26 ♕a2 ♖xd4 +-) 24...♗a2+! 25 ♕xa2 ♖xb2#.

22...♗f6 23 ♖xf6

23 ♖h5 intends 24 ♖xh7+ ♕xh7 25 ♖h5#, but is well met by 23...♖xf7. This looks dangerous, but Black comes out on top after 24 ♖g6! (24 ♖h3 ♗g5) 24...♗g5! 25 ♗xf6 ♖xf6 (the g5-knight does a great job of defending

against mate on h7) 26 ♖xg5 ♗xb3 +-.

23...♗xb3 0-1

White resigned due to the threat of ...♗a2+ and the simple ...♗xf6. Tempo and calculation are the keys here as Black needed to make sure moves like 24 ♖xg7+ are not dangerous.

32) Tal – Smyslov

Bled/Zagreb/Belgrade Ct 1959

19 ♖xf7!!

This move combines a number of common tactical motifs, including back-rank mate and smothered mate.

19...♖a1+

Black has to lose material to avoid being mated. Other moves:

a) 19...♖e8 20 ♖g8+! followed by 21 ♗f7#.

b) 19...♖xf7 20 ♖xd8+ +-.

c) 19...♗e7 and now the prettiest way to win is 20 ♗e5! (with the threat of 21 ♖g8+ ♗xg8 22 ♗hf7+ ♖xf7 23 ♗xf7#) 20...gxh6 21 ♖xe7 +-.

20 ♗d2 ♖xf7 21 ♗xf7+ ♕g8 22 ♖xa1 ♗xf7 +-

White has a decisive advantage, and duly won in another 4 moves.

33) S. Williams – Benitah

Oakham (Glorney Cup) 1997

27 ♖f6+!

White gains time to do a bit of attacking himself.

27...♖xf6

27...♖xf6? 28 ♗xf6 +-.

28 ♖xd7+ ♕e8

28...♕g6 29 gxh4 +-.

29 ♖xb7 ♖ff8

Black's only move.

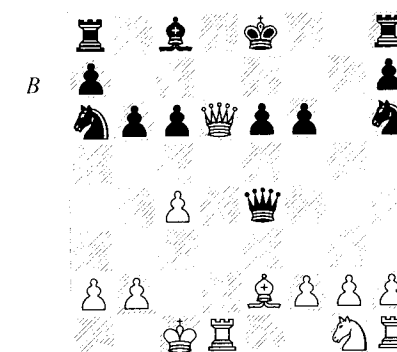
30 ♖c8+ ♖d8 31 ♖xd8+ ♕xd8 32 b6 ±

White's rook dominates the 7th rank, giving him a pleasant advantage. He went on to win.

34) S. Williams – Zhao Zong Yuan

Witley jr 2001

12 ♗xf6! gxf6 13 0-0-0! (D)



Now ♖d8+ and ♗h5+ are both major threats, while 13...♗f7 is also prevented.

13...♖g8

Black's only move. Alternatively: 13...♗f7 14 ♗h5 +- and 15 ♖d8# is next; 13...♗f7 14 ♗h5+ ♕g7 15 ♖e7+ +-; 13...♗g4 14 ♖d4! ♖e5 15 ♖xc6+ ♗f7 16 ♖xg4 ±.

14 ♗h5+ ♖g6 15 ♖d8+

White must keep playing actively.

15...♗f7 16 ♖h8!

Making room for the white rook to come to d8.

16...♗f5?

16... ♖xc4+ 17 ♖b1 ♗e4+ 18 ♖a1 ♜f5 19 f3 +- is a position reached in the game.

17 ♜d8! ♖xc4+

17... ♗e1+ 18 ♜d1 +-.

18 ♖b1?

Missing 18 ♜d2! ♗f4+/♗b4+ 19 ♜d1! ♗a4+ 20 b3 and White wins Black's queen for nothing.

18... ♗e4+ 19 ♖a1 ♗e1+ 20 ♜d1 ♖c4? 21 f3! ♗c2 22 ♜e2 ♜c5

The queen must try to stay on the b1-h7 diagonal; 22... ♗xe2 allows 23 ♗xh7+ ♜g7 24 ♗xg6+ +-.

23 ♜f4 ♖e7 24 ♜xg6+ hxg6 25 ♗h7+ 1-0

Mate is coming.

35) Alekhine – Sämisch

Berlin 1923

18 fxe6!

This pawn is stronger than the white queen.

18... ♜xg3 19 exf7+ ♖h8 20 ♜d5! 1-0

Black did not wish to see the following variations:

a) 20... ♗a7 21 ♜c6 ♜e5 22 ♜xe5 dxe5 23 ♜xa7 ♜xa7 24 ♜xb6 ♜f8 25 ♜xc8 ♜xc8 26 ♜xd7 +-.

b) 20... ♗b7 21 ♜e6 ♜e5 (♜xg7# was the threat) 22 ♜xd8 +-.

c) 20... ♗c5 21 ♜e6 ♜e5 22 ♜xe5 dxe5 23 ♜xc5 bxc5 24 ♜c7 ♜b8 25 ♜e8 +-.

d) 20... ♗b8 21 ♜c6 and then:

d1) 21... ♗b7 22 ♜xd8 +-.

d2) 21... ♜h4 22 ♜xb8 ♜xb8 23 g3 ♜g5 24 h4 ♜h6 (24... ♜f6 25 ♜xf6

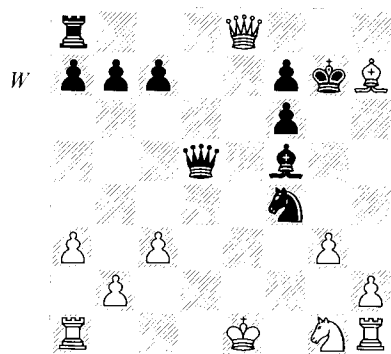
gxf6 26 ♜xf6! +-) 25 g4 also wins for White.

d3) 21... ♜e5 22 ♜xe5 dxe5 23 ♜xb8 ♜xb8 24 ♜c7 (the threat is ♜e8 as well as ♜e6) 24... ♜f8 25 ♜e6 g6 26 ♜xf8 ♜xf8 27 ♜d8 +- ♜g7 28 ♜fd1 ♜a8 29 ♜ld6 and Black's queenside pawns will drop, with an easily won ending for White.

36) Topalov – Bareev

Linares 1994

17... ♜f5! (D)



This move diverts the white queen, brings another black piece into the attack, and negates the h7-bishop's control over the central squares. As we have already seen, three pieces is normally enough to mate an exposed king.

18 ♗xa8 ♗e4+ 19 ♖f2

Or:

a) 19 ♖d1 ♗c2+ 20 ♖e1 ♜d3+ 21 ♖f1 ♗f2#.

b) 19 ♖d2 ♗c2+ 20 ♖e3 (20 ♖e1 ♜d3+ 21 ♖f1 ♗f2#) 20... ♗d3+! 21 ♖f2 (21 ♖xf4 ♗e4#) 21... ♗d2+ 22

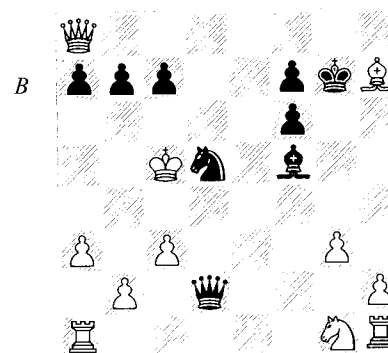
♜f3 (22 ♖f1 ♜h3+! 23 ♜xh3 ♗e2+ 24 ♖g1 ♗g2# – beautiful!) 22... ♗g2+ 23 ♖e3 ♜d5+ 24 ♖d4 ♗e4+ 25 ♖c5 ♗e3+ 26 ♖c4 (26 ♖b5 ♗b6+ 27 ♖c4 ♜e3#) 26... ♜b6+ 27 ♖b4 (27 ♖b3 ♗e6+ 28 c4 ♗xc4#; 27 ♖b5 ♗e5+ 28 ♖b4 ♗e4+) 27... ♗e4+ 28 c4 ♗xc4+ 29 ♖a5 ♗a4#.

19... ♗g2+ 20 ♖e3 ♜d5+ 21 ♖d4 ♗d2+

21... ♗e4+ and 21... ♗f2+ also force mate in six moves. It is nice when you have a choice!

22 ♖c5 (D)

22 ♖c4 ♜b6+ 23 ♖b4 (23 ♖b3 ♗d5+) 23... ♗xb2+ 24 ♖c5 ♗xc3+ 25 ♖b5 c6#.



22... ♗e3+ 23 ♖c4

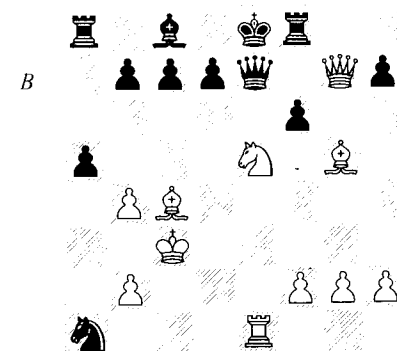
Or: 23 ♖xd5 ♜e6#; 23 ♖b5 ♗b6+ 24 ♖c4 ♜e3#.

23... ♜b6+ 24 ♖b3 ♗e6+ 25 ♖b4 ♗c4+ 26 ♖a5 ♗a4# (0-1)

37) Motylev – Dumitrache

Eforie-Nord 1996

14 ♜e1!! (D)



Bringing the last piece into play. This looks very dangerous for White since Black is allowed a couple of checks.

14... ♗xb4+

Others:

a) 14... axb4+ 15 ♖d2 and Black has run out of checks.

b) With 14... fxg5, Black gives his queen up but in return the position is simplified, which is welcome for Black given that he is material up. Then 15 ♜d3 axb4+ 16 ♖d2 ♗xe1+ 17 ♖xe1 leads to a rather unclear position but White has the better attacking chances. His three remaining pieces work very well together.

c) 14... d5 (this pawn thrust is an attempt to free Black's position) 15 ♜b5+ c6 16 ♜xc6 ♗xe1+ 17 ♜d2 ♜d7! (other moves lose on the spot; for example, 17... ♗e6 18 ♜b8+! ♜d8 19 ♗xf8+ ♖c7 20 ♜f4+ ♖b6 21 ♗c5#) 18 ♜xe1 bxc6 19 ♜e2 (with the idea of playing ♜h5+ at some point) 19... axb4+ 20 ♖xb4 ±. The white king can actually be used as an

attacking piece if Black is not careful – if it reaches d6 for example.

d) 14...d6 can lead to similar positions as in line 'c' after 15 ♖b5+ c6 16 ♜xc6 ♜xe1+ 17 ♕d2 ♕d7 18 ♕xe1 bxc6 19 ♕e2 axb4+ 20 ♜xb4 – the only difference is that Black's pawn is on d6 instead of d5. This may benefit Black as White's king is no longer allowed free reign into the d6-square. However, 15 ♜f3! ♜xe1+ 16 ♜xe1 axb4+ 17 ♜xb4 fxg5 18 ♜xc7 gives White a dangerous initiative.

15 ♜d3 ♜d6+ 16 ♜e2!?

White can draw immediately with 16 ♜c3 ♜b4+ 17 ♜d3 ♜d6+ 18 ♜c3, but fortune favours the brave!

16...fxg5?

Or:

a) 16...fxe5?? 17 ♜f1 ♜f5 18 ♜xe5+! ♜xe5 (18...♜xe5 19 ♕f7#) 19 ♜g8+ ♜f8 20 ♕f7#.

b) 16...♜e7? 17 ♜f1! does not help Black's position.

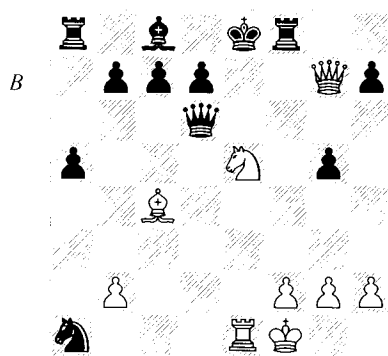
c) 16...♜xe5+ 17 ♜f1 ♜xe1+ 18 ♜xe1 fxg5 and the only winning attempt here is the very brave 19 ♕e2!? (19 ♜e5+ ♜d8 20 ♜xg5+ ♜e8 21 ♜e5+ is a draw) 19...♜c2+ 20 ♜f1 ♜e3+ 21 ♜gl g4 22 fxe3, when Black still has problems to overcome, as his pieces are disorganized.

d) 16...♜c2 looks like Black's most natural move because White's e1-rook

is a constant irritation. 17 ♕f7+ ♜e7 (17...♜d8?? 18 ♜xf6+ ♜xf6 19 ♕xf6#) 18 ♕f4 ♜c5! (18...♜d8? 19 ♜c6+! +-; 18...♜xe1? 19 ♜g6+! hxg6 20 ♕xd6+ cxd6 21 ♕xg6+ +-) and it seems that a draw may be the fair result: 19 ♕b3+ ♜e8 (19...♜d6?? 20 ♜xf8#; 19...♜d8? 20 ♕xc2! ♜xc2+? 21 ♜f1 +-) 20 ♕f7+ ♜e7 21 ♕b3+ with a perpetual check.

17 ♜f1 (D)

After 17 ♜f7 ♜e7+ 18 ♜f1 ♜xe1+ 19 ♜xe1 White also has a decisive attack.



17...♜d8?!

17...♜e7 is relatively best, when White has a pleasant choice between 18 ♜f7, as in the note to White's 17th move, 18 ♜f3 and 18 ♜g4.

18 ♜xg5+ ♜f6 19 ♜f7+! ♜xf7 20 ♕xf7 1-0

5 Attacking on Opposite Sides

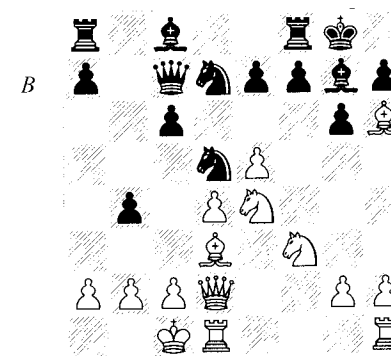
Some of the most exciting games of chess occur when players have castled on opposite sides. This is because in most cases it is essential for a player to attack the enemy king as viciously as possible. To do this successfully, it is very important to take the initiative. Once a player has the initiative, the defending side will be on the back foot, spending time defending. If a player is defending, he will not have time to attack.

There are some common themes which appear in games where players have castled on opposite sides, I will go over some of them now:

1) **Pushing pawns towards the enemy king.** This is a great way to soften up his position. This is viable because the pawns are not needed to protect their own king any more.

2) **Make maximum use of open files or semi-open files leading towards the enemy king.** If a file is available, then line up heavy pieces on it (an example of how useful this can be is demonstrated in puzzle 1). It is sometimes worth sacrificing a pawn just to open up a file.

3) **Eliminate your opponent's best defenders.** If one of your opponent's pieces is holding up the attack, then try to eliminate it. Here is an example:

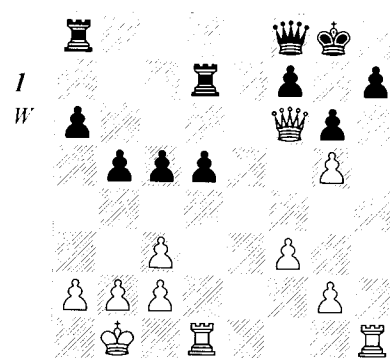


Ferčec – Karabačić

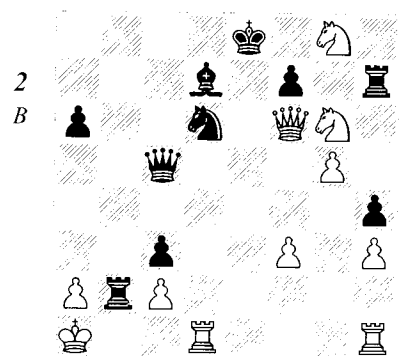
Zadar 2003

White has just played 13 ♕g5-h6 to eliminate Black's g7-bishop, which is his best defender. This can be combined with pushing the h-pawn to h5 to open up the h-file. White played this idea and won in just over 20 moves.

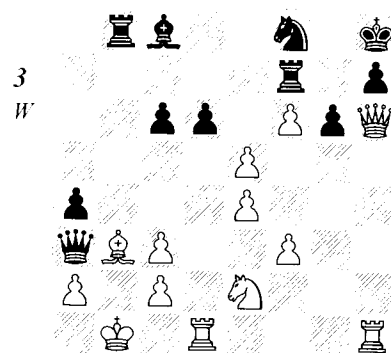
Puzzles



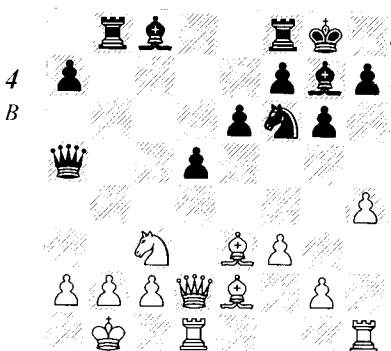
White has an open h-file and a well-placed queen. How did White use these factors to cash his chips in?



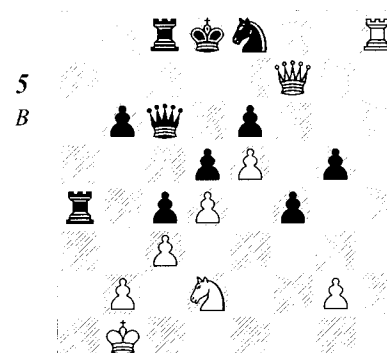
Both kings are in mortal danger but it is Black to move first. How should Black turn the game in his favour?



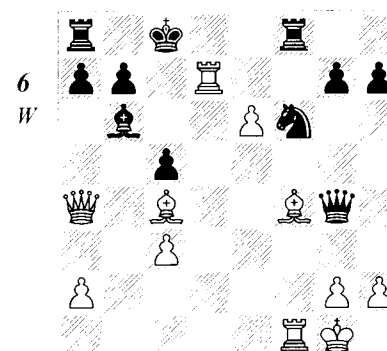
A very sharp position has been reached, with both kings living on the edge. In positions such as this the initiative is everything, and here it is White's move. How did White force checkmate in four moves?



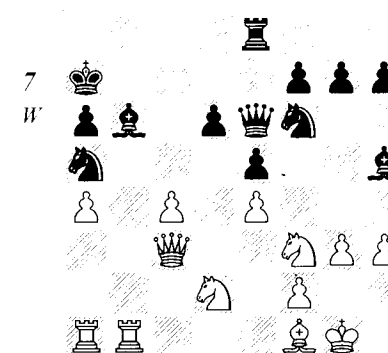
Black has the very dangerous team of b8-rook, g7-bishop and queen on a5, a set-up often adopted in the Dragon. The finish is also of a type often seen in the Dragon. What should Black play?



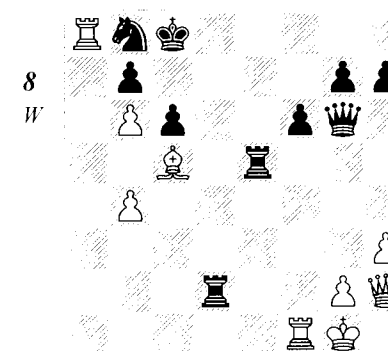
The a-file proves useful for Black here. How can he force a quick checkmate?



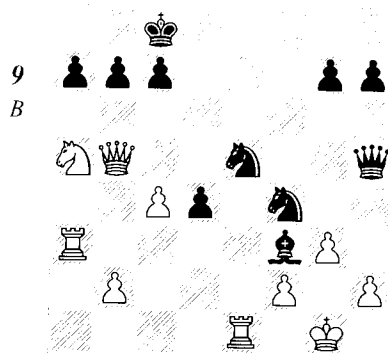
Black's king has been viciously chased from the kingside to the queenside. White obviously has a commanding position, with a rook on the seventh and a mighty bishop on f4. What killer blow did White land here?



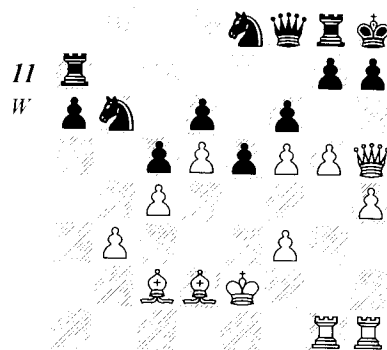
White has the better attacking chances, mainly because Black's king lacks adequate pawn-cover and White has the open b-file available to him. What should White play?



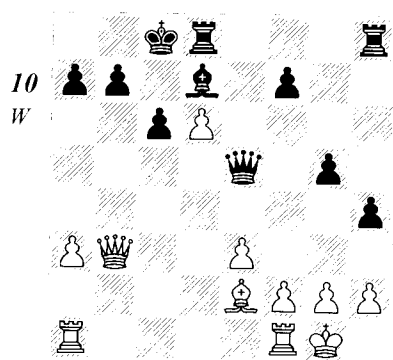
How did White force checkmate here through the use of a crafty tactic?



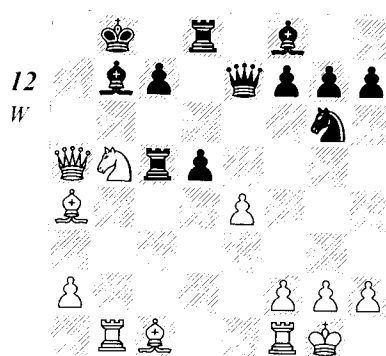
The white king has no defenders to guard it, while Black has his whole army gathering for the kill. How could Black force checkmate?



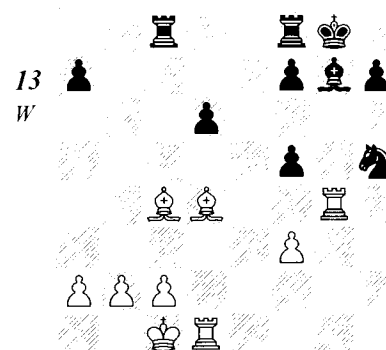
Black's king is stuck in a 'box' and it is not surprising that White can break through with an attractive combination. What is it?



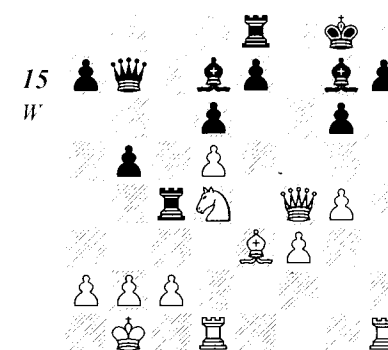
White clearly has more open lines to attack on. How can he exploit this factor to win the game?



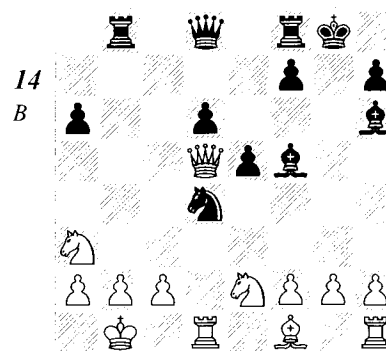
White has all the pressure, with four pieces all wanting to mate the black king. It is therefore not surprising that White can win with a little combination. Can you find it?



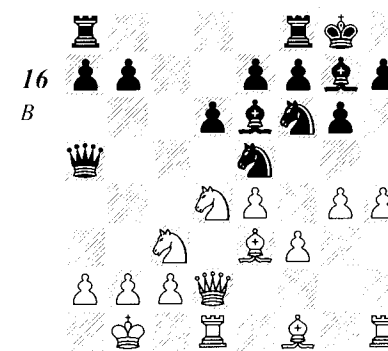
Even with a lack of pieces on the board, mate threats can still arise. How did White make use of the open g-file to force the win?



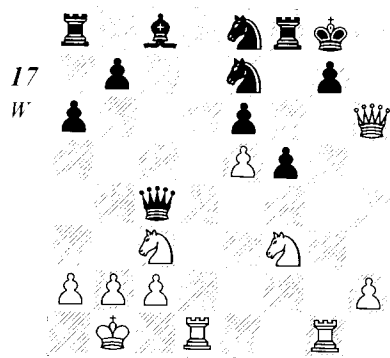
The opening has clearly gone wrong for Black. He has no real attacking chances on the queenside while White has the open h-file and more dynamically placed pieces. How did White use these factors to force the win?



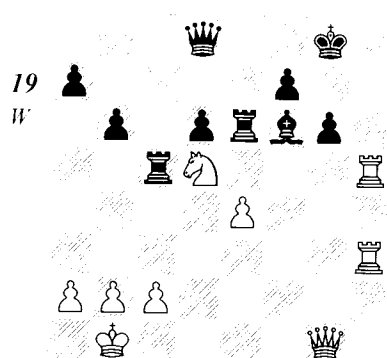
White is under serious pressure in view of the open b- and c-files and Black's strong knight and light-squared bishop. It is therefore not surprising that Black can force the win through the use of an attractive combination. What is it?



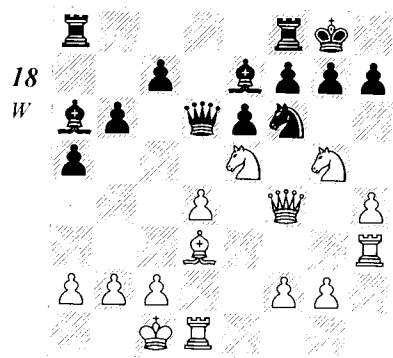
Black's pieces are well-placed for an assault on the white king. If we look closer we can see that a2 is a major weakness in White's position. The only problem for Black is that his pieces are blocking each other. How should Black unblock his pieces and force the win?



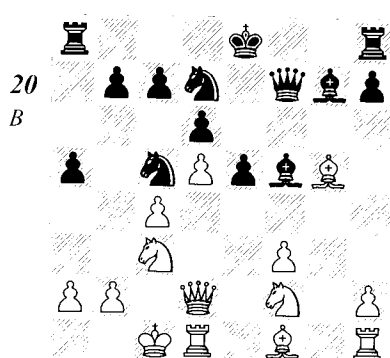
White has conducted the attack with a good deal of aggression up to this point – which is the right approach when attacking on opposite sides. How should White finish off the attack?



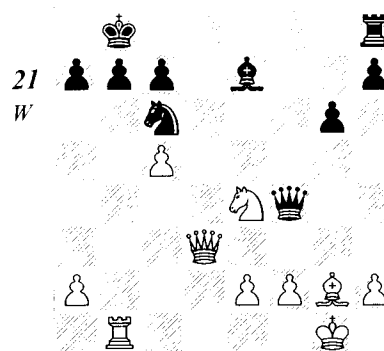
White clearly has dangerous pressure on the h-file but the black bishop is doing a good defensive job. How can White overload the bishop?



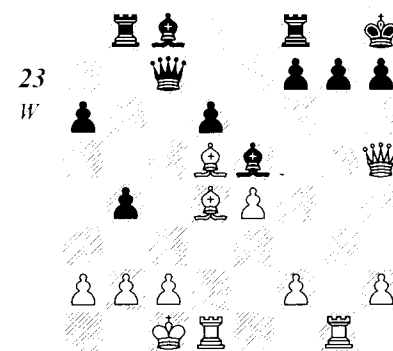
White has positioned her pieces so that they are all ready to strike the black king. The white knights are looking especially dangerous, attacking two weak points in Black's position: h7 and f7. How did White break through Black's defences?



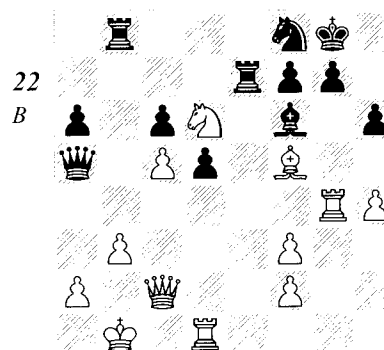
Black's f5-bishop is a special piece, cutting across White's king. If only the white pawn weren't on a2 Black could play ...♖b3#. What should Black play?



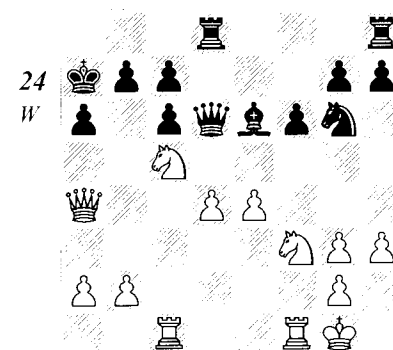
The black king is in a dangerous position compared to its white counterpart, which is safely tucked away on g1. White has the b-file available to him as a major attacking avenue. What should White play to force the win?



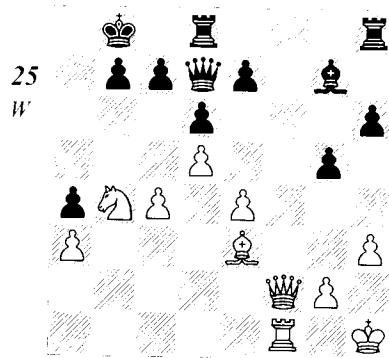
White's position has a menacing look about it; with an open g-file and queen placed dangerously near the black king, the alarm bells are ringing. What should White play?



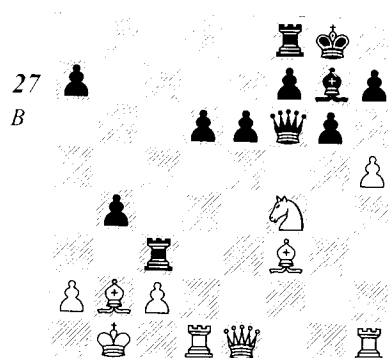
Black has a lot of active pieces here, a factor that must have encouraged him to search for a win. How did Black force the win?



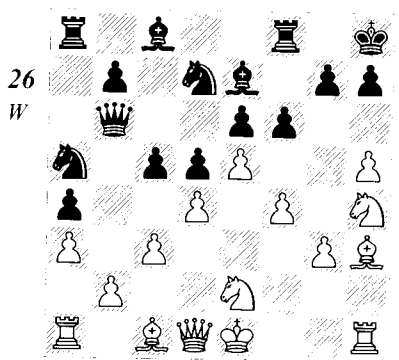
White has a large initiative on the queenside, with three pieces poised near the black king, which is lacking any defenders. How did White break through?



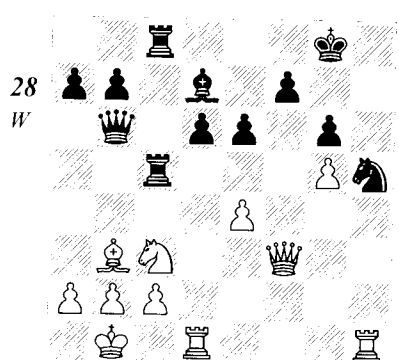
White is the exchange down but he has the open b-file to attack on, and a very active knight on b4. What should White play?



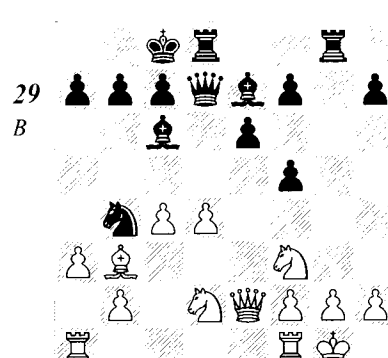
Black has the classic battering-ram of queen and bishop on the a1-h8 diagonal. 22...♙xf4 looks natural but then White has some chances of survival. What is the best move in this position for Black?



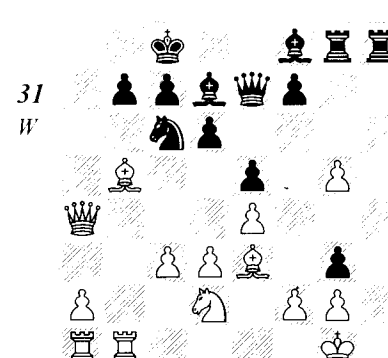
Black has been largely ignoring White's play on the kingside. White now has a pretty win; what is it?



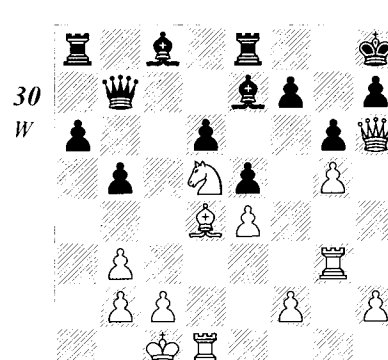
Fischer (White here) had a habit of beating the Dragon with regular ease and this game was no exception. What did White play and what was the follow-up?



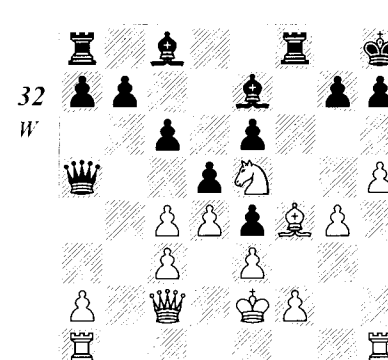
There is one point in White's position that stands out here and that is the g2-square. With Black's g8-rook and c6-bishop both staring towards this square, a disaster is just waiting to happen. What should Black play?



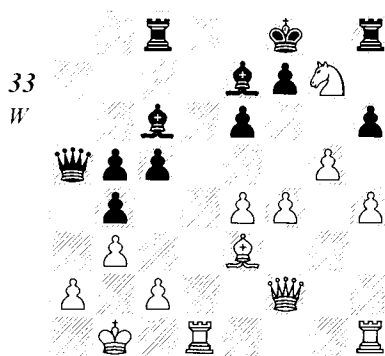
If we look at the important aspects of this position, it is clear that White's pieces are on much better squares than Black's. How can White force checkmate in six moves with the help of a discovered check?



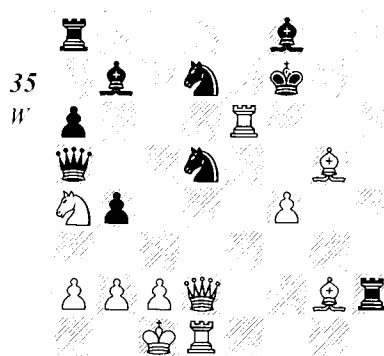
Black's king is under serious pressure, but it seems that Black can just about hold things together after 21 ♖f6 ♙xf6 ♗g8. Is this White's best plan or is there a better idea?



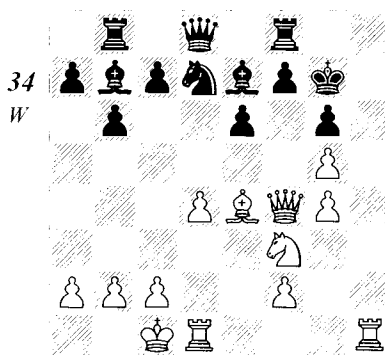
In this position White used a familiar motif to reach a winning position. What did White play and what was the follow-up?



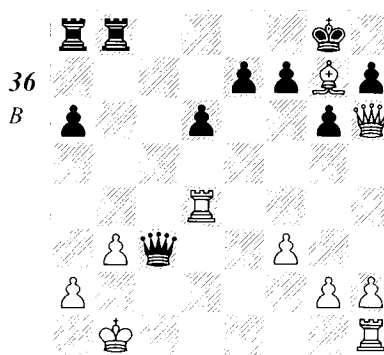
When attacking on opposite sides, the most important thing is normally to pursue the initiative as aggressively as possible. Sometimes this means sacrificing pawns and even pieces to gain time. How should White keep the attack going here?



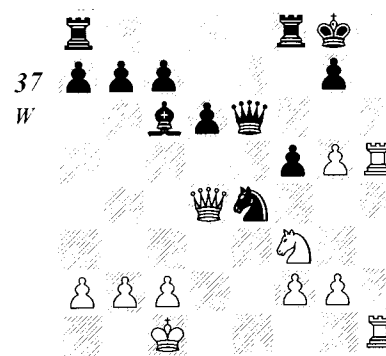
A rather messy position has been reached where Black's king is very exposed, but White only has a couple of pieces attacking it at the moment. What should White play?



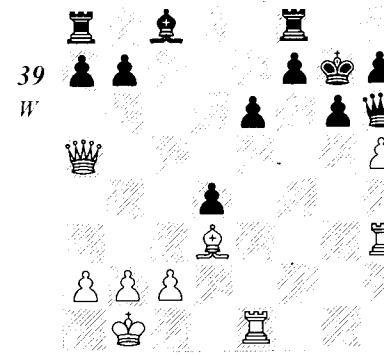
White has correctly sacrificed a piece to reach this position. White's position has a lot of factors in its favour: pressure on the h-file and pawns on g4 and g5 which guard two critical squares, f6 and h6. How should White continue the attack?



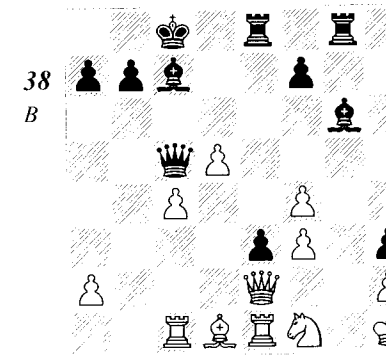
This game was awarded the best game prize at the British Championship in 1998 and deservedly so. How did Black finish off his attack? Try to calculate the variations until the end.



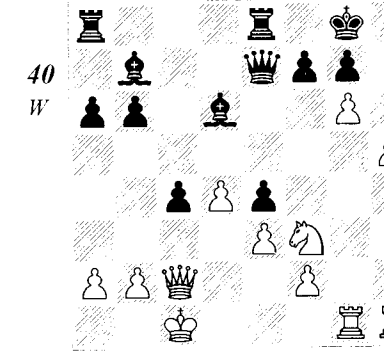
White has the initiative due to the open h-file and advanced g-pawn. Yet it seems that Black always has the f7-square available to him as an escape-route for his king, and he is a piece up. What should White play?



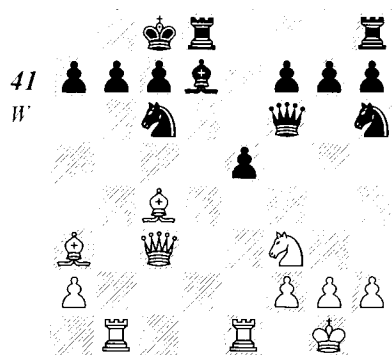
White has sacrificed many pawns to reach this position. Such a tactic is quite common when players have castled on opposite sides. How did White prove that he had enough compensation for the material?



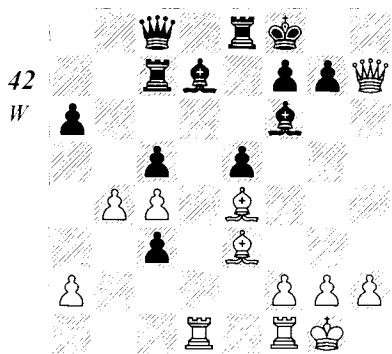
Winning combinations often arise from the accumulation of small advantages. Here Black could play the simple 27...♘a5, which wins, but Black chose a different and effective path. What did he play?



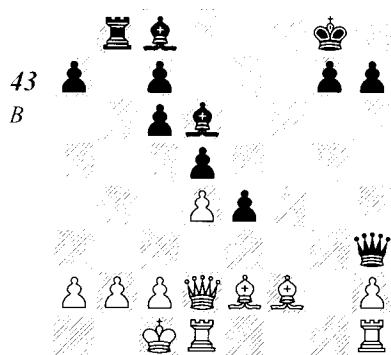
White has sacrificed a piece to gain some time for the attack. How should he conduct the rest of the attack against the black king? Analyse as deeply as possible.



White is material down but he has strong attacking chances. This is mainly due to the semi-open b-file, via which he can launch an attack. White played an unexpected move here to give himself the best practical chances. What was that move and the subsequent follow-up?



White's attack looks dangerous. 22 ♖xc5+ would win the exchange but Black can fight on with 22...♗xc5. Is there a better move available to White?



Black has just sacrificed a rook with 17...♖f8xf2 18 ♙e3xf2. Morphy (Black) had a brilliant idea in mind when playing 17...♖xf2. Can you find his next move and the follow-up?

Solutions

1) Shirov – Motylev

Moscow rpd 2002

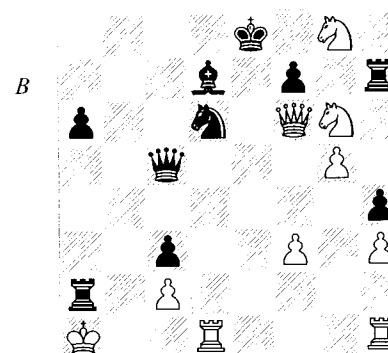
27 ♖xh7! 1-0

Simple and strong. Black resigned in anticipation of the forthcoming mate: 27...♗xh7 28 ♖h1+ ♔g8 29 ♖h8#.

2) Bosten – Ranker

Germany 2000

29...♖xa2+! (D)



Removing the last bit of pawn-cover around the white king.

30 ♖xa2 ♖a5+ 0-1

3) Skuya – Rosenberg

Riga 1962

1 ♗xf8+!

This move diverts Black's f7-rook, which is guarding the h7-pawn.

1...♖xf8 2 ♖xh7+!

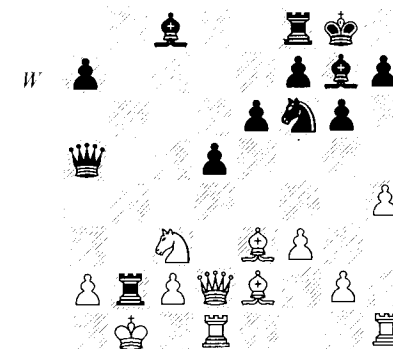
The natural follow-up to White's last move.

2...♗xh7 3 ♖h1+ ♙h3 4 ♖xh3#

4) Hidegh – Nandor

Sarospatak Ch 1998

14...♖xb2+! (D)



Making maximum use of the dark squares.

15 ♖xb2 ♖b4+ 16 ♖c1

16 ♖a1 ♖e4 +.

16...♖e4! + 17 fxe4

17 ♖xe4 ♖b2#.

17...♖xc3 0-1

5) Bachmann – Dahlheimer

Germany tt 1997/8

33...♖a1+! 0-1

Allowing the queen to enter. White resigned here rather than see the finish: 34 ♖xa1 (34 ♖c2 ♖a4+ 35 b3 ♖a2#) 34...♖a4+ 35 ♖b1 ♖d1+ 36 ♖a2 ♖a8+.

6) Morphy – J. Thompson

New York 1859

25 ♖c6+!

Making room for the other bishop to land on a6 with mate.

25...bxc6 26 ♙a6# (1-0)

7) **Bianchi – Laurencena***corr. OL 1987-94***22 ♖xb6! 1-0**

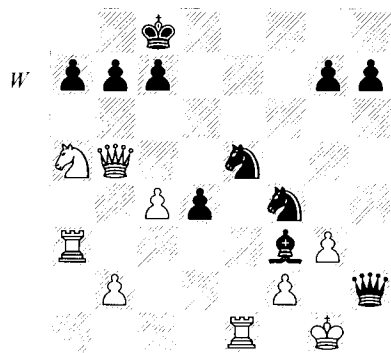
Black's dark-squared bishop was the only piece holding the queenside together, so White eliminates it. Black resigned because of 22...♖xb6 23 ♖b1+ ♖a7 24 ♖xa5, when as well as being a piece up White is threatening mate.

8) **Alekhine – Reshevsky***Kemer 1937***35 ♖xb8+!**

Nudging the black king over to the corner.

35...♖xb8 36 ♖xe5+! 1-0

Black resigned as he will get mated on the back rank; e.g., 36...fxe5 37 ♖f8+ ♖e8 38 ♖xe8+ ♖d8 39 ♖xd8#.

9) **Emmrich – Moritz***Bad Oeynhausen 1922***1...♖xh2+! (D)**

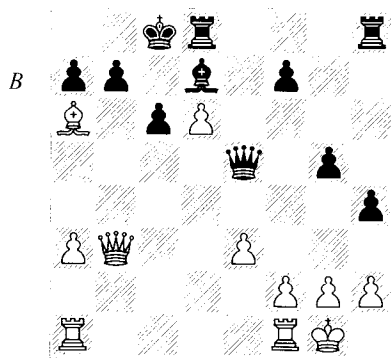
A check and a capture – one of the first moves that should be looked at!

2 ♖xh2 ♖g4+

Three minor pieces when working well together can be an unstoppable attacking force, as this game shows.

3 ♖g1 ♖h3+ 4 ♖f1 ♖h2# (0-1)

A beautiful finish!

10) **T. Karolyi – Shrenzel***Tel Aviv 1990***1 ♖a6! (D)**

Opening the b-file for White's major pieces to work down.

1...bxa6 2 ♖ab1 ♖b5

Black has to try to block the b-file.

3 ♖c3 1-0

Black resigned due to 3...♖a4 4 ♖c5 or 3...♖d5 4 ♖fd1 ♖f5 5 e4 ♖xe4 6 ♖b3.

11) **V. Borisenko – Nakhimovskaya***USSR Cht 1968***37 ♖xh7+!**

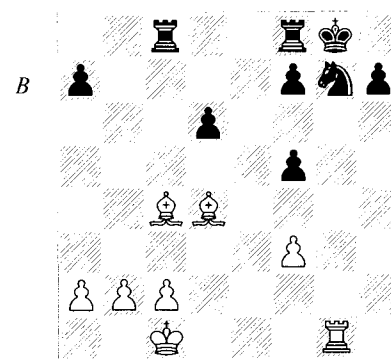
The h-file must be opened one way or another!

37...♖xh7 38 g6+ ♖h8 39 ♖g5! 1-0

Black resigned due to 39...fxg5 40 hxg5#.

12) **S. Williams – A. Wohl***British League (4NCL) 2002/3***21 ♖a7+ ♖c8 22 ♖a8+! 1-0**

Black resigned in view of 22...♖xa8 (22...♖d7 23 ♖xb7 +-) 23 ♖a7#.

13) **Chatalbashev – V. Georgiev***Saint Vincent 2002***24 ♖xg7+! ♖xg7 25 ♖g1 +- (D)**

Bishops coordinate very well with rooks and this game is no exception.

25...♖xc4 26 ♖xg7+ ♖h8 27 ♖f6 1-0

Due to 27...h5 28 ♖g4+ ♖h7 29 ♖xc4.

14) **Vasić – S. Mirković***corr. 1979***17...♖xb2+!**

Opening up the white king to a battering down the b-file. This combination works due to White's lack of piece development: White's rooks are a long

way away from getting connected and guarding the b1-square.

18 ♖xb2 ♖b6+ 19 ♖a1

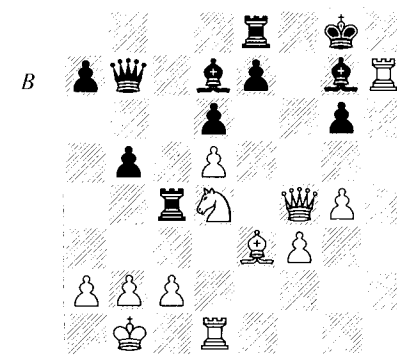
19 ♖b5 ♖e6! 20 ♖xd6 ♖xb5+ 21 ♖a1 (21 ♖c3 ♖c8+ -) 21...♖xc2#.

19...♖b8 20 ♖b5

20 ♖b1 ♖xb1+! 21 ♖xb1 ♖xc2# is a nice finish.

20...♖e6 0-1

White wisely resigned here.

15) **Ardeshi – Hayrapetian***Fajr 2001***22 ♖xh7! (D)**

A common theme: Black's position quickly falls apart.

22...♖xd5

22...♖xh7 23 ♖f7! +- was White's idea: Black is powerless to stop ♖h1#.

23 ♖xg7+!

Removing the sole defender of the black king.

23...♖xg7 24 ♖f5+ +-

Another strong plan is 24 ♖h6+ ♖f7 25 ♖h7+ ♖f6 (or 25...♖f8 26 ♖h6#) 26 g5+ ♖e5 27 ♖g7#.

16) P. Fossan – Ward

Gausdal (Arnold Cup) 1987

12...♖xf3!

Weakening e4 and unblocking the g7-bishop.

13 ♖xf3 ♖xe4!

Now the bishops can have free range of the white king!

14 ♖d3

14 ♖xe4 ♖xa2+ 15 ♖c1 ♖a1#.

14...♖xc3+ 15 bxc3 ♖xc3 0-1

17) Short – Velikov

Solingen – Slavija ECC 1987

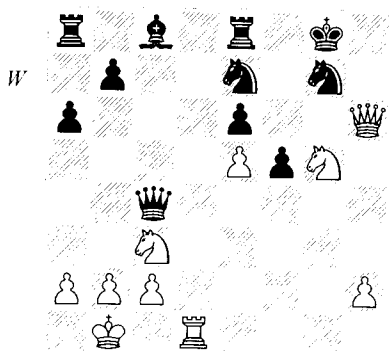
24 ♖xg7+!

Opening the g-file and allowing a white knight to jump to g5.

24...♖xg7 25 ♖g5

25 ♖g1? is wrong since Black can reply 25...♖g4!.

25...♖e8 (D)



26 ♖g1

Going for the magic number of three attacking pieces, which is normally enough to win against a lone king.

26...♖d4

26...♖g4 does not help Black now that the f8-rook has moved off the f-file: White can play 27 ♖xg4 fxg4 28 ♖ce4 +-.

26...♖d5 loses to 27 ♖h7+ ♖f8 28 ♖xe6+.

27 ♖h7+ ♖f8 28 ♖xe6+

Always look for checks and captures!

28...♖xe6

28...♖xe6 29 ♖xg7#.

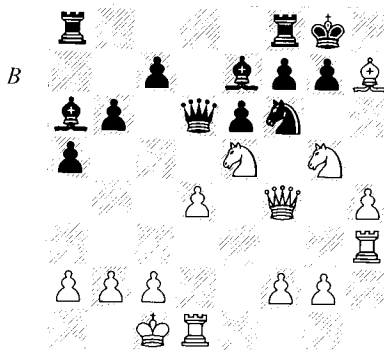
29 ♖h6+ 1-0

It is mate after 29...♖f7 30 ♖f6#.

18) Arakhamia-Grant – Bin Sattar

British Ch (Edinburgh) 2003

16 ♖xh7+! (D)



Removing the pawn-cover around Black's king, so that White's major pieces can enter the attack.

16...♖xh7

16...♖h8 17 ♖xf7+ +-.

17 ♖xf7 ♖xe5

Desperate but Black was lost anyway – 18 ♖g3 was coming with mate to follow; for example, 17...♖d5 18

♖g3 ♖f6 (18...♖f6 19 ♖xg7+ ♖xg7 20 ♖h6+ ♖g8 21 ♖g6#) 19 ♖h6+ ♖h8 20 ♖g6# is one nice line.

18 ♖h6+ gxf6 19 ♖xe5 ♖d6 20 ♖g3+ 1-0

19) Dvoirys – Feher

Budapest 1991

24 ♖g5! 1-0

Black resigned because of the following possible lines:

a) 24...♖xg5 25 ♖h8+ ♖g7 26 ♖3h7#.

b) 24...♖xd5 25 ♖h8+ ♖xh8 26 ♖xd8+ ♖g7 27 ♖xh8#.

c) 24...♖c8 25 ♖xf6+ ♖xf6 26 ♖xf6 ♖xf6 27 ♖h8+ ♖g7 28 ♖3h7#.

20) M. Pavlović – Čabrilo

Čačak 1991

1...♖b3+!

Removing the pawn from a2!

2 axb3 ♖c5 +-.

White can't stop ...♖xb3+.

3 ♖d3 ♖xd3

A bit cheeky since 3...♖xb3+ wins the white queen.

4 ♖xd3 ♖xb3+ 5 ♖c2 ♖xd2 0-1

A queen is a queen.

21) Korchnoi – Veinger

Beersheba 1978

23 ♖xb7+!

The first move that should be analysed!

23...♖xb7 24 ♖b5+ ♖c8

24...♖a8 does little to help Black's cause, because 25 ♖d2!, preventing 25...♖c1+, wins on the spot.

25 ♖h3+ 1-0

The bishop finds itself a more attractive diagonal. After 25...♖d8 26 ♖xc6 Black will get mated on either a8 or d7.

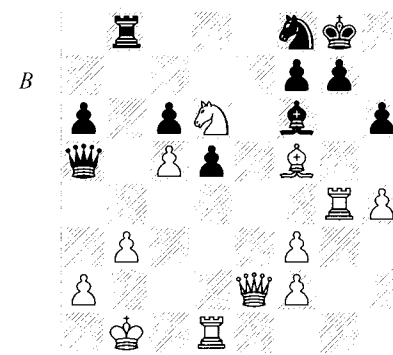
22) Pelaez – Dovitiis

Havana 1993

22...♖e2!

Deflecting the white queen away from its defensive duties. 22...♖xb3+? is a mistake here as White can recapture on b3 with his queen: 23 ♖xb3 +-.

23 ♖xe2 (D)



23...♖xb3+!

This works now that White can't play ♖xb3.

24 ♖c1

24 axb3 ♖a1+ 25 ♖c2 ♖b2+ 26 ♖d3 ♖c3#.

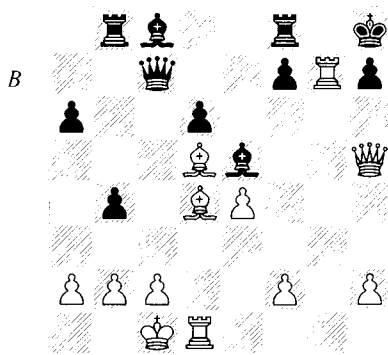
24...♖c3+ 0-1

In view of 25 ♖c2 ♖b1+! 26 ♖xb1 ♖a1#. A good demonstration of the power of the dark-squared bishop in such positions.

23) Graudins – Karklins

Latvia 1992

1 ♖xg7! (D)



The first move that should be looked at as it is a capture and leads to forcing play.

1... ♖xg7

1... ♖xg7 allows White to force mate by 2 ♖xg7+ ♖xg7 (2... ♖g8 3 ♖f6) 3 ♖g5+ ♖h8 4 ♖f6+ ♖g8 5 ♖g1+ ♖g4 6 ♖xg4#.

2 ♖g5+ ♖h8 3 ♖f6+! 1-0

Mate is coming: 3... ♖xf6 4 ♖xf6+ ♖g8 5 ♖g1+ ♖g4 6 ♖xg4#.

24) Fischer – Gligorić

Havana OL 1966

18 ♖xa6! ♖xh3

In a lost position Black lashes out. 18... ♖xa6 19 ♖xc6 ♖xg3 (19... ♖d7 20 ♖xa6+ ♖b7 21 ♖a7+ ♖b6 22 ♖a6#) 20 ♖xa6+ ♖b8 21 ♖a8+ ♖b7 22 ♖a6#.

19 e5!

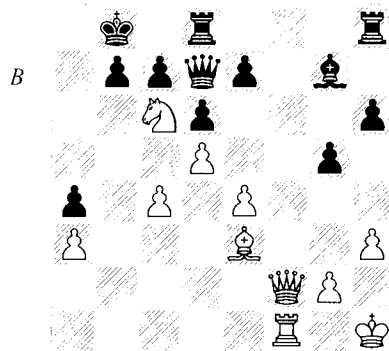
Winning a piece. The game concluded as follows:

19... ♖xe5 20 dxe5 fxe5 21 ♖c5+ ♖b8 22 gxh3 e4 23 ♖xe4 ♖e7 24 ♖c3 b5 25 ♖c2 1-0

25) Nimzowitsch – N. Lange

Berlin 1902

1 ♖c6+! (D)



Trying to open the b-file for the white rook.

1... ♖xc6

1... ♖c8 is a better try, but White is still on top after 2 ♖c2!, bringing the queen around to a4, and hopefully a8. After 2... ♖df8! (the only move since 2... ♖xc6? fails to 3 ♖xa4 ♖b7 4 ♖b1+ ♖c8 5 ♖a8#) 3 ♖b1 ± White is having all the fun.

2 ♖b1+ ♖c8

2... ♖a8? loses to 3 ♖d2 followed by ♖a5#.

3 ♖a7 ♖e8

The only way to stop an immediate ♖b8#.

Now:

a) 4 ♖f7?! was the move chosen by Nimzowitsch – a brilliant idea but it

gives Black chances to defend. Black played 4... ♖xf7 5 dxc6 ♖f1+! 6 ♖xf1 ♖d4! 7 ♖xd4 e5 and his king could run to the e7-square.

b) 4 ♖f5+! wins on the spot. 4... e6 5 dxe6 and ♖b8# is next.

c) 4 dxc6! is also simple and good. It is mate after 4... ♖xc6 5 ♖f5+ e6 6 ♖xe6+ ♖d7 7 ♖b8#.

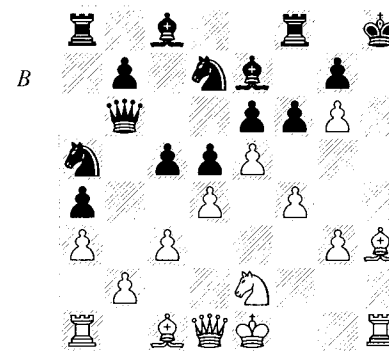
26) Middleburg – Michiels

Groningen 2001

17 ♖g6+!

Correctly opening up the h-file to conduct an assault on the black king.

17... ♖xg6 18 ♖xg6 (D)



18... ♖g8

The king has to try to run away, but now comes a swift finish.

19 ♖g1! +-

A nice move, making room for the queen to come to h5; the main threat now is 20 ♖xe6+ ♖xe6 21 ♖h8+ ♖xh8 22 ♖h5+ ♖g8 23 ♖h7#.

19 ♖xe6+? is a mistake since Black can defend with 19... ♖xe6 20 ♖f2 (20

♖g1 ♖f5) 20... ♖b6! 21 ♖h8+ ♖xh8 22 ♖h1+ ♖h3 -+.

19... ♖e8 20 ♖h5 ♖d6 21 ♖h8+ 1-0

27) D. Parr – R. Pert

Hastings Challengers 2001/2

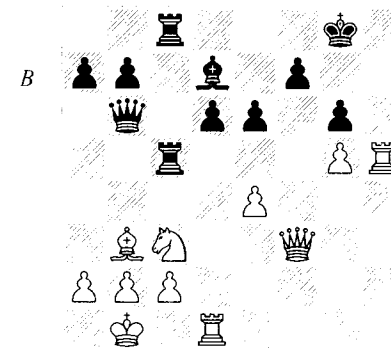
22... ♖b3! 0-1

Putting the b2-bishop under serious pressure. White could have played on a bit longer, but his position is losing: 23 c3 ♖xc3!? (23... ♖xb2+ 24 ♖xb2 ♖xf4 25 ♖e4 ♖xc3+ 26 ♖c2 ♖xe4+ 27 ♖xe4 d5 should be good for Black but is rather unclear) 24 axb3 c2+! 25 ♖xc2 ♖xb2+ 26 ♖d3 ♖b8. White's king is too exposed to last much longer.

28) Fischer – Gligorić

Bled/Zagreb/Belgrade Ct 1959

26 ♖xh5! (D)



A standard sacrifice in such positions. White opens up the h-file for his queen and rook to act down.

26... ♖xh5 27 ♖xh5 ♖e8

Other moves are even worse:

a) 27...♖f8 (trying to run away) 28 ♖h8+ ♗e7 29 ♖f6+ ♗e8 30 ♜h1 ♙b5 31 ♙xe6 fxe6 32 ♖xe6+ ♗d8 33 ♜h8+ ♗c7 34 ♖xc8#.

b) 27...♜xc3 (trying to drum up some counterplay) 28 g6 ♖f2 29 bxc3 ♗f8 30 g7+! ♗xg7 31 ♖g5+ ♗f8 32 ♜h1 +–.

28 ♖h6

Preventing the black king from running.

28...♜xc3

A search for counterplay.

29 bxc3 ♜xc3 30 g6!

Opening up the black king.

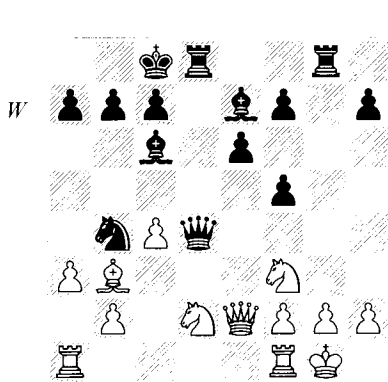
30...fxg6 31 ♜h1 ♖d4 32 ♖h7+ 1-0

It is mate after 32...♗f8 33 ♜f1+.

29) Spoelman – Stellwagen

Hoogeveen 2003

15...♖xd4! (D)



Trying to divert the white knight from f3 in order to play ...♜xg2+!

16 ♜xd4

This allows a nice checkmate but White's position was already doomed, since the f3-knight cannot continue to cover g2 on its own. 16 axb4 leads to a nice textbook finish after 16...♜xg2+! (another winning move is 16...♖g4 but it is always pleasant to finish the game off with checks) 17 ♗xg2 ♖g4+ 18 ♗h1 ♜xd2! (the c6-bishop really comes into its own) 19 ♖xd2 ♙xf3#.

16...♜xg2+ 17 ♗h1 ♜g1+! 0-1

A unique finish. White resigned because after 18 ♗xg1 ♜g8+ it is mate next move.

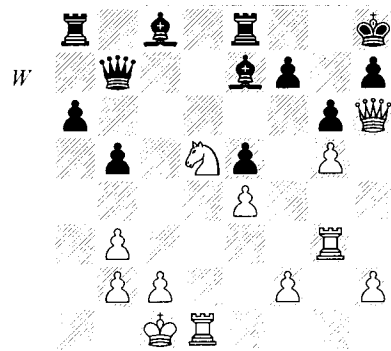
30) Emelin – Nepomnishay

St Petersburg Ch 1996

21 ♙xe5+!

Opening up the d-file so White's d1-rook can play a major part in the following combination.

21...dxe5 (D)



22 ♜f6 1-0

Mate is now forced: 22...♙xf6 23 gxf6 ♜g8 24 ♜d8! (the point!) 24...♙d7 25 ♖g7#.

31) Balogh – Gromer

Prague OL 1931

21 ♖a8+ ♜b8 22 ♖xb7+!

The power of White's bishops, combined with the b1-rook, is very impressive. Mate is unstoppable.

22...♗xb7 23 ♙xd7+ 1-0

Black resigned in view of the following lines:

a) 23...♙a6 24 ♙c8+ ♗a5 25 ♜c4+ ♗a4 26 ♜b4# is a picturesque position.

b) 23...♗a8 24 ♜xb8+! (this removes the last defender of the black king, and more importantly the c6-square is now available to the d7-bishop) 24...♗xb8 25 ♜b1+ ♗a8 26 ♙c6#.

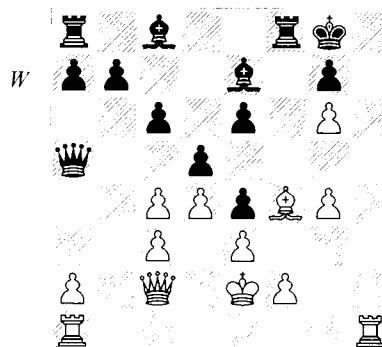
32) Aagaard – L. Williams

Hampstead 1998

16 ♜g6+!

Opening the h-file with devastating effect.

16...hxcg6 17 hxcg6+ ♗g8 (D)



18 ♖c1!

The threat is ♜h8+!, ♖h1+ and ♖h7# – a tricky one to stop as I found out!

18...♖d8

The idea is to try to hold up White's attack with 19...♙h4.

18...♜xf4 is another try but White still wins:

a) 19 exf4 is one good option: 19...♙d6 (trying to give the black king some space to run to: 19...♙f6? 20 g5 +–) 20 ♜h8+ (20 ♖e3 ±) 20...♗xh8 21 ♖h1+ ♗g8 22 ♖h7+ ♗f8 23 ♖h8+ ♗e7 24 ♖xg7+ ♗d8 25 ♜h1 ♖xa2+ 26 ♗f1 ♖b1+ 27 ♗g2 ♖xh1+ 28 ♗xh1 +– and White's g-pawn will decide the day.

b) 19 ♜h8+! ♗xh8 20 ♖h1+ ♙h4 21 ♖xh4+ ♗g8 22 exf4 +–.

19 ♙c7

Deflecting the black queen away from its defensive duties. 19 ♜h8+! is thematic and winning: 19...♗xh8 20 ♖h1+ ♙h4 21 g5 ♜xf4 22 exf4 ♗g8 23 ♖xh4 ♖e8 24 ♖h7+ ♗f8 25 ♖h8+ ♗e7 26 ♖xg7+ ♗d8 (26...♙d6 27 c5#) 27 ♜h1 +–.

19...♜xf2+

Desperation; maybe a better try is 19...♙h4 20 ♙xd8 ♜xf2+ 21 ♙d1 ♙xd8 22 ♗e1 ♜f3 23 ♗e2 ♜g3, but White is still winning rather easily.

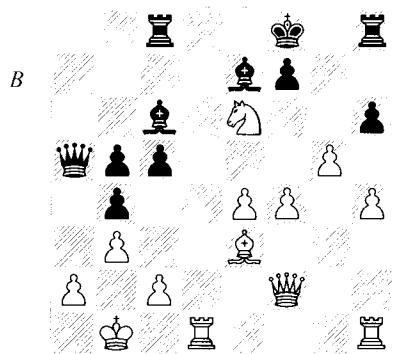
20 ♗xf2 +– ♙h4+ 21 ♗e2 ♖g5 22 ♖g1 e5 23 ♖h2 ♙xg4+ 24 ♙d2 exd4 25 cxd4 dxc4 1-0

33) Shirov – Svidler

Moscow rpd 2002

25 ♙xe6+! (D)

Opening up the f-file for White to attack down. 25 f5 ♖a8 26 a4 is another good option, but the game continuation is more thematic: attacking all the way!



25...fxe6

25...♙g8 26 gxh6 ♖xh6 27 f5 +-.

26 f5 ♖e8

Other moves are no better; for example, 26...♖h7 27 g6 ♖a8 28 fxe6+ ♙g8 (28...♙e8 29 ♖f7+! {nice!} 29...♖xf7 30 gxf7+ ♙f8 31 ♙xh6#) 29 gxh7+ +-; 26...♙g8 27 ♖g3 ♖h7 28 gxh6+ ♙f8 29 ♖hg1 +-.

27 fxe6 1-0

Black resigned because of the following possible lines: 27...♖h7 28 g6 ♖a8 29 ♖f7+! ♖xf7 30 gxf7+ ♙f8 31 ♙xh6#; 27...♖f8 28 ♖e2 ♙d8 29 ♖h5+ ♙e7 30 ♙xc5+ +-.

34) J. Polgar – Berkes

Budapest 2003

18 ♖h7+!

This move gives White a decisive advantage.

18...♙xh7 19 ♖h2+ ♙g8

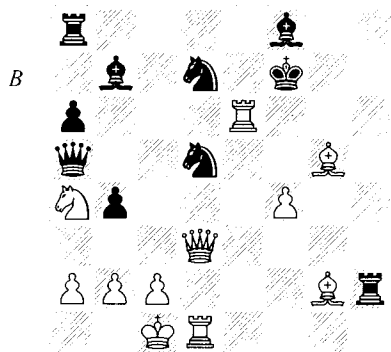
The main point of the combination is that White can meet 19...♙g7 with 20 ♖h6+ ♙g8 21 ♙xg6! +-.

20 ♖h1 ♙xg5+ 21 ♙xg5 ♖xg5+ 22 f4 ♖xf4+ 23 ♖xf4 ♙xe4 24 ♖xe4 1-0

35) Kasparov – Van Wely

Wijk aan Zee 2000

22 ♖d3! (D)



Very nice. White's queen is needed over on the kingside in order to mate Black. f5 and g6 are both excellent squares for it to land on. When trying to attack it is always worth considering where your pieces are best placed and this is what White has done here.

22...♙g7

Other moves do not help Black's cause either:

a) 22...♙xe6 23 ♙xd5+ ♙xd5 (or 23...♖xd5? 24 ♖g6+ ♙f6 25 ♖xf6+ ♙d7 26 ♖xd5+ +-) 24 ♖g6+ ♙f6 25 ♖xf6+ ♙d7 26 ♖xd5+! ♖xd5 27 ♙b6+ +-.

b) 22...♙g8 23 ♖g6+ ♙h8 (after 23...♙g7 White forces a win by 24 ♙xd5 ♙xd5 25 ♖e7 ♖h7 26 ♙h6 ♙f8 27 ♖de1 +-) 24 ♖e2! (25 ♙xd5 is one nasty idea behind this move, when mate is threatened on g8 and h2) 24...♙e7 25 ♙xe7 ♙g7 26 ♖xd7 ♖xa4 27 ♙xb7 ♖xe2 28 ♖h5+ ♙g8 29 ♙d5+ +-.

23 ♖f5+ ♙g8 24 ♖xd5 ♖xa4 25 ♖e7 1-0

Checkmate is inevitable.

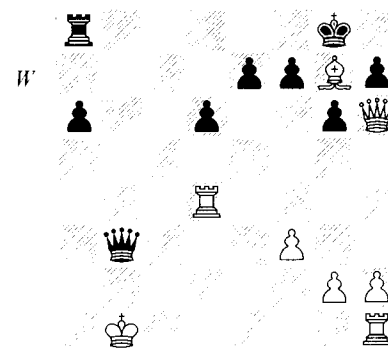
36) Tebb – Ward

British Ch (Torquay) 1998

24...♖xb3+!

Opening up the white queenside. The combination of queen and rook attacking is especially powerful here.

25 axb3 ♖xb3+ (D)



26 ♙c1

After 26 ♙a1 Black has a few attractive options. The quiet move 26...♖b8 forces mate; e.g., 27 ♖d2 (27 ♖c1 ♖b5 +-) 27...f6! +- and White cannot stop ...♖a3+ followed by ...♖c3+ with mate next move.

26...♖c8+ 27 ♙d2 ♖c2+!

27...♖c2+ also seems strong but is not quite as good; for example, 28 ♙e1 ♖xg2 29 ♖f1 g5! and Black has the advantage.

28 ♙e1 ♖e6+!

An important check. Black wishes to dislodge White's d4-rook from its defensive post.

29 ♖e4 ♖a2 +-

Now 30...♖b1+ will be terminal; if Black had not inserted 28...♖e6+, then White would have had ♖d1 in reply.

30 ♙f1 ♖f2+ 31 ♙e1

31 ♙g1 ♖xg2+ 32 ♙f1 ♖f2#.

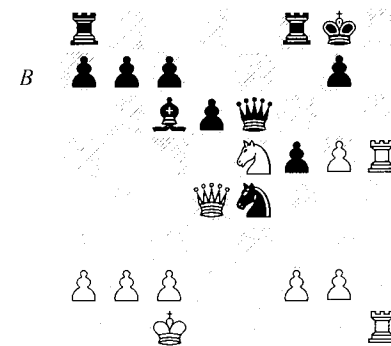
31...♖xg2 32 ♖c1 ♖f2+ 33 ♙d1 ♖xf3+ 0-1

It is mate after 34 ♙e1 ♖xe4+ 35 ♙f1 ♖e2#.

37) Alekhine – Van Mindeno

Netherlands simul 1933

16 ♙e5!! (D)



A great move: White must deny Black the f7-square. Another strong move is 16 ♖h7!? ♖g6 17 ♖c4+ d5 18

♖h8+ ♜f7 19 ♜e5+ ♜e6 20 ♜xg6 ♖xh8 21 ♖xh8 ♖xh8 22 ♖f1, when White has a large advantage but the game goes on. 16 g6? is not good though: 16...♖xg6 17 ♖c4+ d5 and Black is better.

16...dxe5

16...♖xe5 17 g6 +-.

17 g6! 1-0

Black threw in the towel due to 17...♖xg6 18 ♖c4+, when White has denied Black the f7-square.

38) Bakulin – Bronstein

USSR Ch (Kiev) 1964/5

27...♙d3!?

Inspired!

28 ♖xd3 ♖g1+! 29 ♜xg1 e2+ 30 ♜e3

30 ♜h1 ♖f2 31 ♖f5+ ♜b8 32 ♖g4 exf1 ♖+ 33 ♖xf1 ♖xf1+ 34 ♖g1 ♖e1 +.

30...♖xe3 31 ♖f5+ ♖e6+ 32 ♜h1 ♖f2 0-1

39) Cappelo – Zargouni

Tunis 1979

1 hxg6!

Opening up lines towards the black king.

1...♖xh3 2 ♖e5+ f6

Or: 2...♜g8 3 gxh7+ +-; 2...♜h6 3 g7 +-.

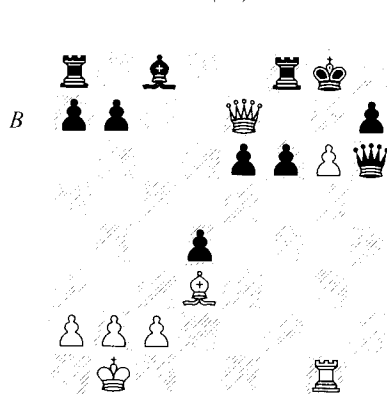
3 ♖c7+ ♜g8

Alternatively: 3...♜h6 4 ♖xh7+ +-; 3...♜h8 4 g7+ +-.

4 ♖g1!

A good example of how to make maximum use of all your pieces.

4...♖h6 5 ♖e7! (D)



Black is tied down while White is threatening g7.

5...♙d7 6 ♖xd7 ♖ac8

Others:

a) 6...♖ad8 7 ♖xe6+ is similar to the game but White sometimes has the option of playing ♙c4+, which is obviously to his advantage.

b) 6...♖ae8 7 g7 +-.

7 ♖xe6+ ♜g7 8 ♖e7+ ♜g8

Now 9 ♙c4+! ♖xc4 10 g7 forces mate.

40) Rubinstein – Teichmann

Vienna 1908

21 h6!

With this move White opens up two major lines against the black king. The f3-knight is of little concern to White.

21...f6

Trying to keep some lines closed. Other moves:

a) 21...exf3 22 gxf7+ ♖xf7 (alternatively, 22...♜xf7 23 ♖g6+ ♜g8 24 hxg7 +-) 23 hxg7! +-.

b) 21...fxg6! 22 h7! ♜f7 23 ♜h4 g5 24 ♜f5 ♖c7 (or 24...♖f6 25 ♖xg5! ♖xg5 26 ♜xd6+ ♜e7 27 ♜xe8 ♖xe8 28 ♖xc4 ♜d6 29 ♖g8 +-) 25 ♖xg5 g6 26 ♖e2! with a big attack.

22 hxg7 exf3

22...♖e6 23 ♖h8+ ♜xg7 24 ♖h7+ ♜f8 25 ♖xb7 exf3 26 g7+ ♜g8 27 ♖h7+! ♜xh7 28 g8 ♖+ ♜h6 29 ♖g6#.

23 ♖h8+ ♜xg7 24 ♖h7+ ♜g8 25 ♖f5!

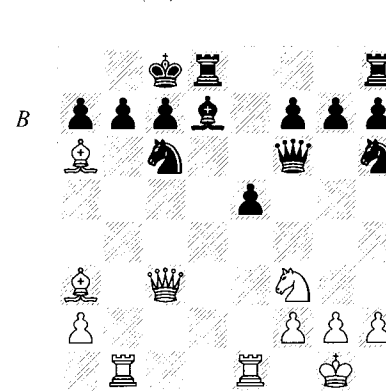
White's queen enters the attack with devastating effect.

25...c3 26 ♖xe7 1-0

41) P. Morphy – E. Morphy

New Orleans 1850

15 ♙a6! (D)



White opens up the black king's defences.

15...♙a5?

After this move the win is simple. Taking the bait was better and would seem to lead to approximately equal chances with best play: 15...bxa6 16 ♖b3 (simple chess; the point of 15

♙a6 is that now Black cannot play ...b6) and then:

a) 16...♜b4!? is an interesting way to try to stop White's play down the b-file, but White will keep enduring pressure after 17 ♖xb4 ♙b5 18 ♖xe5 ♖he8 19 ♙b2. White wishes to play a4 at some point, and the position is unclear. Against another human I would rather play White, though against a strong computer I might be a bit concerned.

b) 16...♙g4 17 ♖b7+ ♜d7 18 ♖bd1+ ♜e8 19 ♖xd8+ and here:

b1) 19...♖xd8? 20 ♖xc6+ ♖d7 (not 20...♙d7? 21 ♖xe5+ +-) 21 ♖xe5+ ♙e6 22 ♖xa6 ±. White's a3-bishop is very annoying for Black. It is not clear where Black should put his king, and meanwhile White can slowly increase the pressure.

b2) 19...♜xd8? 20 ♖xc7 ♙e6 (trying to block the e-file; 20...♙xf3? 21 ♖xe5+ ♜e6 22 ♖c8+ ♖d8 23 ♖xe6+ fxe6 24 ♖xe6+ ♖e7 25 ♖xe7#) 21 ♜xe5 leaves Black seriously tied up. White is winning; e.g., 21...♜f5 22 ♖d1! and 23 ♜c6 comes next, with mate or material gain.

b3) 19...♜xd8! is clearly Black's best move, and should lead to a roughly equal position. Defending and finding such moves is always harder than attacking and letting your opponent find the 'only' moves. 20 ♖d1+ ♜e8 21 ♖xc7 ♖e6! (the only move; for example, 21...♜d8? 22 ♜xe5! ♙e6 23 ♜c6 +-; 21...e4? 22 ♜e5! +-) 22 ♖d6 ♖c8 and Black is just about holding on. For example, 23 ♖xc6 ♖xc7 24 ♖xc7

♙d8 25 ♖xa7 ♙xf3 26 gxf3 ♖e8 and then:

b31) 27 ♖xa6 leads to an unclear ending. White has a strong passed a-pawn but his kingside is seriously weakened.

b32) 27 ♙c1! is probably best and leads to a slightly better position for White after 27...♗e7 28 ♖a8+ ♙d7 29 ♙xh6 gxh6 30 ♖xa6, but a draw would be a fair result.

16 ♖ec1

Piling on the pressure.

16...♙c6 17 ♖xa5 bxa6 18 ♖xa6+ ♙d7 19 ♖xc6 +-.

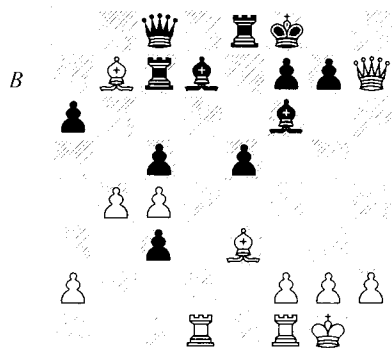
The game finished as follows:

19...♗f5 20 ♖xc7+! ♙e8 21 ♖c6+ ♙d7 22 ♖b8!? ♖xc6 23 ♖e7+ ♙f8 24 ♖xd8+ ♖e8 25 ♖dx8# (1-0)

42) Murey – Grinberg

Ramat Gan 1980

22 ♙b7!! (D)



This shocking little move puts an end to any serious resistance from Black.

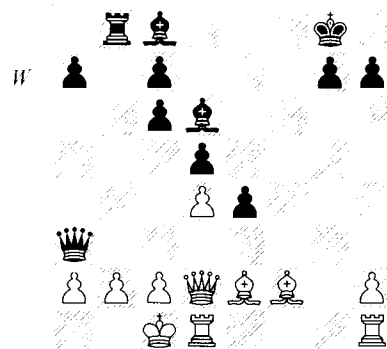
22...♙f5

Desperation. Other moves are no better though: 22...♖xb7 23 ♙xc5+ +-; 22...♗xb7 23 ♖xd7! +-.
23 ♖h8+ ♙e7 24 ♙xc8 ♖xh8 25 ♙xf5 +- cxb4 26 c5 ♖b8 27 ♖d6 a5 28 ♖a6 ♖b5 29 ♖d1 g6 30 ♙c2 1-0

43) Bird – Morphy

London 1858

18...♖a3!! (D)



A truly original idea – Black gave up a whole rook just to play ...♖a3. White's defence is now extremely difficult.

19 c3

The only sensible way to stop mate on b2.

19...♖xa2 20 b4

Again White's has no real choice.

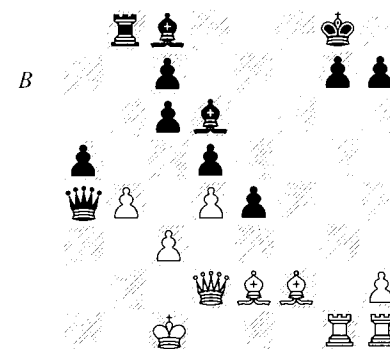
20...♖a1+ 21 ♙c2 ♖a4+ 22 ♙b2??

A slight error. White would have better practical chances of defending with 22 ♙c1, but Black is still winning after the quiet but deadly 22...a5!. Once the b-file is open White has little

hope of defending. White has many moves all leading to the same result: a brief look at some of these lines will prove this:

a) 23 ♙g3 (White tries to exchange some pieces, but with little success) 23...axb4 24 ♖c2 (24 ♙xd6 ♖a1+ 25 ♙c2 b3#) 24...b3 25 ♖b1 e3 +- and White is powerless to stop all of Black's threats.

b) 23 ♖dgl (D) is a tricky move:



b1) 23...♖a3+?! 24 ♖b2 only helps White, as the pressure is relaxed.

b2) 23...axb4?? is a blunder allowing White to force mate: 24 ♖xg7+! ♙xg7 25 ♖g5+ ♙f8 26 ♖f6+ ♙e8 27 ♙h5+ ♙d7 28 ♖f5+ ♙d8 29 ♙h4+ ♙e7 30 ♖f8+ ♙d7 31 ♖xe7#. Certainly not what Morphy had intended after 18...♖a3!

b3) 23...g6?! is interesting, stopping any tricks that White had planned and getting ready to play ...axb4. A possible line might be 24 ♖c2 ♖a3+ 25 ♖b2 axb4! (not fearing the queen exchange), and here:

b31) 26 ♖xa3 (it is natural for White to swap the queens off) 26...bxa3 27 ♙g3 ♙f8 leads to a very unclear position. After 28 ♙f4 ♖b2 Black's position is the easier to play; even a rook up White will find it hard to unravel. Then 29 ♖g2 ♙a6 30 ♙d2 e3 31 ♙xa6 exd2+ 32 ♖xd2 ♙h6 33 ♖hd1 ♙xd2+ 34 ♖xd2 ♖xd2 35 ♙xd2 a2 +- is one strange line.

b32) 26 cxb4 may be more accurate though:

b321) 26...♖a4!? 27 ♙d1 ♙f4+ 28 ♙b1 ♖xb4 29 ♖xb4 ♖xb4+ 30 ♙a2 ♙a6 is very unclear.

b322) 26...axb4 27 ♖xa3 ♙xa3+ 28 ♙c2 ♖b2+ and a draw is probably all that Black can get.

b4) 23...♙f5! is logical, developing a piece and stopping 24 ♖xg7+. Black should win now; for example:

b41) 24 ♖g5 ♙g6 25 ♙h5 ♖a1+ (or 25...axb4!) 26 ♙c2 ♖a2+ 27 ♙d1 (27 ♙c1 ♙xb4! 28 cxb4 e3! 29 ♙xg6 ♖d2+ 30 ♙b1 ♖xb4+ 31 ♙a1 ♖b2#) 27...♖b1+ 28 ♙d2 ♖d3+ 29 ♙e1 ♖xc3+ -+.

b42) 24 ♖c2 ♖xc2+ 25 ♙xc2 e3+ 26 ♙d3 exf2 27 ♖f1 ♙xd3+ 28 ♙xd3 axb4 29 ♖xf2 bxc3 30 ♙xc3 c5 ♖.

b43) 24 ♙e3 ♙xb4! (this is even stronger than 24...axb4) 25 cxb4 ♖xb4 26 ♖c2 ♖a3+ 27 ♙d2 ♖b2 ♖.

22...axb4 23 cxb4 ♖xb4+ 24 ♖xb4 ♖xb4+ +- 25 ♙c2 e3! 26 ♙xe3 ♙f5+ 27 ♖d3

27 ♙d3 ♖c4+.

27...♖c4+ 28 ♙d2 ♖a2+ 29 ♙d1 ♖b1+ 0-1

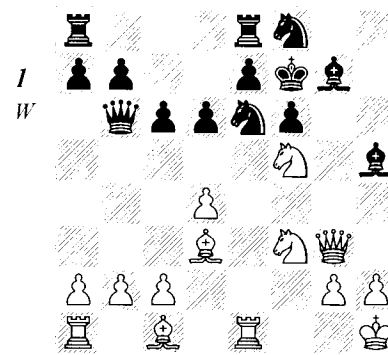
6 Expect the Unexpected

How many chess-players recognize the following scenario? The game has been developing perfectly: you have gained a nice advantage from the opening. This advantage has developed into a big attack, which you think should be winning in a matter of moves. Then all of a sudden, bang! From nowhere, your opponent plays a ridiculous-looking move that turns the tables in his favour!

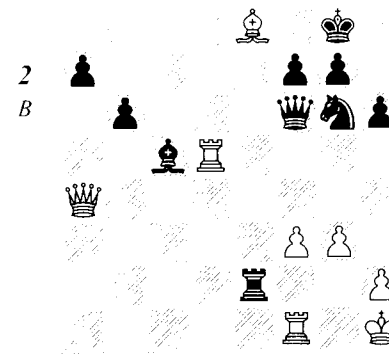
I know it has happened to me plenty of times, and it's not a pleasant feeling. What to do about such cases? Expect the unexpected! In many of these cases, the turning of the tide can be put down to lack of attention. A player feels safe and loses interest in what is developing on the board. Instead of fully concentrating on the game, the mind starts to wonder, maybe thinking about the best way to celebrate in the evening. A false sense of security has been many a player's downfall. So what is the moral of the story? Only relax when you have handed in the score-sheets, not before!

The following puzzles all include shocking little moves that are not obvious, so good luck in solving them!

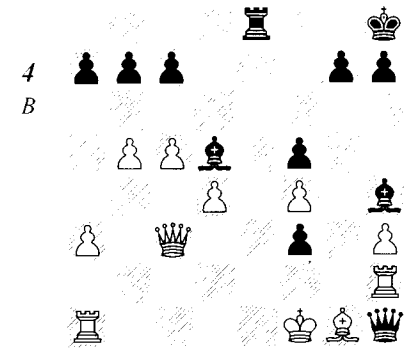
Puzzles



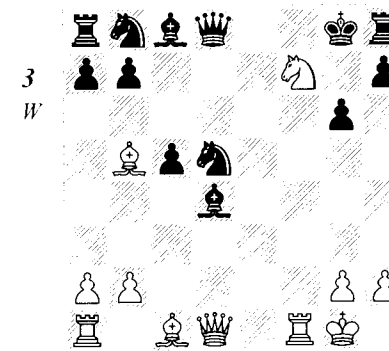
It is clear that Black's king is very exposed, while White has many pieces attacking. How did White finish Black off?



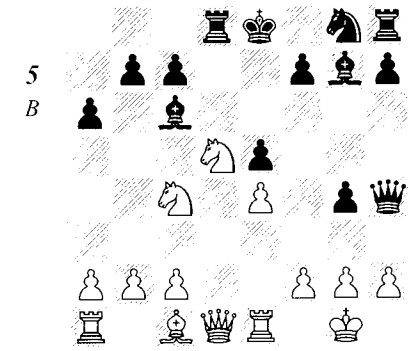
White's king has been weakened by the moves f3 and g3, and it also lacks defenders. How can Black stop any resistance from White?



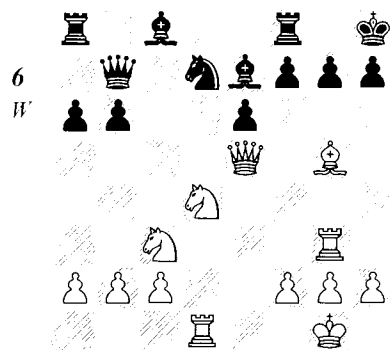
Black's queen is lost in the given position, but this didn't seem to bother Black. What did he play?



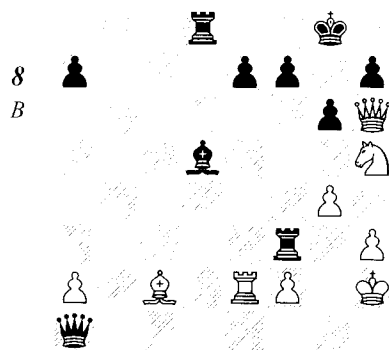
Black has just played 16...♙d4+?? and was probably very shocked by White's reply. What was it?



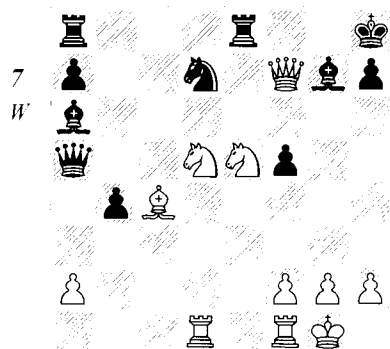
Black has a rather surprising way to win a piece here. What is it?



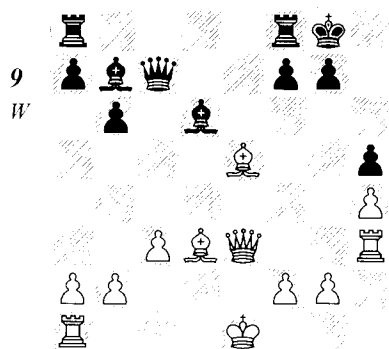
Black's kingside is in serious danger, especially on the g7-square, which has White's queen and rook lined up against it. 21 ♖xg7+ is tempting, but is there a better option?



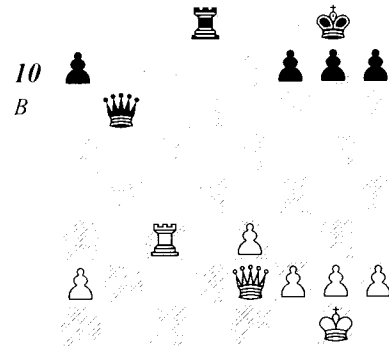
Black has an overwhelming advantage here. How did he force checkmate in three moves?



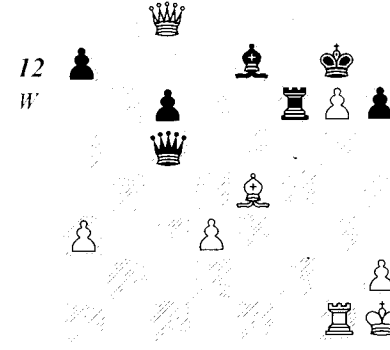
White has a pair of very strong knights dominating the centre of the board. How can he force checkmate?



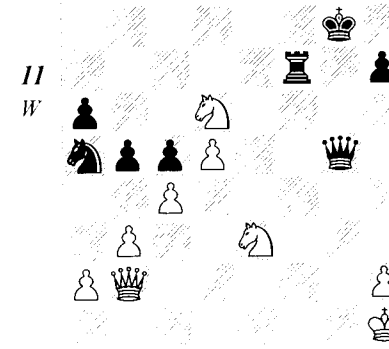
White needs to act quickly before Black can simplify the position and start attacking White's king, which is still yet to castle. How did White force the win with his next shocking move?



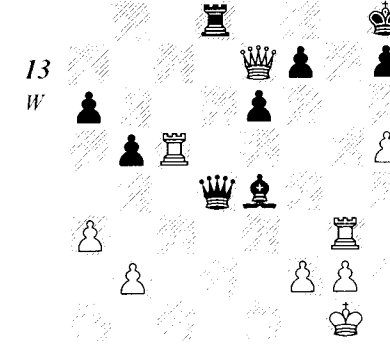
At first glance this position looks rather harmless as there is a serious lack of pieces left on the board; but under more careful inspection it is clear that White's back rank is very weak. How should Black take advantage of this?



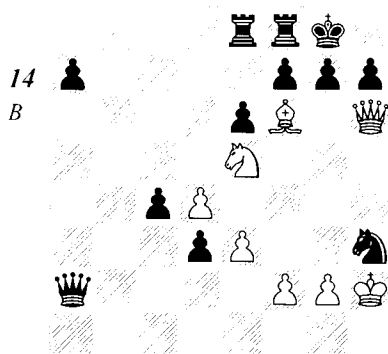
White's main asset here is his pawn on g6. How can he use this to devastating effect?



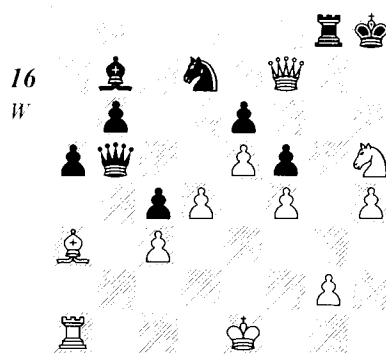
Black was probably expecting 30 ♖xf7 here, when he has some chances of survival, but White has a much stronger move. What is it?



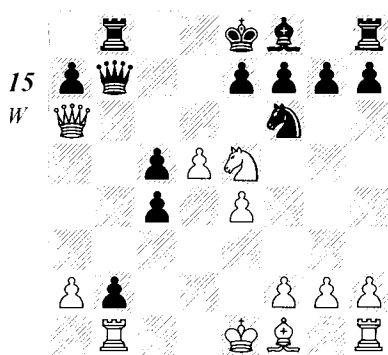
Black's king is lacking squares. If the black rook moved away from the back rank then ♖f8# would be mate. Moreover, if the black queen moved, then either ♖f6 would be mate, or the black rook would drop. How did White force one of these things to happen?



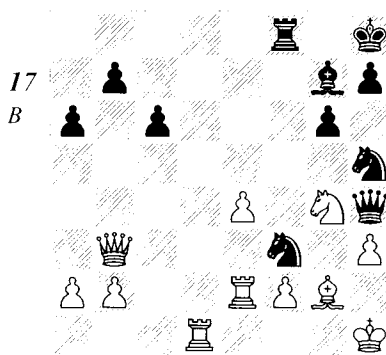
White has just played the bizarre ♖h5-h6, an amazing idea. Two questions here. How would White win if Black plays ...gxf6? And can Black defend against mate?



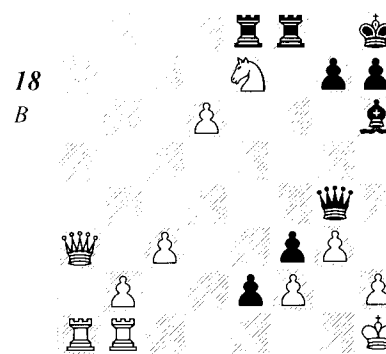
White is attacking here with the combination of queen and knight – a deadly duo in most cases, and this is no exception. 28 ♘f6 is a good option but it allows Black some chances of survival. There is a stronger move: what is it?



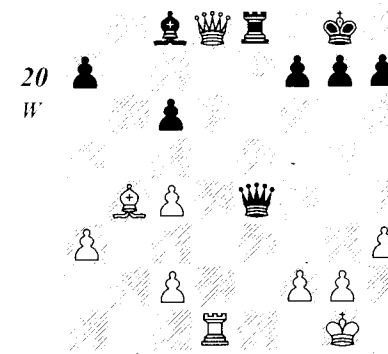
This position arose in a blitz game between two highly talented players. Black has just played 12...♗d7-b7??. which loses to White's reply. What was that reply?



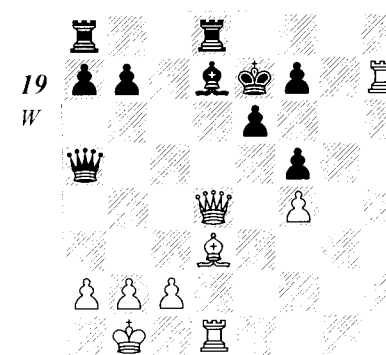
Black's knights are jiggling the dance of death around White's king. How can Black use these knights to obtain the better position?



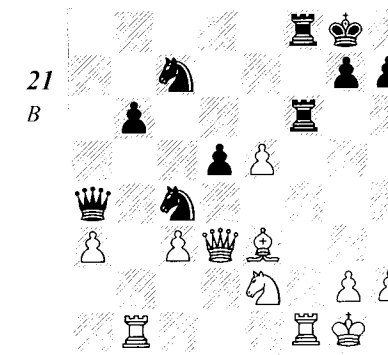
Black has a mass of pawns on the kingside. How can he get them rolling?



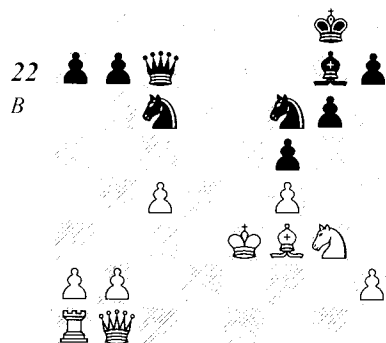
Black's back rank stands out as being especially weak, but it is not clear how White can take advantage of it. What should White play?



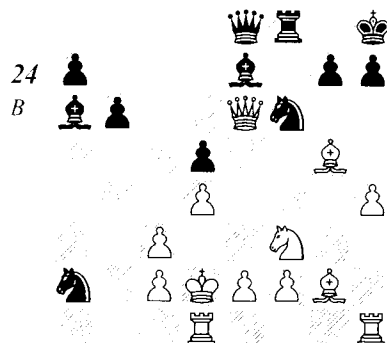
After White's next move Black immediately resigned. What did White play?



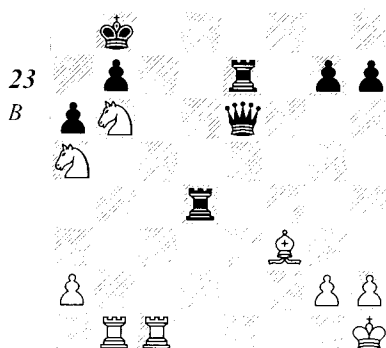
White's main problem is his insecure bishop on e3. The other white pieces are also uncoordinated. How should Black take advantage of all this?



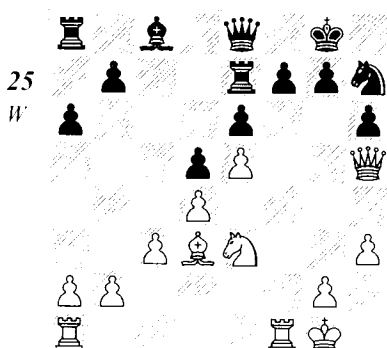
White's king is feeling very lonely stuck in the middle of the board without much protection. White's queen and rook also play no part in the game, and these factors allow Black to force a win. How?



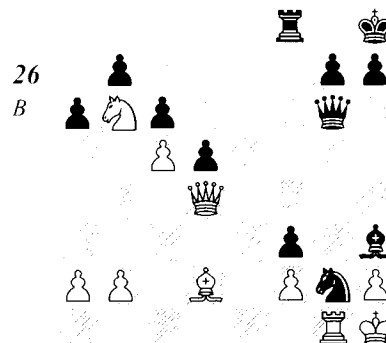
To do the white king serious damage, Black needs to get more pieces involved in the attack. In such cases it is always worth considering which pieces are playing a part in the game, and which are not. Thinking along these lines, Black found a strong move. What was it?



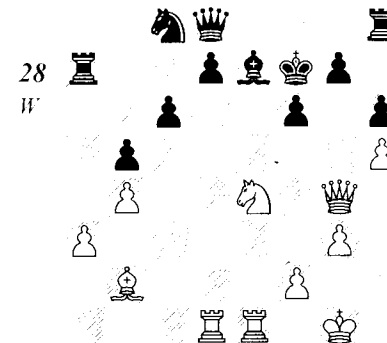
White has just played 33 $\text{f}c1$, which is actually a blunder that Black failed to exploit. How can Black win a piece and with it the game?



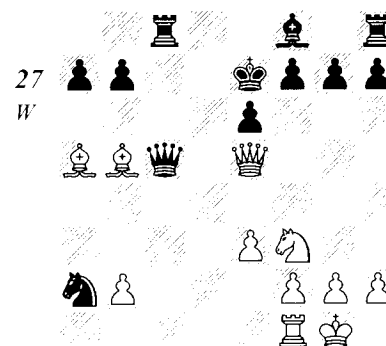
If it were Black to move here, then he would free his position with 19...f5. when his king would feel a lot safer. White found a clever way to stop this. What did he play and what was the follow-up?



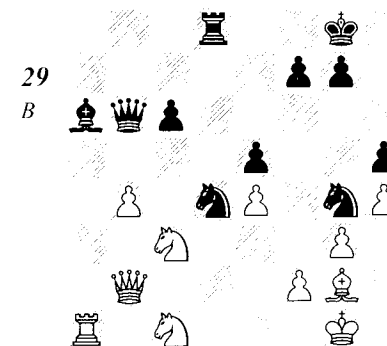
How can Black win the exchange and with it the game?



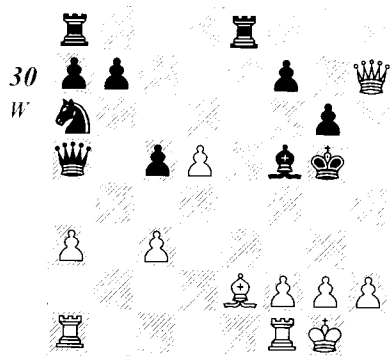
Black has seriously weakened his kingside with the moves ...f6 and ...h6. After these two moves White always has g6 as an entry point for his queen. How should White continue? Analyse as deeply as possible.



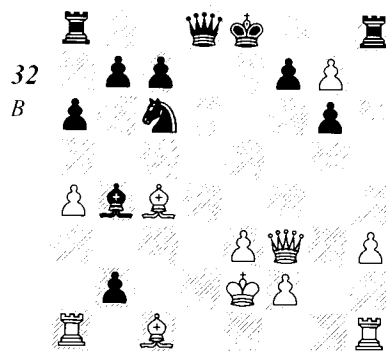
White has to do something rather urgent in this position before Black can consolidate and convert his extra material. What should White play? Analyse until you have reached a verdict on the position.



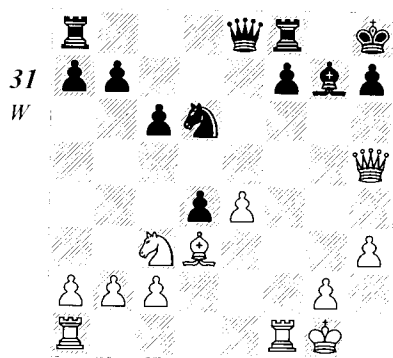
Black's pieces stand on much better squares compared to White's. If we look deeper into the position it is clear that White also has a big weakness on f2. What should Black play?



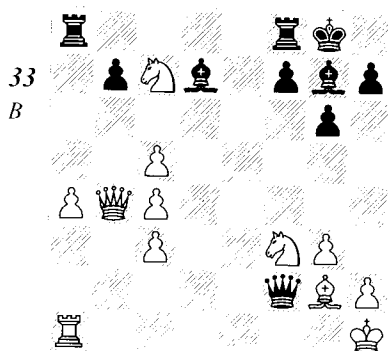
Black's king is wandering around in no man's land. Given a chance though it will start running back to its first rank with ...♔f6. What should White do to stop this and how should the game continue with best defence from Black?



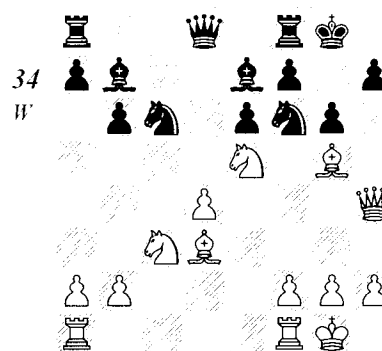
It looks like Black is in dire straits as mate is threatened on f7 and the h8-rook is also *en prise*. Yet Black found an amazing resource that he had probably planned in advance. What was that resource?



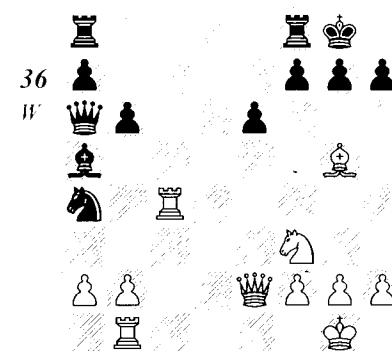
White would like to play 19 e5, threatening mate on h7, but this is met by 19...f5, which stops the mate. What shocking move did White play that gave him a decisive advantage?



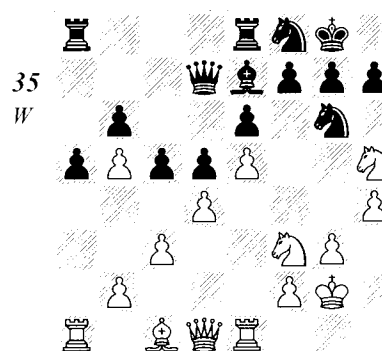
Black would like to play 24...♙h3 here but White can answer this with 25 ♙xh3 ♜xf3+ 26 ♙g2, when he holds the advantage. How can Black refine this idea?



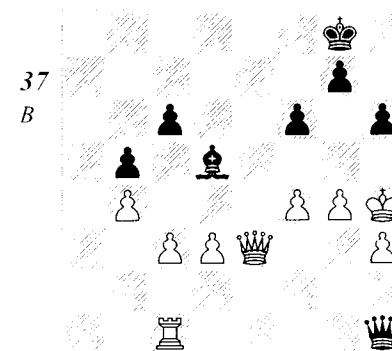
This position looks quite tame upon first glance. The mist will only clear upon further inspection. Black's position is under considerable pressure, the pin on the d8-h4 diagonal being a major pain for Black. What is White's best move and how should the game finish?



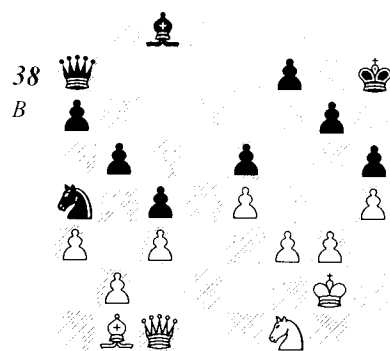
Black's pieces are sidelined over on the queenside, which leaves the black king with a serious lack of protection. How did White take advantage of this and start a mating attack?



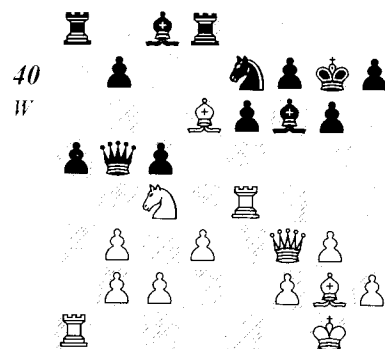
White has been making gradual progress on the kingside for a while, but it is not clear how he can break through Black's defences. Yet Kasparov is playing White and if there is a strong move Kasparov will find it! What did he play?



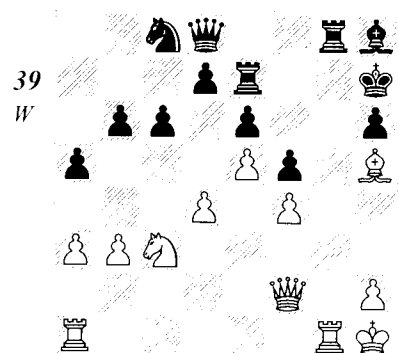
White's king is on a walk of death. How can Black force mate through the use of an attractive forcing line?



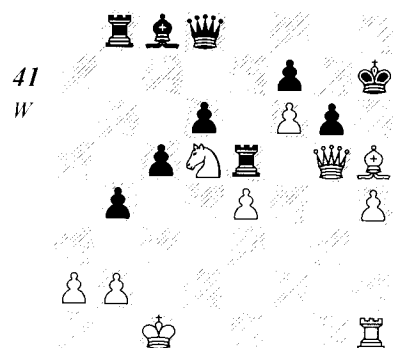
The position looks rather dull, but that is when both sides have to be the most alert, as a false sense of security is many a player's downfall. What should Black play?



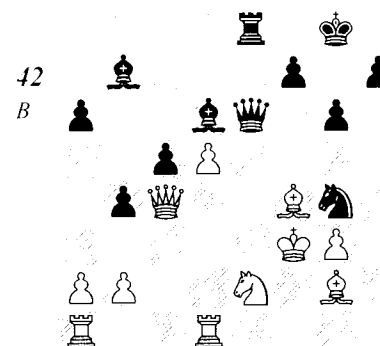
Black's position looks OK, but under closer inspection it is clear it is held up almost single-handedly by his f6-bishop, which guards all the dark squares near his king. How did White undermine this to produce a stunning finish? Analyse until the end.



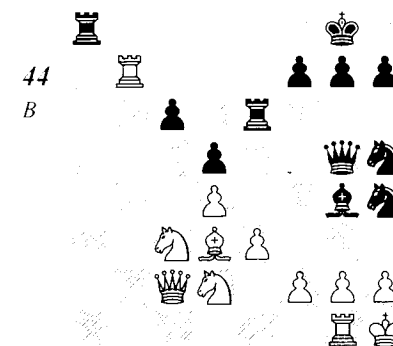
White's pieces are all functioning nicely except the knight on c3. What should White play and how should the game continue?



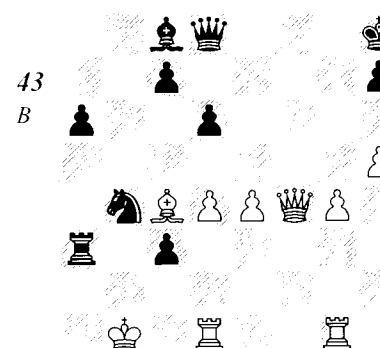
At first glance it looks like White has to retreat his queen and therefore lose all of his attacking chances, but White had another idea. What was it?



Black has sacrificed a rook to reach this position. In exchange for the rook, White's king is seriously exposed. Black has two ways to win this position, one more elegant than the other. Can you spot either of the ways that Black can win?



Black has a powerful presence of pieces congregating around White's king. On top of this there is only one white piece defending the king, the g1-rook. How did Black crash through the white lines with an amazing move?



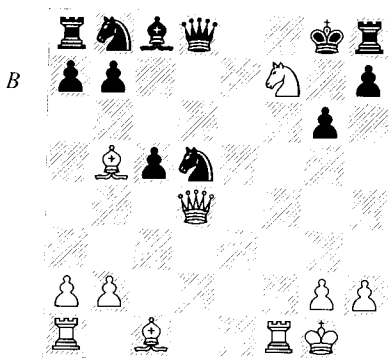
Black's position looks very dangerous but without the black queen taking part in the attack it will be tricky to deliver checkmate. How did Black brilliantly conclude his attack?

Solutions

- 1) **Lechtynsky – Kubicek**
Prague 1968
1 ♖xg7+! ♜xg7 2 ♜h6# (1-0)

- 2) **Krasenkow – Karpov**
Wijk aan Zee 2003
29...♗e1! 0-1
This wins on the spot. White resigned in view of 30 ♖g2 (30 ♗xe1 ♖xf3#) 30...♗xf1 31 ♖xf1 ♖xf3+ –+.

- 3) **Boguslavsky – Lepin**
Moscow 1989
17 ♖xd4! (D)

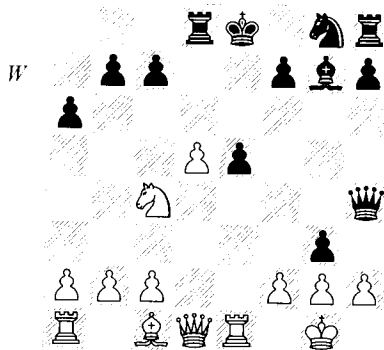


As Black is so behind in development, a move such as this should not come as a real shock.

17...cxd4 18 ♜h6+ ♖g7 19 ♗f7#

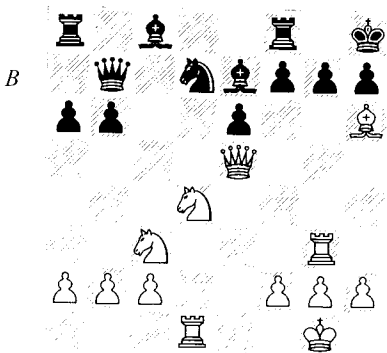
- 4) **Viakhirev – Alekhine**
corr. 1908
35...♖g2+! 36 ♗xg2 fxg2#

- 5) **Korchnoi – Portisch**
Wijk aan Zee 1968
13...♙xd5 14 exd5 g3! (D)



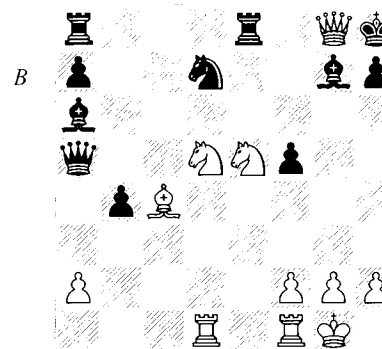
Suddenly the c4-knight is *en prise* as well as the f2-pawn, so White must lose a piece and with it the game.

- 6) **Bronstein – Kotov**
Moscow Ch 1946
21 ♙h6! (D) 1-0



This wins on the spot. Black resigned due to 21...♜xe5 22 ♙xg7+ ♖g8 23 ♙xe5+ ♙g5 24 ♗xg5#.

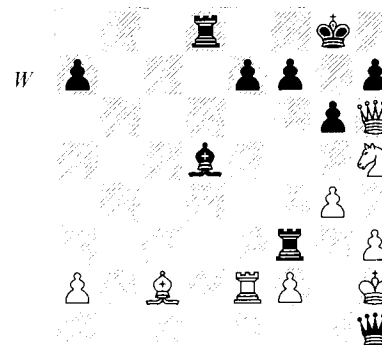
- 7) **Podzerov – Kunstowicz**
corr. 1970
1 ♖g8+! (D)



A combination along the lines of smothered mate.

- 1...♖xg8
1...♗xg8 2 ♜f7#.
2 ♜e7++ ♖f8
2...♖h8 3 ♜f7#.
3 ♜7g6+! hxg6 4 ♜xg6#

- 8) **Krstev – Tringov**
Skopje 1961
1...♖h1+! (D)



- 2 ♖xh1 ♗xh3++

From d5 the bishop dominates all parts of the board.

- 3 ♖g1 ♗h1#

- 9) **Janowski – Sämisch**
Marienbad 1925

- 20 ♖h6! 1-0

Opening the g-file for the h3-rook (20...gxh6 21 ♗g3#) or forcing mate on h7 or g7.

- 10) **O. Bernstein – Capablanca**
Moscow 1914

- 29...♖b2! 0-1

This move forces immediate resignation. 30 ♖xb2 ♗d1#; 30 ♖e1 ♖xc3 31 ♖xc3 ♗d1+ 32 ♖e1 ♗xe1#.

- 11) **Petrosian – Spassky**
Moscow Wch (10) 1966

- 30 ♖h8+! 1-0

This wins a whole piece: 30...♖xh8 31 ♜xf7+ ♖g7 32 ♜xg5.

- 12) **Piotrovsky – Tenenbaum**
Lvov 1926

- 1 ♖h8+!

This striking move forces the promotion of the white g-pawn, and with it checkmate.

- 1...♖xh8 2 g7+ ♖g8 3 ♙h7+! ♖xh7 4 g8♖#

- 13) **Eliskases – Hölzl**
Austria 1931

- 1 ♗d5!

A nice move that interferes with Black's coordination.

1...♖xd5

Or: 1...♖xd5 2 ♖f8#; 1...exd5 2 ♖xd8#; 1...♙xd5 2 ♖xd8#.

2 ♖f6#

14) Nimzowitsch – Hoffer

Nuremberg 1904

Question 1: 1...gxf6?? 2 ♖g4! +-. White forces mate next move, as Black can't stop ♖h6#.

Question 2: 1...gxf6! is the best way to defend as after 2 ♖g4 ♖xf2! Black stops mate on f6 and is close to winning.

15) Shirov – Motylev

Moscow FIDE blitz 2001

13 ♖xb2! 1-0

This diverts the queen away from its defensive duties. Black resigned due to 13...♖xb2 (13...♖xa6 14 ♖xb8+ and mate next move) 14 ♖c6+ ♙d8 15 ♖xf7#.

16) Anand – Shirov

Frankfurt rpd 2000

28 ♙f8! 1-0

A third white piece enters the attack with devastating effect. Black resigned in view of 28...♖xf8 29 ♖g7# and 28...♖xf8 29 ♖f6 ♖g7 30 ♖xf8+ ♖g8 31 ♖xg8#.

17) Cserna – Ozsvath

Hungary 1979

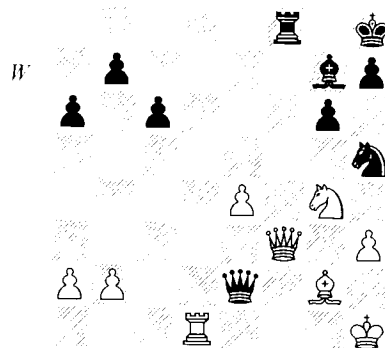
1...♖xf2!

Very nice, vacating the g3-square for Black's h5-knight.

2 ♖xf3

The only move to keep White in the game. Other moves: 2 ♖xf2 ♖g3#; 2 ♙xf3 ♖g3#.

2...♖xe2! (D)



Again using the power of the black knights.

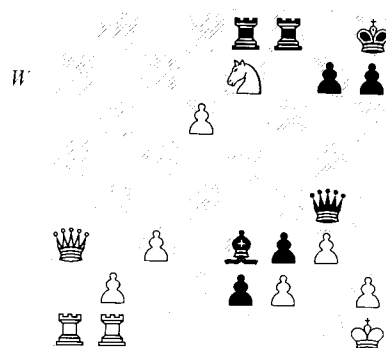
3 ♖xe2 ♖g3+ 4 ♙h2 ♖xe2 +

With the moves ...h5 and ...♙e5+ to come, White's position is unenviable.

18) Diani – Toro Solis

corr. 1992

40...♙e3! (D) 0-1



White resigned in view of 41 ♙g1 ♖h3 and 41 fxe3 f2.

19) Mi. Tseitlin – Osipov

corr. 1978

23 ♙b5! 1-0

This move has two functions: it clears a line for the white queen and it also interferes with the black pieces. In some lines the c5-square is now available for the white queen. Some possible variations:

a) 23...♖xb5 24 ♖d6+ ♙f6 (alternatively, 24...♙e8 25 ♖h8#) 25 ♖h6+ ♙g7 26 ♖e7! +-.

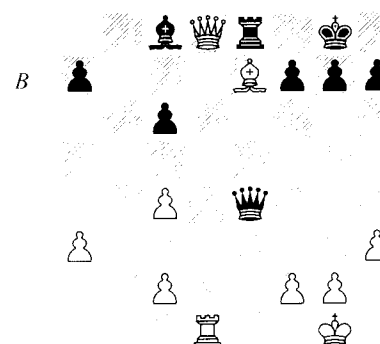
b) 23...♖c7 24 ♖g7 (or 24 ♖b4+) 24...♙e8 (24...♖f8 25 ♖xd7+ +-) 25 ♖g5+ ♙f8 26 ♖h8#.

c) 23...♙xb5 24 ♖c5+ ♙f6 (or 24...♙e8 25 ♖h8#) 25 ♖h6+ ♙g7 26 ♖g1+! ♙f8 (26...♙xh6 27 ♖g5+ ♙h7 28 ♖h1#) 27 ♖h8+ ♙e7 28 ♖g5+ f6 29 ♖g7#.

20) Tartakower – Billicard

Ostend 1907

27 ♙e7! (D) 1-0



A nice example of interference. For example, 27...♖xe7 28 ♖xe7 ♖xe7 29 ♖d8+ ♖e8 30 ♖xe8# or 27...♙d7 28 ♖xd7 ♖e1+ 29 ♙h2 ♖e5+ 30 g3 +-.

21) Tikhonov – Tzoumbas

Rimavska Sobota U-14 Ech 1992

25...♖c2!

Highlighting the lack of coordination in White's camp.

26 ♖d4

Or: 26 ♖fd1 ♖f1+ -+; 26 ♖xc2 ♖xf1+ 27 ♖xf1 ♖xf1+ 28 ♙xf1 ♖xe3+ 29 ♙g1 ♖xc2 -+.

26...♖xf1+ 27 ♖xf1 ♖xe2 0-1

22) Letelier – Fischer

Leipzig OL 1960

23...♖xf4+! 0-1

White resigned due to the following lines: 24 ♙xf4 ♙h6#; 24 ♙d3 ♖xf3+ -+; 24 ♙e2 ♖d4+; 24 ♙f2 ♖g4+ 25 ♙g2 ♖e3+ 26 ♙f2 ♖d4 27 ♖h1 ♖g4+ -+.

23) Graf – Mainka

Dresden 2001

33...♖b4!

Exploiting White's weak back rank and picking up the b6-knight; for example, 34 ♖xb4 ♖e1+ 35 ♖xe1 ♖xe1# or 34 ♖d7+ ♙a7 35 ♖f1 ♖xb1 36 ♖xb1 ♖e1+, mating.

24) Menadue – N. Pert

British Ch (Swansea) 1995

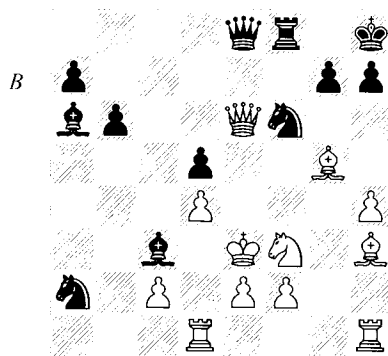
18...♙b4!

Maximizing the potential of the black pieces.

19 ♖h3

19 ♖xe8 ♕xc3+ 20 ♖e3 ♘g4# and all the black pieces have arrived on time.

19...♕xc3+ 20 ♖e3 (D)



Come to daddy!

20...♘b4!

The knight has done its job on a2 of cutting off the white king's retreat to the queenside. Now it pursues the white king to its death.

21 ♖xe8?

Better, though still hopeless for White, is 21 ♖c1 ♖xe6+ 22 ♕xe6 ♖e8.

21...♘g4+! 0-1

White resigned due to 22 ♕xg4 ♘xc2#.

25) Tal – Leonov
Riga jr 1949

19 ♖f6!

Fischer played a very similar idea 14 years later, as we shall see. The white rook cramps Black's position and stops any freeing moves.

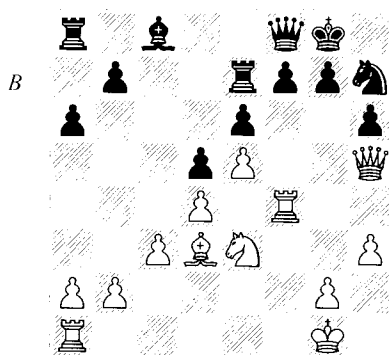
19...♖f8

Others:

a) 19...gxf6 20 ♕xh7+ ♖xh7 21 ♘g4 ♖f8 22 ♖f1 f5 23 ♘f6+ ♖h8 24 ♖f3 +–.

b) 19...♘xf6 20 exf6 gxf6 21 ♖xh6 f5 22 ♘g4! +–.

20 ♖f4 +– (D)



Black's queen is now misplaced on f8. Before, when it was on e8, it could offer an exchange of queens after ...f5.

The game finished:

20...♕d7 21 ♘g4

Another piece slides towards the black king.

21...♕e8 22 ♘f6+! ♘xf6 23 exf6 ♖c7 24 fxg7 ♖xg7 25 ♖e5+ 1-0

26) Vygodchikov – Alekhine
corr. 1909

28...♘f4!

White's position is now hopeless.

29 ♖xg6 ♕g2+ 30 ♖xg2

30 ♖g1 ♘e2#.

30...fxg2+ 31 ♖g1 ♘e2+ 32 ♖xg2 ♘xd4 0-1

27) Touset – Hidalgo
Spain 1989

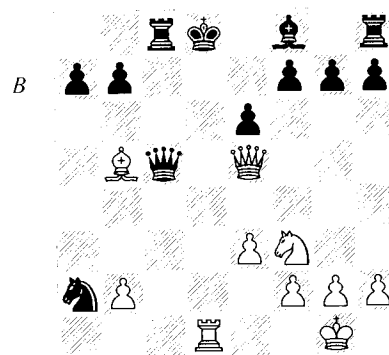
1 ♕d8+!!

This bolt from the blue puts Black on the defensive.

1...♖xd8

1...♖xd8?? 2 ♖xc5+ +–.

2 ♕d1+ (D)



2...♕d6

2...♖e7 is not a very attractive possibility for Black but gives better chances than the text-move: 3 ♕d7+ ♖e8 4 ♖xb7+ (the rook does a good job of mopping up the black pawns) 4...♕d8 5 ♕d7+ ♖e8 6 ♖xa7+ ♕d8 7 ♕d7+ ♖e8 8 ♖c7+ +– and the win is quite simple.

3 ♖xd6+ ♖e7 4 ♕d7+

Another way to force mate is 4 ♖xe6+! ♕d8 (4...fxe6 5 ♖xg7+ ♕d6 6 ♖d7#) 5 ♕d6+ ♖c7 6 ♖c6+ ♕d8 7 ♖xc5 ♖xc5 8 ♕d6+ ♖c8 9 ♕d7+ ♕d8 10 ♕e6+ ♖e8 11 ♕d7+ ♖f8 12 ♖xf7#. It's always nice to have a choice of two ways to mate your opponent!

4...♖f8 5 ♖xf7+! ♖xf7 6 ♘g5+ ♖g6 7 ♕d3+ ♖h5 8 g4+ ♖h4 8...♖xg4 9 ♕e2+ ♖h4 10 ♖g3#. 9 ♘f3+ ♖xg4 10 ♖f4+ ♖h5 11 ♖h4#

28) Kasparov – Andersson
Tilburg 1981

24 ♘xf6! gxf6

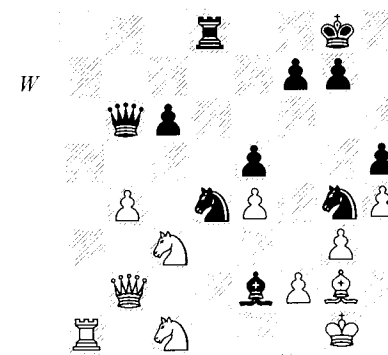
24...♕xf6 25 ♖g6+ ♖f8 26 ♕xf6 gxf6 27 ♖e6! +–.

25 ♖g6+ ♖f8 26 ♕c1! d5 27 ♖d4 ♘d6 28 ♖g4 ♘f7 29 ♕xh6+! ♖e8

Or: 29...♖xh6 30 ♖g8#; 29...♘xh6 30 ♖g7+ ♖e8 31 ♖xh8+ ♕d7 32 ♖xh6 +–.

30 ♕g7 +–

29) Levitt – A. Martin
British Ch (Plymouth) 1992
26...♕e2! (D) 0-1

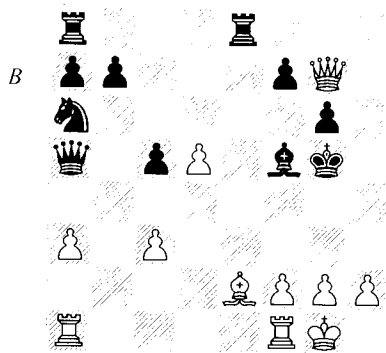


Blocking the white queen's defence of the f2-pawn. White resigned in view of 27 ♘1xe2 ♘f3+! 28 ♕xf3 (28 ♖h1 ♘xf2#; 28 ♖f1 ♘gh2#) 28...♖xf2+ 29 ♖h1 ♖h2#.

30) Smyslov – Florian

Moscow – Budapest 1949

19 ♖g7!! (D)

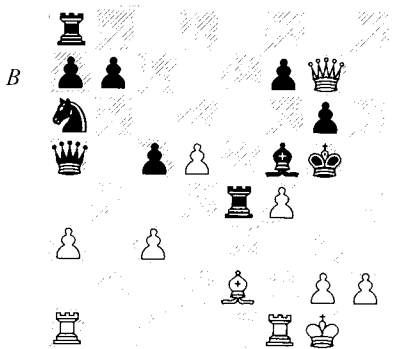


Quiet moves are the most difficult to find as they do not follow the 'check or capture' rule. This move is logical since now Black's king will be hunted down in the middle of the board.

19...♗e4

Trying to stop White playing f4. Black's other options are no better; for example, 19...♗xe2 20 f4+ ♖g4 21 h3+ ♖h4 22 ♖h6+ ♖g3 23 ♗f3#.

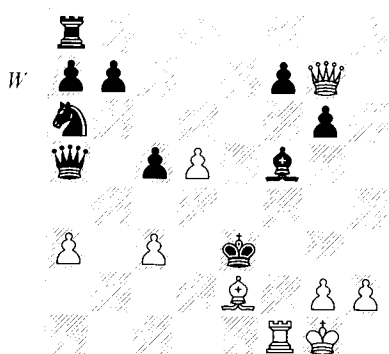
20 f4+! (D)



White plays f4 anyway!

20...♗xf4 21 ♗xf4 ♖xf4 22 ♗f1+ ♖e3 (D)

Or: 22...♖g5 23 h4+ ♖xh4 24 ♖h6+ ♖g3 25 ♖h2#; 22...♖e4 23 ♖c4! and White forces mate.



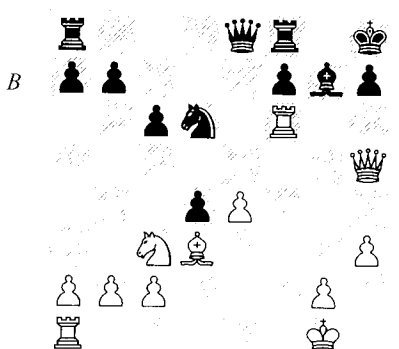
23 ♖e5+ ♖d2 24 ♖c4 ♖xa3 25 ♗f2+ 1-0

Black did not wish to see 25...♖d1 26 ♖e2+ ♖c1 27 ♖e1#.

31) Fischer – Benko

US Ch (New York) 1963/4

19 ♗f6!! (D)



This move blocks the f-pawn and therefore is quite logical.

19...♖g8

Or: 19...♖xf6 20 e5 h6 21 ♖xh6+ ♖g8 22 ♖h7#; 19...dxc3 20 e5 h6 21 ♗xh6+ ♖g8 22 ♗h8+ ♖xh8 23 ♖h7#.

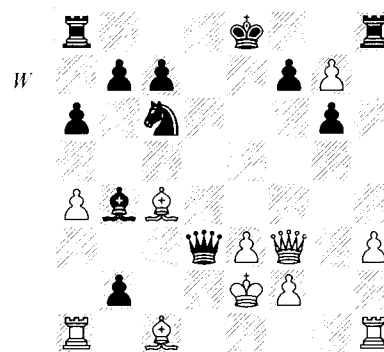
20 e5 h6 21 ♖e2! 1-0

Black's kingside is about to fall apart.

32) Novikov – Nikolaev

Kharlov 1968

16...♖d3+!! (D)



White resigned immediately because of 25 ♗xa4 ♖h3! 26 ♖xh3 (26 ♖h4 ♖e1+ 27 ♖f1 ♖xf1#) 26...♖xf3+ 27 ♖g1 (27 ♖g2 is unplayable because of 27...♖d1+ 28 ♖f1 ♖xf1#) 27...♖xc3 +- and White either loses his queen or gets mated after ...♖d4+.

34) Plaskett – K. Arkell

London (WFW) 1991

14 ♖a6!

This idea had appeared in many encounters from similar positions. White undermines the c6-knight and in the process the e7-bishop.

14...h6

Or: 14...♖xe5 15 dxe5 ♖xa6 16 exf6 +-; 14...♖xa6 15 ♖xc6 ♖d6 16 ♖xe7+ ♖xe7 17 ♖xf6 +-.

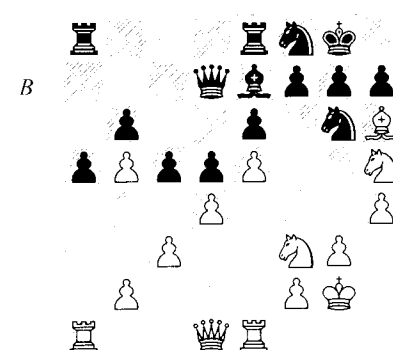
15 ♖xh6 ♖d5 16 ♖h3 ♖xc3 17 ♖xb7 ♖e2+ 18 ♖h1 ♖cxd4 19 ♖xf8 ♖xf8 20 ♖xa8 ♖xa8 +-

Black resigned on move 24.

35) Kasparov – Short

Zurich rpd 2001

18 ♖h6!! (D)



This amazing idea either deflects the bishop or enables Black to castle queenside with check.

17 ♖xd3

17 ♖xd3? 0-0-0+ 18 ♖e2 bxa1 ♖x1.

17...bxa1 ♖ 18 gxf8 ♖+ ♖xh8 ♖

The complications have ended with Black a pawn up. He duly went on to win.

33) Lputian – Ivanchuk

Montecatini Terme 2000

24...♗xa4! 0-1

I would have liked to have seen Nigel's face here!

18...gxh6

Forced; otherwise White captures on g7 with a winning position.

19 ♖d2

The attack is successful because Black is so cramped on the kingside and cannot organize a successful defence.

19...f5

Again the only move. Black's queen needs to cover g7.

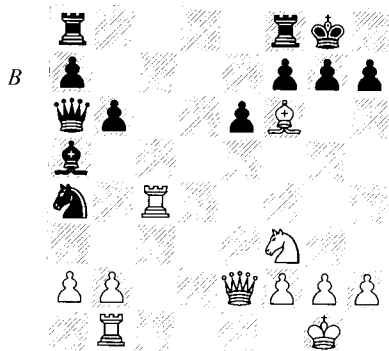
20 exf6 ♕d8 21 ♖xh6 ♖a7 22 ♖g5 ♖xb5 23 f7+ ♖xf7 24 ♖xf7 1-0

It is mate after 24...♗xf7 25 ♖g7#.

36) Alekhine – Sterk

Budapest 1921

23 ♕f6!! (D)



Opening the kingside up; I expect that this came as rather an unpleasant blow for Black. White is using the pin on his rook to his own advantage. The threat is 24 ♖g4 ♖xe2 25 ♖xg7+ ♖h8 26 ♖g6#.

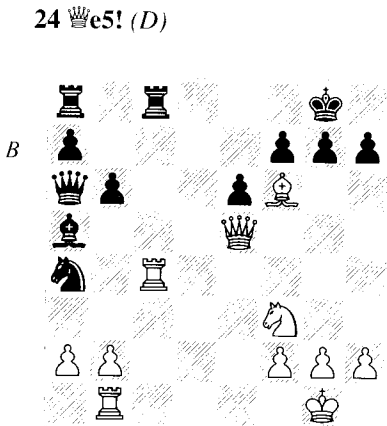
23...♖fe8

The only attempt at defence. Other lines:

a) 23...h5 24 ♖g4 ♖xe2 25 ♖xg7+ ♖h8 26 ♖g5! +- and Black cannot stop mate on h8.

b) 23...h6 24 ♖e5! +-. Next move White will bring his queen over to the kingside with a mating attack.

c) 23...gxf6 24 ♖g4+ ♖h8 25 ♖xa6 +-.
24 ♖e5! (D)



The white queen longs for the g5-square.

24...♖c5

Others:

a) 24...gxf6 25 ♖g4+ ♖f8 (25...♖h8 26 ♖xf6#) 26 ♖d6+ ♖e8 27 ♖g8#.

b) 24...♖xc4 25 ♖g5 ♖g4 (25...g6 26 ♖h6 +-) 26 ♖xg4 g6 27 ♖xa4 +-.
c) 24...♖xc4 25 ♖g5 ♖f8 26 ♖xg7+ ♖e8 27 ♖g8+ ♖d7 28 ♖e5+ ♖c7 (28...♖d6 29 ♖xc4+ also wins) 29 ♖xf7+ ♖b8 30 ♖xc4 +-.

25 ♖g3 +- g6 26 ♖xa4 ♖d3 27 ♖f1 ♖f5 28 ♖f4 ♖c2 29 ♖h6 1-0

37) Pascual Perez – Cruz-Lima

Cuba 1993

1...g5+ 2 fxg5 hxg5+!

2...fxg5+? 3 ♖h5 ♖xh3+? 4 ♖xh3 ♖g7 5 ♖f1 would have spoiled any illusions of greatness.

3 ♖h5 ♖xh3+!!

A picturesque finish.

4 ♖xh3 ♖g7 0-1

...♕f7# is next!

38) Mesierina – Umanskaya

Russia 1992

1...♕h3+!

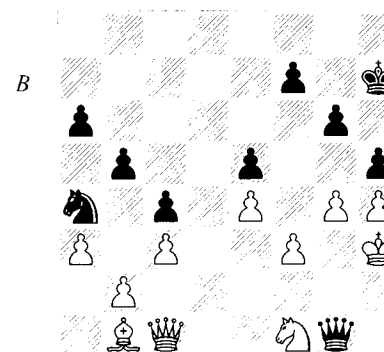
So the black queen can enter deep into White's position.

2 ♖xh3 ♖g1

...♖h1# is the big threat.

3 g4 (D)

Or: 3 ♖d2 ♖xf1+ 4 ♖h2 ♖xb1 +-; 3 ♖c2 ♖xf1+ 4 ♖h2 ♖xf3 +-.
3...♕e5!!



3...♕e5!!

A very difficult move to spot as the knight appears irrelevant. The threat is now ...♖e6 followed by ...♖f4+, which White is powerless to prevent.

4 gxh5

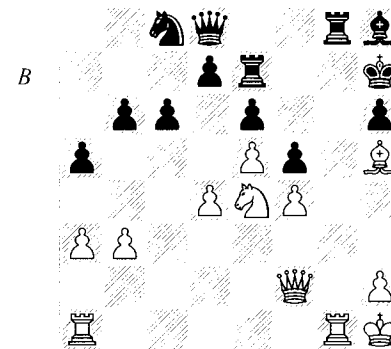
4 ♖e3 ♖xf1+ 5 ♖g3 ♖e6 6 ♕c2 ♖f4 +-.
4...♖e6 5 hxg6+ fxg6 0-1

...♖f4+ is next.

39) Kasparov – Yusupov

USSR Ch (Frunze) 1981

31 ♖e4!! (D)



A positional sacrifice: White wants to employ his f-pawn as a battering-ram.

31...fxe4

Black has to accept the sacrifice, since otherwise the knight will jump into f6.

32 f5

The white f-pawn is the key to the position.

32...♖g5 33 ♖xg5 hxg5 34 f6 +- ♖h6 35 fxe7 ♖xe7 36 ♖f7 d6 37 ♖f1 g4 38 ♖xe6 ♖xe6 39 ♖h4+ ♖g7 1-0

40) Petrosian – Pachman

Bled 1961

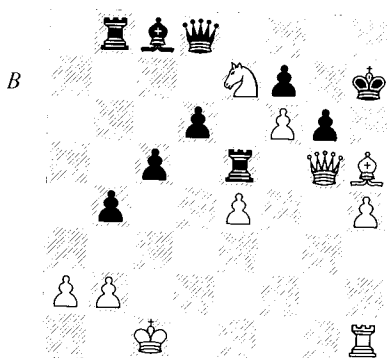
19 ♖xf6+!!

At the cost of a queen, White brings Black's king into the open and takes over the dark squares.

19...xf6 20 e5+ g5 21 g7! 1-0

A similar theme to puzzle 30 (Smyslov-Florian): Black's king can't retreat due to White's dominant bishop on g7. Black resigned since he cannot stop mate.

41) Rivas – Mestel
Marbella Z 1982
26 e7! (D)



Stopping the black king from ever retreating to g8.

26...g8

Desperation, but other moves lose as well; for example:

a) 26...xg5 27 hxg5 xe7 (the only way to stop mate; 27...gxh5 28 fxe7 d7 (28...e6 29 d1+ g7 30 e4 +-)) 29 e4+ and White wins.

b) 26...f8 leads to a beautiful win for White after 27 xg6+ h8 (or

27...fxg6 28 h5! +-) 28 f5 xf5 29 exf5 h7 30 g8! +-.

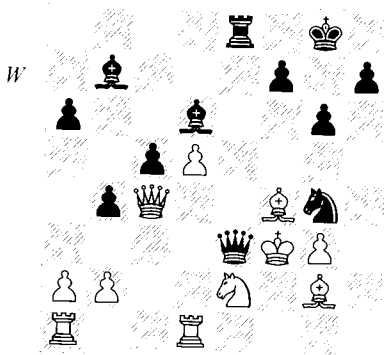
27 d1 h8

27...xe7 28 h5 +-.

28 h6+ 1-0

42) Cifuentes – Zviagintsev
Wijk aan Zee 1995
31...e3+! (D)

This was the move chosen in the game. 31...xf4! is also winning; for example, 32 xf4 h2+ 33 f2 e3# or 32 gxf4 e3+ 33 xg4 c8+ 34 f5 xf5+ 35 h4 f2+ 36 g3 e3 +-.



32 e3

32 xg4 c8+ 33 g5 e5+ 34 h6 f8#.

32...xe3+ 33 xg4 c8+ 34 g5

34 h4 c7#.

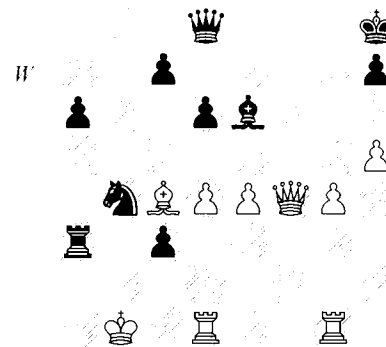
34...h6+

Bringing the white king deeper into Black's territory.

35 xh6 e5! 0-1

White can't stop both 36...f8# and 36...h5#.

43) Bagirov – Gufeld
Kirovabad 1973
25...e6!! (D)



Sacrificing a piece so that the black queen can enter the attack via b8.

26 xe6 d3! 27 f7

White's best try. 27 fxd3 fails after 27...b8+ 28 c2 b2+ 29 d1 a1+ 30 c1 xc1#.

27...b8+ 28 b3

28 c2 b2+ (28...b4+ is also winning: 29 b1 a1+! 30 xal c2+ 31 a2 b2#) 29 xd3 c2+.

28...xb3+ 29 c2 b4+! 30 xb3

Black has only left himself with a queen, knight and pawn to mate the white king, but they work perfectly together. 30 c1 b1+ 31 xbl d5+ 32 c2 transposes to the game.

30...d5+! 31 c2

Others: 31 c4 b5#: 31 a4 b4#; 31 a2 b2#.

31...b2+ 32 d3 b5+ 0-1

It is mate after 33 c2 e2+ 34 b3 b2+ 35 c4 b5#.

44) Scharapov – Retinsky
Ukraine 1995
1...xe3!!

This truly spectacular queen sacrifice gives Black a decisive advantage.

2 g6

Black holds the advantage in all lines:

a) 2 fxe3 g3+! 3 hxg3 h6! (mate is unstoppable) 4 gxh4 (4 gb1 f3#) 4...hxh4#.

b) 2 xh7+ h8 3 xf7 xf2!! 4 xf2 g3+ 5 hxg3 h6 +- with mate soon.

c) 2 d1 h6 +.

d) 2 e4! is White's best attempt, and sets a vicious trap for Black:

d1) 2...dxe4? 3 a2! f8? (the alternative is 3...d3+ 4 hxg3 g6 5 xa8+ f8 6 f1 h6+ 7 gl exd3 ±) 4 fxe3 g3+ 5 hxg3 h6 6 xf7+! (with this move the tide changes and it is White who is winning) 6...xf7 7 b8+ f8 8 c4+ e6 9 e6+ xe6 10 xf8+ xf8 11 gxh4 +-.

d2) 2...xd4 +.

d3) 2...f5!? is a very interesting continuation.

d4) 2...h6! is Black's best move, when White's king is still under serious threat.

2...xf2 3 xf7+

3 xf7 xg6 4 xf2 g3+! 5 hxg3 h6 +-.

3...xf7!! 4 xf7 g3+! 5 hxg3 h6 0-1

Mate is imminent.

- Paschitta 25
 Pascual Perez **155**
 Pavlović, M. **123**
 Pelaez **123**
 Pelletier **79**
 Penrose 44, 54, **71**
 Pert, N. **58**, 98, 149
 Pert, R. 125
 Petersons 19
 Petroff **21**, 29
 Petrosian 46, **147**, **155**
 Pichon 101
 Piket 51
 Pillsbury **48**
 Piotrovsky **147**
 Pirrot **97**
 Plaskett **80**, **153**
 Podzerov **147**
 Polgar, J. **51**, **99**, **100**, **128**
 Portisch 146
 Potaux 69
 Potemkin **96**
 Pritchett 47
 Puskeits 81
 Ranker 119
 Ratner 48
 Rayner, F. **72**
 Repp **25**
 Reshevsky 120
 Réti **20**
 Retinsky 157
 Ristić **46**
 Rivas **156**
 Rodriguez, An. 52
 Rolf 53
 Romero, M. 21
 Rosenberg 119
 Rovner 53
 Rubinstein 55, 100, **130**
 Ruiz **21**
 Russell 97
 Saint-Amant **48**
 Sämisch 104, 147
 Santos 56
 Saravanan 76
 Sax 19, **96**
 Scharapov **157**
 Scherbakov, R. 75
 Seirawan 20, **25**, 77
 Shabalov 102
 Shagalovich 97
 Shirov **19**, 21, **24**, **44**, 51, **119**, **127**, **148**, 148
 Short **20**, 96, **122**, 153
 Shrenzel 120
 Skuya **119**
 Smirin 97
 Smyslov 103, **152**
 Solodovnichenko 48
 Sorial 45
 Souleidis 47
 Spassky 100, 147
 Spoelman **126**
 Staunton **99**
 Stefanovski 47
 Stellwagen 126
 Sterk 154
 Stoppa **49**
 Storoshenko 20
 Suba **19**
 Subin 101
 Suetin 74
 Sulskis **28**
 Sundararajan **76**
 Sutovsky **72**, **97**
 Svidler **8**, **75**, 127
 Szymanski 21
 Tal **21**, **46**, 51, **79**, **103**, **150**
 Tarrasch 48
 Tartakower 20, 21, **149**
 Tatai **79**
 Tebb **129**
 Teichmann 130
 Teller **21**
 Tenenbaum 147
 Thomas 47
 Thompson, J. 119
 Thorhallsson 76
 Tikhonov **149**
 Timman **44**
 Topalov **104**
 Toro Solis 148
 Touset **151**
 Treybal **44**
 Tringov 21, 147
 Tseitlin, Mi. **149**
 Turuk 69
 Tzoumbas 149
 Umanskaya 155
 Urban **69**
 Vaganian **51**
 Vaissier 22
 Vallejo Pons **46**
 Van Mindeno 129
 Van Wely 24, 44, 46, **51**, **56**, 128
 Vasić **121**
 Veinger 123
 Velička **47**
 Velikov 122
 Vera 98
 Vetemaa **102**
 Viakhirev **146**
 Vogel **28**
 Volkov 69
 Vygodchikov **150**
 Wagman **27**
 Wahls **98**
 Ward 122, 129
 Wells 46, **50**
 West 20
 Williams, L. 127
 Williams, S. 72, **101**, **103** (2), **121**
 Wilson, J. **24**
 Wirthensohn **71**
 Wohl, A. 121
 Xie Jun **71**
 Yanofsky **23**
 Yusupov 84, 155
 Zaitsev, I. **20**
 Zapata **52**
 Zargouni 130
 Zarnicki **98**
 Ždanovs **22**
 Zeziulkina **83**
 Zhao Zong Yuan 103
 Zhukova 52, 71
 Zilbershtein 20
 Züger **74**
 Zviagintsev 156